

Arabic, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Arabic set in
Noto Naskh Arabic (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Arabic one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Arabic letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, right-to-left, so you learn to read سلام *and* learn that it means “peace” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Arabic simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Arabic changes the etymology game entirely. The Romance and Germanic volumes trace words back to Latin or Germanic roots; Arabic doesn’t need tracing — its roots are on the *surface*. Nearly every Arabic word is built from a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed patterns, so *peace*, *Islam*, *Muslim*, and the greeting *salaam* are visibly one family (s-l-m), the way this book wishes Latin were. That root system is taught as the organizing engine. A recurring thread is Arabic’s long shadow over **Spanish**, another language in this project: the article *al-* smuggled into English *algebra* and *alcohol*, and the sun-letter assimilation still audible in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*) — every such form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of Spanish is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Arabic out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings	1
1.1 salām	1
1.2 sīn, lām	2
1.3 alif, mīm — salām	3
1.4 marḥaban	4
1.5 rā ³ , ḥā ³	5
1.6 bā ³ , tā ³ , thā ³ — marḥaban	6
1.7 ال	7
1.8 as-salāmu ^c alaykum	8
1.9 ^c ayn, yā ³	9
1.10 kāf, wāw — as-salāmu ^c alaykum	9
1.11 as-salāmu ^c alaykum	10
1.12 الخير صباح	11
1.13 الخير مساء	12
1.14 شكرا	13
1.15 Practice	14
2 Introducing Yourself	17
2.1 اسم	17
2.2 ي	18
2.3 اسمي	19
2.4 أنت	19
2.5 ما	20
2.6 اسمك؟ ما	21
2.7 تشرفنا	22
2.8 Practice	23
2.9 nūn, tā ³ , thā ³	24

2.10	yā [◌]	25
2.11	fathā, kasra, ḍamma; hamza	27
2.12	sukūn, shadda, fathatan	28
2.13	hamza	29
3	How Are You?	31
3.1	ḥā [◌] , khā [◌] , jīm	31
3.2	kāf, rā	33
3.3	khayr, bi-khayr	34
3.4	kayfa	35
3.5	ḥāl	37
3.6	kayfa ḥāluka / kayfa ḥāluki	38
3.7	bi-khayr	39
3.8	al-ḥamdu lillāh	41
3.9	Practice	43
4	Farewells	45
4.1	ʿayn	45
4.2	hā [◌] , tā [◌] marbūṭa	47
4.3	ma ^ʿ a s-salāma	48
4.4	ma ^ʿ a	50
4.5	as-salāma	51
4.6	ma ^ʿ a s-salāma	53
4.7	ilā l-liqā [◌]	54
4.8	Practice	56
5	Yes and No	59
5.1	نعم	59
5.2	لا	60
6	Please	63
6.1	فضلك من	63
7	Sorry	65
7.1	آسفة / آسف	65
8	Days of the Week	67
8.1	الخميس الأربعاء الثلاثاء الإثنين الأحد	67
8.2	السبت الجمعة	69

9	Four Core Colours	71
9.1	أبيض أسود	71
9.2	أزرق أحمر	72
10	Family	75
10.1	أم أب	75
10.2	أخت أخ	76
11	Head and Hand	79
11.1	رأس	79
11.2	يد	80
12	Seasons	83
12.1	شتاء خريف صيف ربيع	83
13	Water and Bread	85
13.1	خبز ماء	85
14	Months	87
14.1	... يونيو مايو أبريل مارس فبراير يناير	87
15	Noon and Midnight	91
15.1	الليل منتصف الظهر	91
16	Telling Time	93
16.1	الساعة	93
17	Asking Someone's Age	97
17.1	عمرك؟ كم	97
18	Weather	99
18.1	الطقس	99
19	Numbers One to Five	101
19.1	خمسة أربعة ثلاثة اثنان واحد	101
20	Numbers Eleven to Twenty	103
20.1	عشرون — عشر أحد	103
21	Dog and Cat	105
21.1	قط , كلب	105

22	Green and Yellow	107
22.1	أصفر, أخضر	107
23	You're Welcome	109
23.1	عفوا	109
24	See You Tomorrow	111
24.1	ilā l-ghad	111
25	Day	113
25.1	يوم	113
26	Night	115
26.1	ليل	115
27	Good Night	117
27.1	tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr	117
28	Going and Coming	121
28.1	dhahaba	121
28.2	jāʾa	123
29	Saying and Seeing	125
29.1	qāla	125
29.2	raʾā	127
30	Knowing and Eating	129
30.1	ʿarafa	129
30.2	akala	131
31	Understanding, Reading, Writing	133
31.1	fahima	133
31.2	qaraʾa	135
31.3	saʾala	136
31.4	kataba	138
32	Taking, Thinking, Helping, Loving	141
32.1	ʾakhadha	141
32.2	fakkara	143
32.3	sāʿada	144
32.4	ʾaḥabba	146

33	Asking for a Drink	149
33.1	shāy	149
33.2	ḥalīb	151
33.3	sukkar	152
33.4	qahwa	154
34	Asking for Food	157
34.1	milḥ	157
34.2	laḥm	159
34.3	jubn	160
34.4	ṭa ^c ām	162
35	The People You Introduce	165
35.1	jār	165
35.2	ibn, bint	167
35.3	ṣadīq	168
36	Cups, Plates, and More Than One	171
36.1	zayt	171
36.2	kūb	173
36.3	ṭabaq	174
36.4	mil ^c aqa	176
37	The Tense That Was Missing	179
37.1	aktub	179
37.2	lā afham	180
37.3	aktub · lā afham	182
38	Two at Once	183
38.1	wa-	183
38.2	aw	184
38.3	lākin	185
38.4	ḥasanan	187
38.5	wa- · aw · lākin	188
39	Denying, and Asking	191
39.1	laysa	191
39.2	mā	192
39.3	lā ... wa-lā	194
39.4	hal	195
39.5	laysa · mā · hal	196

40	Why, That, and When	199
40.1	limādhā?	199
40.2	li-anna	200
40.3	anna	201
40.4	ḥīnamā	203
40.5	limādhā · li-anna · anna · ḥīnamā	204
41	Calling Somebody, and Asking Again	205
41.1	yā	205
41.2	karrir min faḍlik	206
41.3	yā · karrir min faḍlik	208
	Pronunciation & script (reference)	211
	Glossary	213
	Review Questions	223
	Answer Key	225
	Index	227

Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes:  voice (3)  eyes (4)  pen (8)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 15 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Arabic, recognize the reply, and choose an appropriate response.

Complete AR-C01-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: greet someone in Arabic, recognize the reply, and choose an appropriate response.

1.1 *salām* — say “peace” before meeting the page

Your first Arabic greeting is *salām*. For this lesson, keep your eyes off the script. Put the sound and meaning in your ear first; the next two tiny lessons will reveal its written pieces without asking you to swallow four new shapes at once.

The letters in this word

Say it in two easy beats: *sa* — *lām*. Hold the second *a* a little longer: *sa-LAAM*. The last sound is a clean *m*.

salām = peace; as a greeting, “peace to you.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

salām sits on the three-consonant root **s-l-m**, carrying the idea of wholeness, safety, and peace. The same family gives *islām*, *muslim*, and *sallama*, “to greet.” Hebrew *shalom* is a close Semitic cousin, and

English borrowed *salaam*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sa — lām*
- *salām*, with the long vowel in the second beat
- “peace,” while offering *salām* to an imagined person

Writing — first microstep

Only after you can say the greeting, meet one isolated shape: **س** is *sīn*, the *s* at the start of *salām*. Notice three small teeth and a trailing bowl. Trace **س** once with a finger, hide it, then air-write the three teeth. Do not decode or copy the complete word yet.

- *Write it:* **س** once, then compare its three teeth with the model

Before you move on

What does *salām* offer? (**Peace.**) Which three consonants carry its root? (**s-l-m.**) Which one shape did you trace? (**س, sīn.**) Say the word once more. Do not decode or copy the complete word yet.

1.2 س and ل — recall one shape, add one

Say *salām*. You already know what it means and traced **س** once. Now recall that shape and add only its next consonant. Arabic runs **right to left**, so the first shape waits on the right.

Script — recall sīn and add lām

- **س** is *sīn*, the *s* sound you are retrieving from lesson one. From Phoenician **shin** (“tooth”) — and the shape really is a row of teeth.
- **ل** is *lām*, the *l* sound. Notice its tall upright and low curve. From Phoenician **lāmed** (“ox-goad”) — ancestor of Greek *lambda* and Latin **L**.

Slide a finger from right to left under ل س and say *s — l*. Do not build the whole word yet.

Writing — trace, then recall

1. Trace ل once with a finger: three teeth, then the bowl.
2. Trace س once: tall upright, then the low curve.
3. Hide the models. Air-write the three teeth of *sīn*, then the tall *lām*.

Your turn

- *Point to:* ل, and say *sīn*
- *Point to:* س, and say *lām*
- *Write it:* ل س once, leaving them separate

Before you move on

Which way do Arabic words run? (**Right to left.**) Which letter has three teeth? (ل, **sīn.**) Which has the tall upright? (س, **lām.**)

1.3 ا and م — finish سلام without a cliff

Recall ل and س. Add just two shapes, then the spoken word *salām* becomes readable and writable.

Script — observe two new shapes

- ا is *alif*: one clean upright carrying the long *ā* here. From Phoenician ʾālep (“ox”) — ancestor of Greek *alpha* and Latin **A**.
- م is *mīm*: a small round head and a tail; it gives the final *m*. From Phoenician **mem** (“water”) — sibling of Greek *mu* and Latin **M**.

Arabic letters join — and a joined letter **changes shape**. The same letter looks different at the start, the middle and the end of a joined run. Its skeleton never changes (three teeth stay three teeth); only the connectors at its edges do. This is the one habit that makes Arabic read like handwriting rather than like print.

Watch all of it happen in one short word. In سلام, *sīn* reaches leftward into *lām*; *lām* and *alif* fuse into the fixed pair ل; then *alif*, which never joins leftward, forces a pen lift before final *mīm*.

Writing — guided copy, then delayed copy

1. Point right to left: س · ل · ا · م. Say *s · l · ā · m*.
2. Trace سلام once: teeth, tall hook, upright, lift, round-headed *mīm*.
3. Copy سلام once while looking.
4. Cover it. Write it once from memory, then compare and correct one feature.

Before you move on

Read سلام. (**salām, peace.**) What changes when a letter joins, and what stays the same? (**The connectors at its edges change; its skeleton does not.**) Where does the pen lift? (**After alif.**) Write the word once without looking. This is delayed recall, not penmanship perfection.

1.4 *marḥaban* — make room for someone

You can say *salām*. Now learn the light, everyday “hello” by ear before its written form asks anything of your eyes or hand.

The letters in this word

Build three small beats: *mar* — *ḥa* — *ban*. The middle consonant is a warm, breathy sound made deeper in the throat than English *h*. Approximate it gently; clarity matters more than force.

marḥaban = hello / welcome.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

The root **r-h-b** carries spaciousness: *raḥb* is roomy. So *marḥaban* is not an empty signal. It suggests, “There is room for you here.” A warm reply is *marḥabtayn* — literally, “two welcomes.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mar — ḥa — ban*
- *marḥaban*, keeping the middle consonant gentle
- *marḥabtayn*, “two welcomes”

Before you move on

What does the root r-ḥ-b suggest? (**Room, spaciousness.**) Say the three beats of *marḥaban*. The next two lessons reveal its new letter shapes in groups of two and three before you copy the whole greeting.

1.5 ڀ and ڄ — two shapes inside *marḥaban*

Say *marḥaban*. Its sound and welcome already belong to you. Now notice only two of its new written consonants.

Script — observe $r\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$ and $ḥ\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$

- ڀ is $r\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$, the tapped *r*. It curves down and left. It joins to what comes before it but not to what follows.
- ڄ is $ḥ\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$, the deep, breathy *ḥ*. Its open bowl has **no dot**.

Trace ڀ ڄ separately. Keep $ḥ\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$ open and dotless.

Your turn

- Say it: $r\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$, and trace ڀ
- Say it: $ḥ\bar{a}^{\text{◌}}$, and trace ڄ
- Write it: ڀ ڄ once from memory, then compare

Before you move on

Which letter refuses to join forward? (ج.) Which one is the dotless open bowl? (ح.) Say *marḥaban* again; the next step adds its final new skeleton and two dot-cousins.

1.6 ب ت ث — one bowl, three dot choices

You know ج and ح. Today introduces one shared bowl and three dot patterns — exactly three new shapes — before you copy *marḥaban*.

Script — one skeleton, three letters

- ب = *bā*²: one dot **below**.
- ت = *tā*²: two dots **above**.
- ث = *thā*²: three dots **above**.

The dots are not decoration. They decide which letter you wrote. Trace the bowl once, then practise the three dot choices.

ب comes from Phoenician **bēt** (“house”) — ancestor of Greek *beta* and Latin **B**. Put it beside the *alif* you already know, from **ʾālep** (“ox”), and you have the word *alpha-bet*: the **ox** and the **house**, in that order, still naming every alphabet on earth.

Writing — guided copy, then delayed copy

The greeting uses ب. Its full form is مرحبا.

1. Point right to left: م · ر · ح · ب · ل.
2. Copy مرحبا once while looking.
3. Cover it. Write it once from memory, then check the dot below ب.

Before you move on

Which cousin has one dot below? (ب.) Two above? (ت.) Three above? (ث.) Read and write مرحبا once: *marḥaban*, “welcome.”

1.7 ﺍﻝ (al-) — “the,” hiding in English *algebra*

Before the fuller greetings, one tiny, mighty word: Arabic’s “the.” You’ll need it for *the* peace, *the* goodness — and you already know how to read it.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) No new letters — just ﺍ (alif) and ﻝ (lām), the two you met in *salām*, written together as ﺍﻝ and **attached to the front** of a noun (Arabic glues “the” on; it isn’t a separate word).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ﺍﻝ (*al-*, “the”). For roughly 800 years Arabic was the Mediterranean’s language of science and trade, and English and Spanish absorbed its words **with al- still attached**: **algebra** (*al-jabr*), **alcohol** (*al-kuḥl*), **algorithm** (*al-Khwārizmī*), **alchemy**, **almanac**. Learning Arabic *al-* is meeting an old friend you’ve been carrying in English all along.

Grammar Lens: sun letters and moon letters

Here’s a rule you can *hear*. Before about half the consonants — the **sun letters** (*s, sh, n, r, t, d...*) — the *l* of *al-* assimilates and the next letter **doubles**:

- *al-* + *salām* → **as-salām** (not “al-salām”)
- *al-* + *nūr* → **an-nūr**

Before the **moon letters** (*kh, k, b, m...*) the *l* stays clear: **al-khayr**, **al-bab**. You can still hear this rule fossilized in Spanish *azúcar*, from Arabic *as-sukkar* (“the sugar”) — the *l* long gone, the doubled *s* remaining.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “al-” and three English words hiding it — al-gebra, al-cohol, al-manac
- sun-letter assimilation — *al-* + *salām* → “as-salām”

- moon-letter, no change — al- + khayr → “al-khayr”

Before you move on

What does ل mean, and how does it attach? (“The,” glued to the front of its noun.) What happens before a *sun letter* like *s*? (The *l* assimilates and the letter doubles — *as-salām*.)

1.8 *as-salāmu ʿalaykum* — offer the full greeting by ear

You already own *salām* and *al-*. Now speak the full greeting before decoding or copying its unfamiliar second half.

The letters in this word

Say *as-salāmu* — then *ʿalaykum*. In *ʿalaykum*, begin with a light tightening deep in the throat. That sound is *ʿayn*; an approximation is enough today.

as-salāmu ʿalaykum = peace be upon you.

The *l* of *al-* blends into the following *s*, so *al-salām* is pronounced *as-salām*. Arabic then places “the peace” beside “upon you” and leaves the verb “is” understood.

The exchange — the reply

The fixed reply is *wa-ʿalaykum as-salām*: “and upon you, peace.” Hear the little *wa-* at the front; it means “and.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *as-salāmu* — *ʿalaykum*
- the complete greeting once, slowly
- *wa-ʿalaykum as-salām*, the reply

Before you move on

What are the two spoken blocks? (**as-salāmu + ʿalaykum.**)
Where is the word “is”? (**It is understood.**) Speak the greeting and reply once. The next two lessons reveal the remaining shapes before showing the full line.

1.9 ع and ي — open ʿalaykum gently

Say *as-salāmu ʿalaykum*. Only after speaking the whole greeting do you meet two shapes from its second block.

Script — observe ʿayn and yāʾ

- ع is ʿayn, the deep opening sound in ʿalaykum. Notice its curved hook.
- ي is yāʾ, the y sound. In isolation it carries two dots below.

Trace each once. Then point right to left at ع ي while saying ʿ — y.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* ع, and say ʿayn
- *Trace it:* ي, and say yāʾ
- *Write it:* both once from memory, then compare

Before you move on

Which shape begins the throat sound? (ع.) Which has two dots below when isolated? (ي.) No whole phrase yet; two final shapes come next.

1.10 ل and و — complete the greeting after the sound

You can speak the greeting and recognize ع and ي. Add just two shapes, then copy the complete line.

Script — observe two new shapes

- ك is *kāf*, the *k* near the end of *‘alaykum*.
- و is *wāw*, the *w* in the reply’s opening *wa-*, “and.” Like ج, it does not join to the letter after it.

Writing — guided copy, then delayed copy

1. Find the familiar peace word inside عليكم السلام.
2. Point through the second block, عليكم, right to left.
3. Copy عليكم السلام once while looking.
4. Cover it. Write عليكم from memory, then compare and correct one shape.
5. Add و before that block to begin the reply: و عليكم.

Before you move on

Which letter gives the *k*? (ك.) Which gives *wa-*, “and”? (و.) Read عليكم السلام, then write the shorter block عليكم without looking.

1.11 as-salāmu ‘alaykum — hear, write, repair

Say *as-salāmu ‘alaykum* once. Then turn the page or cover every Arabic model. This lesson adds no shape and no new phrase.

Writing — dictation and repair

1. Hear or read the romanization *as-salāmu ‘alaykum*.
2. Write the Arabic greeting from memory.
3. Reveal عليكم السلام.
4. Compare from right to left. Circle one uncertain shape and repair it once.

Stop after one repaired attempt. Retrieval is the goal; repetition without attention is not.

Before you move on

Read **عليكم السلام** aloud. Which part did you repair? Cover the model and write only **عليكم** once more if that repair still feels uncertain.

1.12 الخير صباح (ṣabāḥ al-khayr) — “morning of goodness”

Time-of-day greetings — built, like everything, from roots and the attached *al-*. And a chance to hear two sounds English doesn’t have.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Two new letters:

- **ص** = *ṣād*, an **emphatic** (heavy, dark) “s” — a *different* letter from the light **س** you know.
- **خ** = *khāʾ*², a throat-scrape from the back of the mouth — the **same** sound as Spanish **j** (as in *José*), or the *ch* in Scottish *loch*.

With the rest known, read **صباح** (*ṣabāḥ*, “morning”) and **خير** (*khayr*, “goodness”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

صباح (*ṣabāḥ*), root **ṣ–b–ḥ** (dawn/waking: *ṣubḥ* “dawn,” *aṣbaḥa* “to become / reach morning”). **خير** (*khayr*, “good, goodness”), root **kh–y–r**. Together **الخير صباح** = “**morning of the goodness**.” Note *al-khayr* keeps its *l* — **خ** is a *moon letter* — a clean contrast with *as-salām*.

Why it’s said this way

The reply mirrors it beautifully: **النور صباح** (*ṣabāḥ an-nūr*) — “morning of the **light**” (*al-* + *nūr*, sun-letter *n* assimilated). You wish someone goodness; they wish you light back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ṣabāḥ al-khayr” — the heavy ṣ, then the throat-scrape kh
- why *al-khayr* keeps its *l* (خ is a moon letter)
- the reply — “ṣabāḥ an-nūr” (“morning of light”)

Before you move on

Read الخير صباح. What are the two roots? (ṣ-b-ḥ “morning,” kh-y-r “goodness.”) Why is it *al-khayr* but *as-salām*? (خ is a moon letter — *l* stays; *s* is a sun letter — *l* assimilates.)

1.13 الخير مساء (masāʾ al-khayr) — “evening of goodness”

The evening twin of ṣabāḥ al-khayr — and Arabic’s tidy habit of naming morning and evening as matched events.

The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Arabic.) One new mark:

- ء = *hamza*, a **glottal stop** — the little catch in the middle of “uh-oh.” At the end of مساء it closes the word: *masāʾ*ʔ.

Everything else — ا س م and the الخير you read last lesson — is already yours.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مساء (*masāʾ*ʔ, “evening”), root **m-s-w**: *amsā*, “to become / reach evening” — the *exact mirror* of *aṣbaḥa* (“to reach morning”). Arabic names the two ends of the day as matched events, each with its own “to become” verb, where French *soir* and Spanish *tarde* both merely meant “late.” الخير مساء = “evening of goodness”; reply النور مساء (*masāʾ an-nūr*), “evening of light.”

Why it's said this way

The symmetry is the point: morning and evening are greeted with the *same* structure (“[time] of goodness”) and answered with the *same* structure (“[time] of light”). Learn one pair, you have both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “masāʾ al-khayr” — the glottal catch at the end of *masāʾ*
- the mirror — *aṣbaḥa* (reach morning) / *amsā* (reach evening)
- the reply — “masāʾ an-nūr”

Before you move on

Read الخير مساء. What does the mark ء (hamza) do? (A glottal stop — the catch in “uh-oh.”) How does Arabic treat morning and evening differently from French/Spanish? (As matched “to become” events, not just “late.”)

1.14 شكرا (shukran) — “thank you”

The word for gratitude — and a chance to watch the root-and-pattern engine do its trick on a brand-new root.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Two new letters:

- ش = *shīn*, “sh” — it is simply س (*sīn*) **plus three dots** on top (the dots-on-a-skeleton idea again).
- ك = *kāf*, “k” — already met inside *ʿalaykum*.

Read شكرا right to left → *shukran*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

شكرا (*shukran*), root **sh-k-r** (*gratitude*): *shukr* (“thanks”), *shākir* (“thankful”), *mashkūr* (“thanked”). Look closely: *shākir* and *mashkūr* sit in the **exact same patterns** as *kātib* (“writer”) and *maktūb* (“written”) from the root engine — *fāʿil* (the doer) and *mafʿūl* (the done-to). Learn a pattern once and it works on every root. And it travels: this same Semitic root **sh-k-r**, carried through Persian, is the source of Hindi/Urdu *shukriyā* (“thanks”).

Why it’s said this way

The reply is gentle: عفو (ʿafwan), “it’s nothing / you’re pardoned” — from a root meaning to forgive or waive. You thank; they wave it away.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read right to left — shuk · ran → “shukran”
- how ش is just س with three dots
- the pattern echo — *shākir/mashkūr* like *kātib/maktūb*

Before you move on

Read شكرا. What is its root, and what two familiar patterns do *shākir* and *mashkūr* follow? (*sh-k-r*; the *kātib* / *maktūb* patterns — doer and done-to.) The reply to *shukran*? (ʿafwan.)

1.15 Chapter 1 — the day of greetings

A dozen letters, learned one greeting at a time, and now the whole day of Arabic greetings and their fixed replies.

You’ll want to know — Read them back

Sound each out **right to left** before checking:

Read		Meaning
سلام	<i>salām</i>	peace
مرحبا	<i>marḥaban</i>	welcome / hi
عليكم السلام	<i>as-salāmu ʿalaykum</i>	peace be upon you
الخير صباح	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>	good morning
الخير مساء	<i>masāʾ al-khayr</i>	good evening
شكرا	<i>shukran</i>	thank you

The exchange — greetings and replies

When	Greeting	Reply
casual	<i>marḥaban</i>	<i>marḥabtayn</i> (“two welcomes”)
any time	<i>as-salāmu ʿalaykum</i>	<i>wa-ʿalaykum as-salām</i>
morning	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>	<i>ṣabāḥ an-nūr</i> (“morning of light”)
evening	<i>masāʾ al-khayr</i>	<i>masāʾ an-nūr</i>
thanks	<i>shukran</i>	<i>ʿafwan</i> (“it’s nothing”)

Two engines did all of it: the three-consonant **root** (*s-l-m*, *sh-k-r*, *ṣ-b-ḥ*...) and the attached **al-** with its sun/moon assimilation (*as-salām* but *al-khayr*). The letters arrived inside real words — about a dozen of them, half the alphabet — never as a chart to memorize.

Your turn

- *Say it:* all six greetings, right to left
- *Say it:* each greeting with its reply — “as-salāmu ʿalaykum” / “wa-ʿalaykum as-salām”
- *Say it:* greet, then thank — “ṣabāḥ al-khayr!” ... “shukran.”
- *Write it:* hear *salām*, write سلام without looking, then compare and repair one shape

Before you move on

Read all six greetings aloud, right to left. Name the two “engines” that build them. (The three-consonant *root*, and the attached *al-* with sun/moon assimilation.)

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *ismī...* (“my name is...” — and how Arabic marks “you” by **gender** (*anta* to a man, *anti* to a woman), a different axis from the formal/informal split of the European languages.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes:  voice (3)  eyes (5)  pen (5)  Hands-free start: first 8 of 13 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can introduce myself in Arabic, give my name, and understand the other person’s name.

The whole introduction exchange, run once to a man and once to a woman: give a name, ask for one back, and close with tasharrafa.

2.1 اسم (ism) — “name”

To introduce yourself you need “name” — and it needs no new letters.

The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Arabic.) All three are from Chapter 1: ا (alif), س (sīn), م (mīm). Read اسم right to left → **ism**.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

اسم (*ism*, “name”), root **s–m–w**. It is a **Semitic** word, cousin of Hebrew *shem* (“name”) — the same pairing you saw with *salām* / *shalom*. It has *no* tie to the Indo-European *name* / Latin *nōmen*: Arabic is a different family entirely, and its word for “name” is its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read right to left — “ism”
- its Hebrew cousin — *shem*

Before you move on

What family does اسم belong to, and what Hebrew word is its cousin? (Semitic; *shem*. Not related to English *name*.)

2.2 ي (-ī) — “my,” a letter stuck on the end

Arabic has no separate word for “my” — it glues one letter onto the noun.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) ي (*yāʾ*), met in *ʿalaykum* — here it does a new job: attached to the end of a noun, it means “my.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Arabic builds “my” by **suffix**, not a separate word: اسم (*ism*, “name”) + ي (-ī, “my”) = اسمي (*ismī*, “my name”). This is the same trick as the attached **al-** (“the”) from Chapter 1 — Arabic loves to fasten little pieces onto a word rather than string separate words together.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ism” + “-ī” → “ismī” (“my name”)
- the pattern — Arabic glues “my” on, like it glued “the” (*al-*)

Before you move on

How does Arabic say “my,” and what is “my name”? (A suffix ي (-ī) glued on; *ismī*.)

2.3 اسمي ... (ismī ...) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

Assemble it — and notice the missing word.

You’ll want to know — The phrase, assembled

- ism (name) + -ī (my) + your name.

اسمي ... = “my-name ...” → “**my name is...**”

Ismī Arun. → “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens: no word for “is” — again

Recall from *as-salāmu ʿalaykum* (Ch. 1) that Arabic sets two words side by side and lets “is” be understood. So *ismī Arun* is literally “my-name Arun.” Arabic shares this **zero copula** with the Dravidian languages (Tamil *eṇ peyar Arun*) — two unrelated families meeting on the same habit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ismī ...” with your name
- notice — no word for “is”

Before you move on

Give your name in Arabic. (*Ismī ...*) What does Arabic leave out, and which other family does the same? (The verb “is” — the zero copula, shared with the Dravidian languages.)

2.4 أَنْتَ (anta / anti) — “you,” marked by *gender*

To ask a name you need “you” — and Arabic’s is unlike any you’ve met: it changes with the *listener’s* gender.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Two new letters: ا (alif with a hamza seat, a glottal “a”-start) and ت (*tāʾ*, “t” — the ب/ت/ث skeleton from Ch. 1, two dots above). The final vowel is a mark: أَنْتَ *anta*, أَنْتِ *anti*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَنْتَ is “you” — but Arabic splits it by the listener’s **gender**: *anta* to a man, *anti* to a woman. (Note the Semitic *-ta/-ti* ending — the same *t* that marks “you” in Hebrew *atta/att*.)

Grammar Lens: a different axis of “you”

The European and Dravidian tracks split “you” by **register** (familiar vs. respectful — *tū/vous*, *nī/nīṅaḷ*). Arabic splits it by **gender**: *anta* (to a man) vs. *anti* (to a woman). Same pronoun, a wholly different distinction — you choose by *who you’re talking to*, not how formal you are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “anta” (to a man), “anti” (to a woman)
- the contrast — European/Dravidian split by register, Arabic by gender

Before you move on

How does Arabic split “you,” and how is that different from French or Tamil? (By **gender** — *anta* (m.) / *anti* (f.); the others split by register.)

2.5 ما (mā) — “what”

The question-word — and you already read it as a warm-up in Chapter 1.

The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Arabic.) No new letters: م (*m*) + ا (*alif*, long *ā*) → ما *mā*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ما (*mā*, “what”) is the everyday question-word for things. (Arabic has a second, *māḍā*, for “what” before verbs; *mā* is the one you want before a noun, as in “what [is] your name?”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mā” (“what”)
- “mā ismuka?” — “what [is] your name?”

Before you move on

What does ما mean, and when is it used? (“What,” before a noun.)

2.6 ما اسمك؟ (mā ismuka / ismuki) — “what’s your name?”

Assemble the question — what + your-name — no “is,” gender in the suffix.

You’ll want to know — The phrase, assembled

- اسمك = اسم (*ism*, name) + ك (*kāf*, the “your” suffix) — and it too is **gendered**: *ismuka* (a man’s name), *ismuki* (a woman’s).

ما اسمك = literally “**what** [is] **your-name**?”

No “is,” the possessive glued on, the gender carried in the suffix.

Grammar Lens: the matched suffixes

“My name” takes ي (*-ī*), “your name” takes ك (*-ka/-ki*). The suffixes are the grammar of the exchange. Answer with *ismī Arun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mā ismuka?” (to a man), “mā ismuki?” (to a woman)
- ask, then answer — “mā ismuka?” / “ismī ...”

Before you move on

What does ما اسمك؟ literally say, and where is the gender marked?
 (“What your-name?”; in the suffix — *-ka* (m.) / *-ki* (f.).)

2.7 تشرفنا (tasharrafnā) — “pleased to meet you”

The warm close — and it presents the meeting as an honour.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Uses ت (*tāʿ*, just met), ش (*shīn*) and ر (*rāʿ*) from Ch. 1, plus ف (*fāʿ*, “f”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*), root **sh-r-f** (*honour, nobility*): *sharaf* (“honour”), *sharīf* (“noble” — the *Sharīf* of Mecca, and distantly the title behind English *sheriff*). *tasharrafnā* means literally “**we have been honoured**” — to meet you is presented as an honour received. A more literal option is سعيدة فرصة (*furṣa saʿīda*, “a happy occasion”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tasharrafnā”
- the root family — *sharaf* (honour), *sharīf* (noble)

Before you move on

What does تشرفنا literally mean, and from what root? (“We have been honoured”; *sh-r-f*, “honour.”)

2.8 Chapter 2 — the introduction, whole

You could already greet someone. Every lesson since has been building one short exchange: give your name, ask for theirs, close warmly. Here it is whole.

The exchange

Read right to left:

Arabic	English
ميرا اسمي. (<i>ismī Mira</i>)	My name is Mira.
ما اسمك؟ (<i>mā ismuka</i>)	What's your name?
أرون اسمي. (<i>ismī Arun</i>)	My name is Arun.
تشرفنا. (<i>tasharrafnā</i>)	Pleased to meet you.

You'll want to know — the pieces

Every piece from the root-and-suffix engine:

- **ism** ← root *s-m-w* (Hebrew *shem*, not English *name*)
- the glued **-ī** (“my”) and **-ka/-ki** (“your”)
- **tasharrafnā** ← root *sh-r-f* (“honour”; *sharīf*, *sheriff*)

Two Arabic habits: it drops “is” entirely (the **zero copula**, shared with the Dravidian languages), and it marks “you” by **gender** (*anta/anti*), not register.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, right to left
- your own introduction — “ismī ..., tasharrafnā”
- ask it back — “mā ismuka?” (to a man) / “mā ismuki?” (to a woman)

Before you move on

Give your name, ask someone else's, say you're pleased. (*Ismī ... / Mā ismuka? / Tasharrafnā.*) Two things Arabic does differently from the European tracks? (No word for “is” — zero copula; and “you” split by *gender*, not register.)
Next chapter: *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“how are you?”) and *al-ḥamdu lillāh* — the responding cycle.

2.9 ن، ت، ث — one bowl, four dot-patterns

In Lesson 3 you drew ب (*bāʾ*) — a boat-bowl with **one dot below** — and met the idea that the **dots make the letter**. Now the promised payoff: the *same* bowl, with the dots moved and multiplied, gives you three more common letters. Learn the bowl once; the dots do the rest.

Script — The bowl family — a truth-table

Every letter here is the **same shallow boat-bowl** you already draw for *bāʾ*. Only the dots change:

letter	sound	the dots
ب <i>bāʾ</i>	b	one dot below (from Lesson 3)
ن <i>nūn</i>	n	one dot above
ت <i>tāʾ</i>	t	two dots above
ث <i>thāʾ</i>	th	three dots above
ح (<i>ḥāʾ</i>)	ḥ	no dot (a bigger hook — Lesson 3's cousin)

Read it as a dial: **below** → **1 above** → **2 above** → **3 above**. The pen-stroke is identical each time; your only real decision is *how many dots, and on which side*.

Script — Draw them

- ن (*nūn*) — the bowl, then **one dot above**. (*nūn* sits a little deeper than *bāʾ* when it stands alone, but joined, it is the shared skeleton + one dot.) From Phoenician **nun**, “fish” — ancestor of Greek *nu* and Latin **N**.

- ت ($tā^2$) — the bowl, then **two dots above**. From Phoenician **taw**, “mark” — the great-grandparent of Latin **T** (and the word *tattoo*-like “mark” survives in *taw* meaning a cross-mark).
- ث ($thā^2$) — the bowl, then **three dots above** (drawn as a little triangle of dots).

Script — Where you have seen them — أنت

The Chapter 2 word أنت (*anta / anti*, “you”) is built from exactly these: an *alif* (with a small **hamza** seat you will meet in Lesson 6), then ن (*nūn*, one dot above) joined to ت ($tā^2$, two dots above). So أنت is, in dots, “bowl-with-one-above, bowl-with-two-above” — you can now read the skeleton of a real word.

Your turn

- *Write it:* the same bowl four times, then dot them — ب (1 below), ن (1 above), ت (2 above), ث (3 above)
- *Say it:* the dial — “below, one above, two above, three above — b, n, t, th”
- *Write it:* the joined pair نت ($nūn \rightarrow tā^2$), the core of أنت

Before you move on

What single feature separates ب, ن, ت, ث? (**The dots** — same bowl; one below / one above / two above / three above.) Which two of them build the Chapter 2 word أنت (“you”) (ن *nūn* and ت $tā^2$)? What Latin letters descend from *nūn* and *taw*? (**N** and **T**.) Next: ي ($yā^2$), the two-dots-below letter — and your name.

2.10 ي ($yā^2$) — the last dot-letter, and “my name”

One more member of the bowl family, and it is a **triple threat**: ي ($yā^2$) is a consonant *y*, **and** the long vowel **ī**, **and** the little suffix **-ī** meaning “**my**.” With it you can finally write a whole Chapter 2 phrase in your own hand: اسمي (“my name”).

Script — ي (yāʾ) — two dots below

Break it apart:

1. **the body** — the boat-bowl (standing alone) or a tooth (when joined).
2. **two dots BELOW** — the mark that completes the bowl-family dial: $bāʾ$ had one below, $yāʾ$ has **two** below.

So the full “below/above” set is now closed: ب one-below, ي two-below; ن one-above, ت two-above, ث three-above. $Yāʾ$ comes from Phoenician **yod**, “hand” — the ancestor of Greek *iota* and Latin **I / J** (and the reason we say “not one *iota*,” the smallest letter).

You’ll want to know — Its three jobs

- **consonant y** — as in *yawm* (“day”).
- **long vowel ī** — a *seat* for the “ee” sound.
- **the suffix ي “my”** — the Chapter 2 possessive. Glue $-ī$ onto a noun and it becomes “my _____,” exactly as *ism* (“name”) + $-ī$ → *ismī* (“my name”).

Script — Assemble — first اسم, then اسمي

You already know every letter of اسم (*ism*, “name”) from Lessons 1–3: ا (alif) · س (sīn) · م (mīm). Write it right-to-left:

1. ا (*alif*) — the upright; it **does not join** forward, so the pen lifts.
2. س (*sīn*) — three teeth, joining into...
3. م (*mīm*) — round head + tail. → اسم.

Now add ي for “my.” *Mīm* joins forward to $yāʾ$, giving اسمي (*ismī*):

- اسمي = *alif* · *sīn* · *mīm* · $yāʾ$ = *i-s-m-ī* = “**my name**.”

Read it back, right to left, and you have written a phrase you will say every time you introduce yourself.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ي — body + **two dots below**
- *Say it:* the closed dial — “ب one-below, ي two-below; ن/ت/ث one/two/three above”
- *Write it:* اسم (ism), then extend to اسمي (ismī, “my name”)

Before you move on

Where do *yāʾ*’s dots sit, and how many? (**Two, below.**) Name *yāʾ*’s **three** jobs. (Consonant *y*; long vowel *ī*; the suffix *-ī* “**my**.”) Spell اسمي letter by letter, right to left. (*alif · sīn · mīm · yāʾ* — “my name.”) Next: the little **vowel marks** — and how one of them flips أنت from “you (m.)” to “you (f.).”

2.11 َ ِ ُ — the short vowels the abjad usually hides

In the first writing cluster you learned Arabic is an **abjad**: short vowels are **usually left out**. This lesson shows the marks that a beginner’s book *does* print when it wants to be clear—the **ḥarakāt**—and one of them delivers the neatest payoff in the whole set: the difference between “you (m.)” and “you (f.)” is a **single dash**.

Script — The ḥarakāt — three short-vowel marks

These are small marks written **around** a consonant, not letters in their own right. On the letter *bāʾ* (ب):

mark	name	where	sound	example
َ	<i>fatha</i>	a slash above	“a”	بَ = <i>ba</i>
ِ	<i>kasra</i>	a slash below	“i”	بِ = <i>bi</i>
ُ	<i>damma</i>	a tiny <i>wāw</i> above	“u”	بُ = <i>bu</i>

Stop at these three vowel marks. The next four-minute micro-lesson adds the separate ideas “no vowel,” “double this consonant,” and the *-an*

ending. Their shapes wait there so this page never asks you to absorb two writing steps at once.

You'll want to know — The payoff — أَنْتَ vs أَنْتِ

Here is why the marks matter. The Chapter 2 word أَنْتَ (“you”) is the *same* consonant skeleton for a man and a woman — *alif · nūn · tāʾ*. What splits them is a single ḥaraka on the final ت:

- أَنْتَ — $tāʾ + \text{fatḥa}$ (the “a” slash above) = **anta**, “you” to a **man**.
- أَنْتِ — $tāʾ + \text{kasra}$ (the “i” slash below) = **anti**, “you” to a **woman**.

One dash up or down carries the whole gender distinction you learned in the introductions chapter. Leave the mark off — as normal Arabic does — and أَنْتَ serves both, the reader deciding from context.

Your turn

- *Write it:* on ب — *fatḥa* above (*ba*), *kasra* below (*bi*), *damma* above (*bu*)
- *Say it:* the flip — “أَنْتَ *anta* (man, slash above) vs أَنْتِ *anti* (woman, slash below)”

Before you move on

What are the ḥarakāt, and does everyday text show them? (The short- **vowel marks** — *fatḥa/kasra/damma*; normally **left off**, since Arabic is an abjad.) Which mark, and where, turns *anta* into *anti*? (A *kasra* — the “i” slash—**below** the final $tāʾ$, instead of the *fatḥa* above.) You have now made one consonant skeleton say *anta* or *anti* with one tiny mark.

2.12 ٸ — stop, double, or add *-an*

You already know the three short-vowel marks. Keep those shapes in mind. This lesson adds exactly three more marks, one job at a time.

Script — Three marks, three instructions

Each mark sits around a consonant. It changes how you read that consonant; it is not another full letter.

mark	name	instruction
◌ْ	<i>sukūn</i>	stop: no vowel follows this consonant
◌ّ	<i>shadda</i>	hold or double this consonant
◌ّٰ	<i>fathatan</i>	add the ending <i>-an</i>

Look at the last mark in **شَكَرًا** (*shukran*, “thank you”). The small doubled stroke above the final letter supplies *-an*. You have seen the word before; today you are learning what that one mark tells the reader.

Your turn

- *Write it:* draw ◌ْ once — a small circle above the line; say “no vowel”
- *Write it:* draw ◌ّ once — a small *w* above the line; say “double”
- *Write it:* draw ◌ّٰ once — two light slashes above the line; say “-an”
- *Say it:* point in order — *sukūn*, *shadda*, *fathatan*

Before you move on

Which mark means “no vowel”? (◌ْ, *sukūn*.) Which doubles a consonant? (◌ّ, *shadda*.) Which gives *shukran* its *-an* ending? (◌ّٰ, *fathatan*.) Trace each once more without rushing.

2.13 ء and ا — the glottal catch

The marks in the last lesson supplied vowels. **Hamza** is different: it writes a real consonant sound.

Script — The catch in “uh-oh”

Say English “uh-oh” slowly. The little catch between the two syllables is a **glottal stop**. Arabic writes that consonant with ء, called **hamza**.

Hamza often sits on a **seat**. At the start of أنت (anta/anti, “you”), it rides above *l*, producing *á*. The *alif* supplies the seat; the hamza marks the glottal-stop consonant.

That gives *alif* two roles you must keep separate:

- *l* can carry long *ā*.
- *á* can be an *alif* seat bearing the consonant *ʿ*.

Hamza is therefore not another short-vowel mark. Its sound is the catch itself.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “uh-oh” and feel the glottal catch
- *Write it*: *ʿ* alone, then *á* on its *alif* seat
- *Point to*: أنت / أنتَ — the same initial hamza in both

Before you move on

Is hamza a vowel mark? (**No.**) What sound does it write? (**A glottal stop.**) What is *á*? (**Hamza riding on an alif seat.**)

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (2) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ **Hands-free start:** none of the 9 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can ask an Arabic speaker how they are, answer that I am well, and change the ending of the question to match a man or a woman.*

The whole how-are-you exchange, run once to a man and once to a woman, with bi-khayr written out by hand.

3.1 ح، خ، ج — the dots trick, on a brand-new body

Before the new letters, point once to َ, ّ, and ٌ. Say their jobs: “no vowel”, “double”, “-an”. If one feels slow, trace it once. Then leave the marks behind for today.

Back in Lesson 4 you learned a whole family of letters that share one **bowl** and differ only by dots. Arabic does the *same trick* on a **second** skeleton — a curvy **hook-and-tail body** — giving three more common letters. Learn the body once; the dots do the rest, exactly as before.

Script — The hook-and-tail family

Every letter here is the **same shape**: a rounded **hook** at the top flowing into a **tail that drops below the line**. Only the dot changes:

letter	sound	the dot
ح <i>ḥāʾ</i>	ḥ — a deep, breathy “h” (from the throat)	no dot
خ <i>khāʾ</i>	kh — like the <i>ch</i> in Scottish “loch”	one dot above
ج <i>jīm</i>	j — as in “jam”	one dot below

It is the bowl-family idea reborn: one skeleton, the dots deciding everything. Say the dial — **no dot / above / below** → ḥ / kh / j.

Script — Draw them

- ح (*ḥāʾ*) — the hook body, then the descending tail; **no dot**. From Phoenician ḥēth (“fence”) — the ancestor of Latin **H**.
- خ (*khāʾ*) — the **same** body, plus **one dot above**. (Arabic built *khāʾ* from *ḥāʾ* by adding the dot — no separate Latin cousin, but you already know the shape.)
- ج (*jīm*) — the same body, plus **one dot below**. From Phoenician gīml (“camel”) — the great-grandparent of Greek *gamma* and Latin **C/G**.

Script — Where you’ve seen it — خير

You have already read خير (*khayr*, “good/well”) inside the Chapter 1 greeting الخير صباح (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*, “good morning”). It **opens with** خ — the hook-body plus one dot above. You now know the first letter of a word you’ve been saying since Lesson... one.

Your turn

- *Write it:* the same hook-and-tail body three times, then dot them — ح (none), خ (above), ج (below)
- *Say it:* the dial — “no dot, above, below — ḥ, kh, j”
- *Say it:* “خ opens خير — the ‘good’ in *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*”

Before you move on

What do ح, خ, ج share, and what tells them apart? (One **hook-and-tail body**; the **dots** — none / above / below.) Which sound is خ, and where's its dot? (**kh**, like *loch*; **one above**.) Which Chapter 1 word opens with خ? (خير, in *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*.) Next: ك (kāf) and ر (rā) — the last letters you need to write it.

3.2 ك and ر — an angular k, and an r that won't hold hands

Two more shapes, and then — next lesson — you can write خير. Meet ك (kāf, “k”) and ر (rā, “r”). One is angular and new; the other revisits a rule you learned on the very first day.

Script — ك (kāf) — the angular k

Break it apart:

1. **the body** — an **angular upright**, bending like an open corner (not a curve — a hard angle).
2. **the inner stroke** — a small *hamza*-like flick tucked **inside** the angle.

ك is kāf, a clean “k.” From Phoenician **kaph** (“palm of the hand”) — the ancestor of Greek *kappa* and Latin **K**. It joins its neighbours, changing shape by position like the other connectors.

Script — ر (rā) — the little downward curve that breaks

Break it apart — there's just *one piece*:

1. **the curve** — a short stroke that **curves down below the baseline** and stops. No dot, no loop.

ر is rā, “r.” From Phoenician **rēsh** (“head”) — ancestor of Greek *rho* and Latin **R**. And here is the important rule: like **alif** (Lesson 1), **rā does not join to the letter after it** — it is one of the **six non-joiners**. So *rā* forces the pen to **lift**, just as *alif* did in سلام.

Your turn

- Write it: 𐤊 — angular body + the inner flick
- Write it: 𐤌 — one short downward curve below the line
- Say it: “*rā*, like *alif*, **breaks** — no joining the next letter”
- Say it: “*kaph* → K, *rēsh* → R — the Phoenician cousins again”

Before you move on

Describe 𐤊: angular or curved, and what sits inside? (**Angular** body with a small **inner stroke**.) What Latin letters descend from *kāf* and *rā*? (**K** and **R**.) What rule does 𐤌 share with **alif**? (It is a **non-joiner** — the pen **lifts** after it.) Next: you assemble خیر — and answer “how are you?”

3.3 خیر and بخیر — writing “good,” and how you say you’re well

Everything comes together. With خ (Lesson 7), ي (Lesson 5), and 𐤌 (Lesson 8), you can now write خیر (*khayr*, “good”) — the word hiding in every “good morning” you’ve greeted with — and then بخیر (*bi-khayr*, “well”), the everyday answer to “how are you?”

Script — Assemble خیر — right to left

Write it starting on the **right**, moving **left**:

1. خ (*khāʾ*) — the hook-body with **one dot above**, **reaching left** into...
2. ي (*yāʾ*) — joined in the middle (its two dots below), flowing into...
3. 𐤌 (*rā*) — the little down-curve. Remember Lesson 8: *rā* is a **non-joiner**, so it simply ends the word — but *yāʾ* **does** join into it from the right.

Read back, right to left: خ · ي · ر = $kh \cdot \bar{i} \cdot r$ = خير, “good.” (The root **kh-y-r** means “good, best, choice” across Semitic — the same three consonants carry the meaning, vowels laid on top, just like Arabic always works.)

Script — Then بخير — “(I’m) well”

Glue ب (*bi-*, “in / with”) onto the front — $b\bar{a}^o$ from Lesson 3, its one dot below — and it joins straight into the $kh\bar{a}^o$:

- بخير = $b\bar{a}^o \cdot kh\bar{a}^o \cdot y\bar{a}^o \cdot r\bar{a}$ = **bi-khayr**, literally “**in goodness**” — what you say when someone asks *kayfa ḥāluk?* (“how are you?”). “*Al-ḥamdu lillāh, bi-khayr*” — “Praise God, (I’m) well.”

You have now written a **real reply** in a real conversation, in your own hand.

Your turn

- Write it: خير, right to left — “ $kh\bar{a}^o$ (dot above), $y\bar{a}^o$, $r\bar{a}$ — lift”
- Write it: بخير — add *bi-* on the right: “ $b\bar{a}^o$ joins into $kh\bar{a}^o$ ”
- Say it: “the root **kh-y-r** = good; *bi-khayr* = ‘in goodness’ = ‘I’m well’”

Before you move on

Spell خير letter by letter, right to left. ($kh\bar{a}^o \cdot y\bar{a}^o \cdot r\bar{a}$ — “good.”) Which letter ends it, and does anything join *after* it? ($r\bar{a}$ — **no**, it’s a non-joiner; the pen lifts.) What does بخير literally mean, and when do you say it? (“**In goodness**” — the answer to “how are you?”, *kayfa ḥāluk?*.) You can now hand-write a greeting *and* its reply — the Arabic script is yours.

3.4 كيف (kayfa) — “how”

Chapter 2 gave you ما (*mā*, “what”). Here is its partner: كيف (*kayfa*, “how”). Two question words, and you can already build with both.

You'll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) ك (kāf) and ي (yāʾ) you have written — kāf in the writing set, yāʾ in اسمي. The last letter, ف (fāʾ, the f), is **new**; the writing track hasn't reached it yet, so read it for now and draw it later.

Right to left: ك · ي · ف → *kay-fa*.

Note the **ay** in the middle — the yāʾ is doing double duty again, this time as part of a diphthong, exactly as it did as a long ī in *ismī*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كيف is a **question word**, so it doesn't behave like the root-and-pattern nouns you've been meeting — it just *is*. But the letters **k-y-f** do form a root elsewhere:

word	meaning
kayfiyya	quality, manner — literally “ how-ness ”
kayyafa	to adapt, adjust (to make a thing fit <i>how</i> it must be)
takyīf	adaptation — and, in modern Arabic, air conditioning

So the abstract noun for “quality” is built straight from the word “how.” Arabic does this constantly: take a word, run it through a pattern, get a concept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kayfa*” — “how”
- the pair — “مَا mā (what) · كيف *kayfa* (how)”
- “*kayfiyya*” — and hear “how-ness”

Before you move on

What does كيف mean? (“**How**.”) Which Chapter 2 word is its partner? (ما, “what”.) Which letter in it is new? (ف, fāʾ — the f.) What is *kayfiyya*? (“**Quality**” — literally *how-ness*, built from this very word.) Next: the word Arabic asks about when it asks how you

are — and it isn't "you."

3.5 حال (ḥāl) — “state, condition”

English asks “how are **you**?” Arabic asks about something else entirely — your حال, your *state*. Get this word and the whole question falls open.

You'll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Three letters, **all already yours**: ح (ḥāʾ, the deep throat *h*, from the hook-family lesson), ا (alif), ل (lām).

Right to left: ح · ا · ل → ḥāl. And remember from the writing set: *alif* **breaks** the join, so ḥā- then -l.

Why it's said this way

Here is the payoff. حال comes from the root ḥ-w-l, “to turn, to change.” Look what grows from it:

word	meaning	the turning inside
ḥāl	state, condition	how things have turned out
ḥawla	around	turning <i>round</i> something
taḥwīl	transformation, transfer	making something turn into another
ḥawl	a year	one full turn of the seasons
aḥwāl	circumstances (plural of ḥāl)	the way things stand

So a “state” in Arabic is not a fixed thing you *are* — it's the position you have **turned to**. The language builds “condition” out of motion. Compare what you already know: Spanish *estar* (“to be, temporarily”) came from Latin *stāre*, “to **stand**.” Two languages, two metaphors for the same idea — one **stands**, one **turns**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ḥāl*” — deep *ḥ* from the throat, not an English *h*
- “*ḥāl* · *ḥawla* · *taḥwīl*” — hear the root turning
- the contrast — “Arabic **turns**, Spanish *estar* **stands**”

Before you move on

What does *ḥāl* mean? (“**State, condition.**”) What root is it from, and what does that root mean? (**ḥ–w–l**, “**to turn, change.**”) So what is a “state,” literally? (**How things have turned.**) What is *ḥawl*? (“**A year**” — one full turn.) Next: bolt a “your” onto it and you have the question.

3.6 *ḥāluka*؟ كيف (kayfa ḥāluka?) — “how are you?”

Everything in this question is already yours. You are not learning a new phrase — you are **bolting three known pieces together**.

You’ll want to know — The assembly

piece	where you met it
كيف <i>kayfa</i> — “how”	last-but-one lesson
حال <i>ḥāl</i> — “state”	last lesson
ك <i>-ka</i> / <i>-ki</i> — “your”	new , but see below

→ *ḥāluka*؟ كيف = “how [is] your state?”

Grammar Lens — The suffix you already half-know

In Chapter 2 you attached *-ī* (ي, “my”) to a noun: *ism* → *ismī* (“my name”). The suffix for “**your**” works **identically** — it just clips onto the end:

- *ḥāluka* — “your state,” said **to a man**
- *ḥāluki* — “your state,” said **to a woman**

And look at that split: **-ka** to a man, **-ki** to a woman. That is exactly the أنت / أنتِ (*anta* / *anti*) division from Chapter 2 — Arabic marking gender, not formality, where Spanish and French mark register. The

same *fatha* / *kasra* mark that flipped *anta* to *anti* flips *ḥāluka* to *ḥāluki*. **One letter, one mark, both meanings.**

Grammar Lens — No verb at all

Notice what is **missing**: there is no “is,” no “are.” Just *how* — *your-state*. This is the **zero copula** you met with اسمي (“my name [is] ...”): Arabic simply doesn’t need a verb to join a thing to its description.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a man — “*kayfa ḥāluka?*”
- to a woman — “*kayfa ḥāluki?*”
- the parallel — “*ismī* my name · *ḥāluka* your state”
- the missing word — “how · your-state — **no ‘is’**”

Before you move on

What does *كيف حالك؟* literally say? (“**How** [is] **your state?**”) Which suffix means “your,” and how does it split? (**-ka** to a man, **-ki** to a woman — the *anta/anti* split again.) Which Chapter 2 suffix does it copy? (**-ī**, “my,” as in *ismī*.) What word is absent from the sentence? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Next: how to answer.

3.7 بخير (bi-khayr) — “well”

The answer to *kayfa ḥāluka?* — and you have **already written this word by hand**. Nothing here is new; it is two old pieces stuck together.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) ب (*bāʾ*), خ (*khāʾ*), ي (*yāʾ*), ر (*rāʾ*) — every one of them from the writing set, where you assembled *خير* and then *بخير* letter by letter. Right to left: ر · ي · خ · ب.

You'll want to know — The two pieces

خير (*khayr*) — “**good, goodness.**” You have met it before without being told: it is sitting inside the Chapter 1 greeting صباح الخير (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*, “morning of **the good**”). The greeting was never a fixed lump — it was always *ṣabāḥ* + *al-* + *khayr*.

بِ (bi-) — “**in, with.**” A **one-letter preposition**, and like ال (*al-*) from Chapter 1, it does not stand alone: it **glues** onto the front of the next word.

→ بخير = *bi-* + *khayr* = “**in goodness.**”

You'll want to know — What you actually say

- — كيف حالك؟ *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“How is your state?”)
- — شكراً بخير. *bi-khayr, shukran.* (“Well, thank you.”)

Literally: “*In goodness, thanks.*” Not “I am fine” — Arabic doesn’t need the “I am” any more than the question needed an “is.”

You'll want to know — The bi- you have heard before

That same بِ opens the most-spoken phrase in the language: الله بسم (*bismillāh*, “**in** the name of God”) — *bi-* + *ism* (the very word from Chapter 2!) + *allāh*. One tiny letter, doing the same job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*bi-khayr*” — “in goodness”
- the callback — “*ṣabāḥ al-khayr ... bi-khayr*”
- the exchange — “*kayfa ḥāluka? — bi-khayr, shukran.*”
- “*bismillāh*” — and find *ism* inside it

Before you move on

What does بخير literally mean? (“**In goodness.**”) Where had you already met *khayr*? (Inside صباح الخير — “morning of the good.”) What kind of word is بِ? (A **one-letter preposition** that attaches, like *al-*.) What is missing from the answer, again? (Any word for “**I**”

am.”) Next: the answer Arabic gives even more often.

3.8 لله الحمد (al-ḥamdu lillāh) — “praise be to God”

Ask an Arabic speaker how they are and this, more often than *bi-khayr*, is what comes back. It also hides the best root story in the chapter.

You’ll want to know — The letters

(Skim if you read Arabic.) ا ل م ح د and ل ل ه — **every letter is one you have written**: *alif*, *lām*, *ḥā*², *mīm*, *dāl*, *hā*². Nothing new to draw.

You’ll want to know — The pieces

piece	meaning	where from
ال <i>al-</i>	“the”	Chapter 1
حمد <i>ḥamd</i>	praise	new , root ḥ–m–d
لي <i>li-</i>	“to, for”	a one-letter preposition, like <i>bi-</i>
الله <i>allāh</i>	God	<i>al-</i> + <i>ilāh</i> , “ the god”

→ لله الحمد = “**the** praise [is] **to** **God**.” Zero copula once more.

Note الله itself: it is *al-* (the article you learned in Chapter 1) fused onto *ilāh*, “a god.” The word is literally “**the** **God**.” Its Semitic cousins are Hebrew **El** and **Elohim** — the same family pairing as *salām* / *shalom* from Chapter 1.

Why it’s said this way

ḥ–m–d means “**to** **praise**.” Run it through Arabic’s patterns:

word	pattern meaning
ḥamd	praise (the plain noun)
maḥmūd	praised
ḥamīd	praiseworthy
aḥmad	“more praiseworthy” — the name Ahmad
muḥammad	“the much-praised one” — the name Muhammad

So the most frequently used phrase in the language and the most common given name on earth are built from **the same three consonants**. This is the root engine doing exactly what Chapter 1 promised: three letters, and a whole family of meanings drops out.

You’ll want to know — Using it

- — كيف حالك؟ *kayfa ḥāluka?*
- — لله الحمد. *al-ḥamdu lillāh.*

It works as “fine, thanks” — said whether things are going well or badly, which is part of its point.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*al-ḥamdu lillāh*”
- the root — “*ḥamd · ḥamīd · aḥmad · muḥammad*”
- “*allāh*” — and hear *al-* + *ilāh*, “**the** god”
- the full exchange — “*kayfa ḥāluka? — al-ḥamdu lillāh.*”

Before you move on

What does الله الحمد literally say? (“**The praise [is] to God.**”) What root is *ḥamd* from? (**ḥ-m-d**, “to praise.”) Which two names come out of that root? (**Aḥmad** and **Muḥammad** — “the much-praised.”) What is *allāh* made of? (*al-* + *ilāh* = “**the** god”;

cousin of Hebrew *El*.) Next: practice the whole exchange.

3.9 Practice — the whole exchange

Chapter 1 let you greet. Chapter 2 let you introduce yourself. This chapter closes the loop: you can **ask after someone and answer back**.

The exchange

	Arabic	literally
A	عليكم السلام (<i>as-salāmu</i> <i>‘alaykum</i>)	peace [be] upon you
B	السلام عليكم (<i>wa-‘alaykum</i> <i>as-salām</i>)	and upon you, peace
A	حالك؟ كيف (<i>kayfa</i> <i>ḥāluka?</i>)	how [is] your state?
B	بخير لله، الحمد. (<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh</i> , <i>bi-khayr</i>)	the praise [is] to God — in goodness
B	اسمك؟ ما وأنت؟ (<i>wa-anta? mā</i> <i>ismuka?</i>)	and you? what [is] your name?

Read down the right-hand column. **Not one line contains a verb “to be.”** Arabic just puts the two things next to each other.

You’ll want to know — the pieces

phrase	built from
<i>kayfa ḥāluka</i>	<i>kayfa</i> + <i>ḥāl</i> + -ka/-ki
<i>bi-khayr</i>	bi- + <i>khayr</i> (already inside <i>ṣabāḥ</i> <i>al-khayr</i>)
<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh</i>	<i>al-</i> + <i>ḥamd</i> + li- + <i>allāh</i>
<i>ismuka</i>	<i>ism</i> + -ka/-ki — the same suffix as <i>ḥāluka</i>

Three attaching pieces — **al-**, **bi-**, **li-** — and two suffixes, **-ī** and **-ka/-ki**. That is most of the chapter.

Grammar Lens — gender

Every “you” here splits. Say the pair aloud:

to a man

to a woman

kayfa ḥāluka?

kayfa ḥāluki?

mā ismuka?

mā ismuki?

anta

anti

One vowel mark decides — the *fatha* / *kasra* pair.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the full exchange, both parts, to a man
- *Say it*: it again, to a woman — every *-ka* becomes *-ki*
- *Write it*: بخير — you have every letter
- *Say it*: the roots met so far — “**s-l-m** peace · **ḥ-w-l** turn · **kh-y-r** good · **ḥ-m-d** praise”

Before you move on

Ask “how are you?” to a woman. (*Kayfa ḥāluki?*) Give both answers. (*Bi-khayr* / *al-ḥamdu lillāh*.) What do *al-*, *bi-* and *li-* have in common? (All **attach** to the next word — they never stand alone.) What single word is absent from every line of the dialogue? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Which root gave both a common phrase and a common name? (**ḥ-m-d** — *al-ḥamdu lillāh* and *Muḥammad*.) Next chapter: **farewells** — and the root that started it all comes back.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: ⇄ **voice** (4) 👁 **eyes** (1) ✍ **pen** (3) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** none of the 8 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can close a conversation in Arabic, choosing between ma^ʿa s-salāma and ilā l-liqāʾ.*

The four-chapter conversation end to end – greet, name, how-are-you, farewell – with every -ka swapped to -ki on the second run.

4.1 ع (ʿayn) — the eye that became an O

Point to ٠, ّ, ّ: “no vowel”, “double”, “-an”.

This is the letter people think of when they think “Arabic.” ع (ʿayn) writes a sound made **deep in the throat** — one English simply does not have. And its history holds the best surprise in the whole alphabet: this consonant is the ancestor of our vowel **O**.

Script — Draw it

Break it apart — *an open curve, then a bowl*:

1. **the open-mouth curve** on top — like a small **c** opening to the left.
2. **the bowl below**, when ʿayn stands alone or ends a word — a scoop underneath.

Joined in the middle of a word it flattens into a little wedge; standing alone it shows the full curve-over-bowl. It is a **connector**, so it changes coat by position like *sīn* and *lām*.

Script — A third dots-family

You know the **bowl** family (ب/ت/ن/ث) from Lesson 4 and the **hook-and-tail** family (ح/خ/ج) from Lesson 7. *ʿayn* opens a **third**: its skeleton is shared with غ (*ghayn*), which is the **same shape plus one dot above**. Same trick, third time — by now you should expect it.

Script — The surprise: *ʿayn* → O

ʿayn comes from Phoenician **ʿayin**, meaning “**eye**” — and the oldest forms were drawn as one. When the **Greeks** borrowed the Phoenician alphabet, they had **no throat-sound** like ʿ. So they did what borrowers do with a sign they can’t use: they **repurposed** it — and turned the eye-shaped letter into the vowel **omicron**, our **O**.

So the round **O** you write is a Phoenician **eye**, and Arabic’s *ʿayn* is the same sign that kept its original consonant job. (Compare the thread so far: *ʾālep*→**A**, *bēt*→**B**, *mem*→**M**, *kaph*→**K**, *rēsh*→**R** — and now *ʿayin*→**O**.)

Script — Where you’ve heard it

You have been *saying* this sound since Chapter 1: عليكم السلام (*as-salāmu ʿalaykum*) — the ʿ in *ʿalaykum* is this letter. And the farewell you’ll write two lessons from now, مع السلامة, opens with it.

Your turn

- *Write it*: ع — the open curve, then the bowl beneath
- *Say it*: the sound, from the throat — as in *ʿalaykum*
- *Say it*: the family — “*ʿayn* ع, and *ghayn* غ = the same shape **plus one dot**”
- *Say it*: “*ʿayin* = **eye** → the Greeks made it **O**”

Before you move on

Describe ع’s two pieces. (An **open-mouth curve** on top, a **bowl** below when isolated or final.) What did Phoenician *ʿayin* mean, and what letter did the Greeks turn it into? (“**Eye**”; they had no such sound, so they made it the vowel **O**.) Which letter shares its skeleton? (غ *ghayn* — one dot above.) Next: ه and the feminine

ending օ.

4.2 𐤇 and օ — the loop, and the ending that means “feminine”

Two related shapes. 𐤇 ($h\bar{a}^o$) is a plain “h” — and the most **shape-shifting** letter you’ve met, wearing four genuinely different coats. Then օ, a letter built *out of* it, whose whole job is to say one grammatical thing: **this word is feminine**.

Script — 𐤇 ($h\bar{a}^o$) — the loop that never looks the same

Break it apart — there is really just *one piece*:

1. **the loop** — a closed round body.

But that loop **changes shape a lot by position** more than any letter so far: standing alone it’s a neat circle-ish loop; at the start it opens out; in the middle it becomes a small figure-of-eight pinched in the centre; at the end it trails. Same letter, four faces — the four-coats rule from Lesson 2 taken to its extreme.

From Phoenician **hē** — the ancestor of Greek *epsilon* and Latin **E**. (Another one for the family tree: $^a\bar{a}lep \rightarrow A$, $b\bar{e}t \rightarrow B$, $h\bar{e} \rightarrow \mathbf{E}$, $mem \rightarrow M$, $^c\bar{a}yin \rightarrow O$.)

Script — օ ($t\bar{a}^o$ marbūṭa) — the “tied $t\bar{a}^o$ ”

Now look carefully at this:

- 𐤇 = $h\bar{a}^o$ ’s loop, **no dots**.
- օ = **the same loop** + $t\bar{a}^o$ ’s **two dots above**.

Its name says exactly what it is: **$t\bar{a}^o$ marbūṭa**, “the **tied-up $t\bar{a}^o$** ” — a 𐤈 ($t\bar{a}^o$, Lesson 4) whose ends have been **tied into a loop**. It appears **only at the end of a word**, and it is the standard mark of a **feminine** noun or adjective.

You already know its partner: back in Lesson 4 you learned 𐤈 with **two dots above**. Put those same two dots on a $h\bar{a}^o$ loop and you get

the feminine ending. Nothing new to memorise — just two known pieces combined.

Where you’ve seen it: the farewell مع السلامة (*ma^ca s-salāma*) ends in ð — *salāma* is feminine. That’s the next lesson.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ه — the loop; then try it isolated and final, feel it change
- *Write it:* ð — the same loop, **plus tāʾ’s two dots above**
- *Say it:* the name — “*tāʾ marbūṭa*, the **tied tāʾ** — it marks the feminine”
- *Say it:* “*hē* → Greek epsilon → Latin **E**”

Before you move on

What makes ه unusual among the letters you’ve learned? (Its **loop changes shape** dramatically by position — four very different coats.) What is ð made of, and what does its name mean? (*hāʾ*’s loop + **tāʾ’s two dots**; “**tied tāʾ**”.) What does ð tell you about a word, and where can it appear? (That it is **feminine**; only at the **end**.) Next: assembling the farewell مع السلامة.

4.3 مع السلامة — the goodbye, and a word you already know

The closing move. مع السلامة (*ma^ca s-salāma*) is how Arabic says goodbye — literally “**with safety**,” *go in peace*. And the heart of it is a word you wrote **all the way back in Lesson 3**: سلام. Everything since has been leading here.

Script — Part 1 — مع (ma^ca, “with”)

Two letters, both known:

1. م (*mīm*, Lesson 3) — round head, joining left into...
 2. ع (*ʿayn*, Lesson 10) — the open curve over its bowl, closing the word.
- مع = ma^ca, “with.”

Script — Part 2 — السلامة (as-salāma, “the safety”)

Look at what this is made of:

- ال — the **al-** (“the”), *alif* + *lām*, both from Lessons 1–2. You’ve read it since Chapter 1 in خيرال and عليكم سلامال.
- سلام — **the exact word you assembled in Lesson 3:** *sīn* · *lām* · *alif* · *mīm*.
- ة — the *tāʾ marbūṭa* from Lesson 11, marking *salāma* as **feminine**.

So السلامة = *al-* + *salām* + *-a*. You are not learning a new word; you are **adding two edges** to one you already own.

Script — The root s-l-m, one more time

salām, *salāma*, *islām*, *muslim* — all from the Semitic root **s-l-m**, “peace, safety, wholeness.” The greeting you learned first (عليكم السلام, “peace be upon you”) and the farewell you learn last (السلامة مع, “with safety”) come from the **same three consonants**. Arabic opens and closes a conversation with one idea.

Script — Assemble it — right to left

1. م then ع → مع
 2. lift; ا + ل (the *al-*), the *lām* joining into...
 3. س · ل · ا — and remember the لا ligature, and that *alif* **breaks**...
 4. م, then ة to close.
- السلامة مع

Your turn

- *Write it:* مع — *mīm* into ʿayn
- *Write it:* السلامة — “the *al-*, then your Lesson-3 word, then the feminine ة”
- *Say it:* “maʿa s-salāma — **with safety**”
- *Say it:* the bookend — “عليكم السلام to greet, السلامة مع to part — same root **s-l-m**”

Before you move on

What does مع السلامة literally mean? (“**With safety.**”) Which earlier word sits inside السلامة, and what was added? (سلام from Lesson 3 — plus ال in front and ة behind.) What does the final ة signal? (*salāma* is **feminine**.) What root ties the first greeting to the last farewell? (**s-l-m** — peace/safety.) You can now hand-write an Arabic conversation from hello to goodbye.

4.4 مع (*ma^ca*) — “with”

Two letters, both already yours, and a word that will carry the whole chapter.

You’ll want to know — The letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) م (*mīm*) from Lesson 3 of the writing set, and ع (*‘ayn*) from Lesson 10 — the throat sound whose Phoenician ancestor meant “**eye**,” and which the Greeks recycled into the vowel **O**.

Right to left: م · ع → *ma^ca*. The *‘ayn* is not a vowel; it is a constriction deep in the throat. Take your time with it.

You’ll want to know — The word

مع (*ma^ca*) = “**with**, together with.”

It is a **preposition**, and unlike ال (*al-*) or ب (*bi-*) from Chapter 3, it is a **free-standing word** — it does not glue onto the next one. Compare:

	attaches?
ال <i>al-</i> “the”	yes
ب <i>bi-</i> “in/with”	yes
ل <i>li-</i> “to”	yes
مع <i>ma^ca</i> “with”	no

So Arabic has *two* words touching on “with”: the one-letter ب (*bi-*, “in/ by means of,” as in *bi-khayr*) and the full word مع (*ma^ca*, “accompanied by”). *Bi-khayr* is “**in** goodness”; *ma^ca* is standing **next to** something.

Why it's said this way

$ma^a \leftarrow$ Semitic $^{*c}imma$, and its Hebrew cousin is **עִם** (^{c}im), “with.” The same pairing you met with **salām** / **shalom** in Chapter 1 and **ism** / **shem** in Chapter 2. Three chapters, three cousins — the family resemblance is systematic, not a coincidence.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “ ma^a ” — the ^{c}ayn from the throat
- *Say it*: the contrast — “*bi-khayr* **in** goodness · ma^a **with**”
- *Say it*: the cousin — “ ma^a · Hebrew ^{c}im ”
- *Write it*: **مع** — $mīm$ joining into ^{c}ayn

Before you move on

What does **مع** mean? (“**With.**”) Does it attach to the next word, like *al-* and *bi-*? (**No** — it stands alone.) What is the difference between *bi-* and ma^a ? (*Bi-* = “**in**/by means of”; ma^a = “**accompanied by**.”) What is its Hebrew cousin? (^{c}im .) Next: the word it goes with — and you already know most of it.

4.5 السلامة (as-salāma) — “the safety”

This looks like a long new word. It isn’t. It is **one word you learned in Chapter 1** with a piece added at each end.

You’ll want to know — Taking it apart

piece	what it is	met in
ال	<i>al-</i> , “the”	Ch. 1
سلام	<i>salām</i> , “peace”	Ch. 1 — the very first word
ة	<i>tā^o marbūṭa</i> , feminine ending	writing Lesson 11

→ السلامة = *al-* + *salām* + *-a* = “**the safety.**”

Every letter is one you have already written by hand.

You'll want to know — The pattern that changed the meaning

Arabic doesn't just add endings — it pours a root into a **shape**. Here the root **s-l-m** goes into the pattern *fa^cāla*, which turns a thing into **the state of being that thing**:

word	meaning
salām	peace
salāma	safety, soundness, wellbeing — <i>the state of being at peace</i>

Same three consonants, one new shape, a new but related word. This is the engine Chapter 1 promised, working in front of you.

You'll want to know — Two small rules, both already learned

1. The sun letter. *S* (س) is a **sun letter**, so the *l* of *al-* assimilates to it: written الس, but said **as-salāma**, not *al-salāma*. The same thing happens in عليكم لام الس — the greeting you have said since Chapter 1.

2. The feminine ة. *Tā^o marbūṭa* marks *salāma* as **feminine**. Arabic abstract nouns very often are.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “as-salāma” — with the doubled *s*, not *al-s*
- *Say it:* the build — “salām ... salāma ... as-salāma”
- *Say it:* the pattern — “peace → **the state of** peace”
- *Write it:* السلامة

Before you move on

What three pieces make السلامة? (*al-* + **salām** + ة.) What did the *fa^cāla* pattern do to the meaning? (Turned “peace” into “**the state of** being at peace” — safety.) Why is it *as-salāma* and not *al-salāma*? (س is a **sun letter**; the *l* assimilates.) What does the ة tell you? (The word is **feminine**.) Next: put *ma^ca* in front of it.

4.6 السلامة مع (ma^ca s-salāma) — “goodbye”

Put the last two lessons together and the farewell falls out. You have already **hand-written** this phrase; now it means something.

You’ll want to know — The assembly

مع (ma^ca, “with”) + السلامة (as-salāma, “the safety”) → السلامة مع
— “**with safety**.”

Said as one run: ma^ca s-salāma — the *a* of ma^ca swallows the *al*’s vowel, and the sun-letter rule doubles the *s*.

It is not “goodbye” in the English sense of a plain sign-off. It is a **wish**: *go in safety*.

You’ll want to know — The circle closes

Look at what Chapter 1 opened with and what Chapter 4 closes with:

	phrase	root
first greeting	عليكم السلام as-salāmu ^c alaykum	s-l-m
last farewell	مع السلامة ma ^c a s-salāma	s-l-m

The same three consonants. Arabic begins and ends a conversation with one idea — peace, safety, wholeness. The root engine you met in the very first lesson has been running the whole time; here it simply comes back round.

The family, one more time: *salām* (peace), *salāma* (safety), *islām* (submission, i.e. entering peace), *muslim* (one who does so).

You’ll want to know — English does the same trick

Goodbye looks like a single word. It is worn down from *God be with ye*. So the English farewell is also built on “**with**” — you are being commended to something protective as you go.

language	farewell	literally
Arabic	<i>ma^ʿa s-salāma</i>	“ with safety”
English	<i>goodbye</i>	“God be with ye”
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God”

Four languages, one instinct: as someone leaves, hand them over to safekeeping.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ma^ʿa s-salāma*”
- the bookend — “*as-salāmu ʿalaykum ... ma^ʿa s-salāma*”
- the root aloud — “**s · l · m**”
- “goodbye ← God be **with** ye”

Before you move on

What does **مع السلامة** literally mean? (“**With safety.**”) What root is it built on, and where have you met that root before? (**s-l-m** — the Chapter 1 greeting *as-salāmu ʿalaykum*, and *salām* itself.) So what does Arabic open and close a conversation with? (**The same idea** — peace/safety.) What is English *goodbye* worn down from? (“**God be with ye.**”) Next: a second farewell, and a word Spanish borrowed.

4.7 اللقاء إلى (ilā l-liqāʾ) — “see you”

The other everyday farewell — and the one with a surprise waiting inside Spanish.

You’ll want to know — A note on the letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Two pieces here are **beyond what the writing track has covered**, so read them for now and draw them later:

- ق (*qāf*) — a *k* made far back against the soft palate, deeper than ك (*kāf*). It is **not** in the letter set you have been writing from.
- ا in إ — this is *alif maqṣūra*, “shortened alif”: it wears **yāʾ’s skeleton with no dots** and is pronounced as a long *ā*. You already know from writing Lessons 4–5 that dots are what separate letters sharing a body; this is that same principle, taken one step further.

The rest — ا ل ء — you have written.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces

piece	meaning
إلى <i>ilā</i>	“to, until”
اللقاء <i>al-liqāʾ</i>	“the meeting”

→ اللقاء إلى = “**until the meeting.**”

لقاء (*liqāʾ*) comes from the root **l-q-y**, “**to meet.**” The final ء is the *hamza* from writing Lesson 6 — a glottal stop, a real consonant here, not decoration.

Note ل is a sun letter too, so *al-liqāʾ* doubles the *l*, just as *as-salāma* doubled the *s*.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish says goodbye like this:

hasta luego — “**until** later” *hasta mañana* — “**until** tomorrow”

Same shape as *ilā l-liqāʾ*: “**until**” + **a future point**. But it goes further — Spanish ***hasta*** is itself an **Arabic loanword**, from ***ḥattā*** (“until”). Of the roughly four thousand Arabic words Spanish took during the eight centuries of al-Andalus, most are nouns; *hasta* is one of the rare borrowed **function words**.

So Spanish did not merely copy the pattern — it borrowed the very word that builds it.

language	farewell	shape
Arabic	<i>ilā l-liqāʿ</i>	until + the meeting
Spanish	<i>hasta luego</i>	until (← <i>ḥattā</i>) + later
French	<i>à bientôt</i>	to + soon
Italian	<i>a presto</i>	to + soon

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ilā l-liqāʿ*” — double the *l*
- the two farewells — “*maʿa s-salāma · ilā l-liqāʿ*”
- the loan — “*hasta* ← *ḥattā*”
- the root — “**l · q · y** — to meet”

Before you move on

What does إلقاء literally say? (“**Until the meeting.**”) What root is *liqāʿ* from? (**l-q-y**, “to meet”.) Which two letters here has the writing track **not** reached? (ق *qāf*, and ع *alif maqṣūra*.) What is *alif maqṣūra*? (**Yāʿ’s body with no dots**, pronounced long *ā*.) Which Spanish word for “until” came from Arabic? (***Hasta*** ← *ḥattā*.) Next: practise the whole conversation, hello to goodbye.

4.8 Practice — the whole conversation

Four chapters. Greet, introduce, ask after someone, part. Here it all is in one piece.

You'll want to know — The full exchange

	Arabic	literally
A	عليكم السلام (<i>as-salāmu</i> <i>‘alaykum</i>)	peace [be] upon you
B	السلام وعليكم (<i>wa-‘alaykum</i> <i>as-salām</i>)	and upon you, peace
A	ما اسمك؟ (<i>mā ismuka?</i>)	what [is] your name?
B	تشرفنا ...، اسمي (<i>ismī</i> <i>..., tasharrafnā</i>)	my name [is] ..., we are honoured
A	كيف حالك؟ (<i>kayfa</i> <i>ḥāluka?</i>)	how [is] your state?
B	بخير لله، الحمد (<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh,</i> <i>bi-khayr</i>)	the praise [is] to God — in goodness
A	مع السلامة (<i>ma‘a</i> <i>s-salāma</i>)	with safety
B	إلى اللقاء (<i>ilā l-liqā‘</i> ²)	until the meeting

Read the right-hand column top to bottom. **Not one line contains a verb “to be.”** The zero copula has held for four chapters.

Why it's said this way

Everything you have learned sits on a handful of three-consonant roots:

root	meaning	words you know
s-l-m	peace, safety	<i>salām, as-salāmu</i> <i>‘alaykum, salāma,</i> <i>ma‘a s-salāma</i>
s-m-w	name	<i>ism, ismī, ismuka</i>
ḥ-w-l	to turn	<i>ḥāl, kayfa ḥāluka</i>
kh-y-r	good	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr,</i> <i>bi-khayr</i>
ḥ-m-d	to praise	<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh,</i> <i>Muḥammad</i>
l-q-y	to meet	<i>liqā‘², ilā l-liqā‘²</i>

Six roots. A whole conversation.

Grammar Lens — The small attaching pieces

piece	job	example
ال <i>al-</i>	the	<i>al-khayr</i>
بـ <i>bi-</i>	in / by	<i>bi-khayr</i>
لـ <i>li-</i>	to	<i>lillāh</i>
يـ <i>-ī</i>	my	<i>ismī</i>
كـ <i>-ka / -ki</i>	your (m./f.)	<i>ismuka, ḥāluki</i>

And مع *ma^ca*, the one that **doesn't** attach.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the full dialogue, both parts, addressing a **man**
- *Say it*: it again to a **woman** — every *-ka* becomes *-ki*
- *Write it*: السلامة مع — every letter is one you have drawn
- *Say it*: the bookend — “السلام to open, السلامة to close”

Before you move on

Give a complete greeting-to-farewell exchange. (The dialogue above.) Which root opens **and** closes it? (**s-l-m**.) Which piece of the chapter doesn't glue onto the next word? (مع *ma^ca*.) What single word is absent from every literal translation? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Which Spanish word came from Arabic *ḥattā*? (**Hasta**.) You can now hold — and hand-write — a short Arabic conversation from beginning to end.

Chapter 5

Yes and No

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer a question in Arabic with na^cam or lā, and write lā as the single joined lām-alif shape.

Say the yes/no pair and form lā as one lām-alif ligature rather than two separate letters.

5.1 نعم (na^cam) — yes

A short word to mean yes — with one sound English simply doesn't have.

You'll want to know — The word

نعم = yes, said na^cam. Arabic reads **right to left**, so its three letters run:

ن (n) · ع (c) · م (m) → na-^ca-m

The middle letter ع is the famous ^cayn — a *pharyngeal* sound made deep in the throat, a tight squeeze with no English equivalent. Don't worry about mastering it today; just know that the little apostrophe-like mark in na^cam (the ^c) is standing in for a real, throaty consonant, not a pause.

You'll want to know — Saying yes, and other ways

na^cam is the clear, standard **yes** — polite and safe anywhere. Two neighbours you'll also hear:

- أَجَل (*ajal*) — a more formal, emphatic “yes, indeed.”
- In everyday speech, many dialects say أَيُّوَة (*aywa*) for a casual “yeah.”

And a useful twist: said as a question, **na^cam?** also means “**pardon?** / **you were saying?**” — the same stretch English gives “yes?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “na^cam” — feel the ع squeeze in the middle of the throat
- right to left — م · ع · ن
- as a question — “na^cam?” = “pardon?”

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Arabic? (**na^cam**, نَعَمْ.) Which way does the script run? (**Right to left.**) What is the ع in the middle — a pause or a sound? (A **sound** — the throaty *‘ayn*, with no English match.) What does *na^cam?* mean when you say it as a question? (“**Pardon?**”)

5.2 ل (lā) — no

Two letters, one long vowel — and one of the most recognisable words in the language.

You’ll want to know — The word

ل = **no**, said **lā** (a long *aah*). It’s just two letters — ل (l) + ا (the long *ā*, *alif*) — but they’re written joined into one sweeping shape, ل, a *lam-alif* that Arabic always writes as a single unit. It’s one of the first letter-joins learners recognise on sight.

You’ll want to know — More than an answer

lā isn’t only the reply “no.” It is Arabic’s great word of **negation**, and it opens the most-spoken sentence in the language — the first half of the *shahada*:

الله إلا إله لا — *lā ilāha illā llāh* — “**There is no** god but God.”

That opening **lā** is your word. The same *lā* also negates present-tense verbs — أعرف لا *lā aʿrif*, “I do **not** know” — so, like Spanish *no*, one little word is both the answer “no” and the sentence’s “not.”

Grammar Lens — Yes and no, together

You now have the pair:

	Arabic	said
yes	نعم	<i>naʿam</i>
no	لا	<i>lā</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lā” — a long, open *aah*
- the join — ج + ل written as one, لا
- the pair — “naʿam / lā”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Arabic? (**lā**, لا.) What two letters make it, and how are they written? (ج + ل, joined as a single *lam-alif* لا.) Which famous sentence does *lā* open? (The *shahada* — *lā ilāha illā llāh*.) Besides “no,” what job does *lā* do? (It **negates verbs** — *lā aʿrif*, “I don’t know.”)

Chapter 6

Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can attach *min faḍlik* to a request in Arabic and change its ending for a man or a woman.

Say min faḍlik with the heavy dād, take it apart as 'from your grace', and offer law samaḥt as the alternative.

6.1 فضلك من (min faḍlik) — please

Arabic doesn't say "please" — it asks for something *from your grace*.

You'll want to know — The phrase

فضلك من — read right to left, **min faḍlik** — is two pieces:

من (*min*, "from") + فضلك (*faḍl* + *-ik/-ak*, "your grace/bounty")
→ "from your grace."

faḍl is a warm, weighty word — "grace, favour, bounty, generosity" (you'll meet it as the name *Faḍl*). Saying *min faḍlik* casts the request as drawing on the other person's generosity — not a command, a courtesy.

Grammar Lens — A gender note (Arabic marks "you")

The ending changes with **whom you address** — and, unwritten, only the vowel moves:

- to a **woman**: *min faḍlik* (the ل said *-ik*)
- to a **man**: *min faḍlak* (the ل said *-ak*)

The spelling فضلك is the same for both; the short vowel that distinguishes them isn't normally written. One sound to respect: the ض (*ḍ*) is an **emphatic** d, said with a heavier, deeper tongue than a plain *d*.

You'll want to know — Another everyday “please”

Just as common, especially getting someone's attention:

لو سمحت — *law samaḥt* — literally “**if you permit**” (*law* “if” + *samaḥt* “you permitted”). Same politeness, a different image — permission rather than grace.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “min faḍlik” — feel the heavy ض
- taken apart — “from your grace”
- the alternative — “law samaḥt” = “if you permit”

Before you move on

How do you say please in Arabic? (**min faḍlik**, فضلك من.) What does it literally mean? (“**From your grace**” — *faḍl* = grace/bounty.) What changes between saying it to a man vs a woman? (The ل ending — *-ak* to a man, *-ik* to a woman; spelling unchanged.) What's the other common “please,” and what does it mean? (**law samaḥt** — “if you permit.”)

Chapter 7

Sorry

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Arabic with *āsif* or *āsifa*, choosing the form that matches who is speaking.

Say the apology twice – āsif for a man, āsifa for a woman – then the ungendered ma^cdhira.

7.1 آسف / آسفة (āsif / āsifa) — sorry

You already know *من فضلك*, “please.” Arabic’s word for “sorry” teaches a new lesson entirely: it isn’t a fixed word at all — **it changes with the speaker.**

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

آسف (*āsif*, said by a man) and آسفة (*āsifa*, said by a woman) both mean “**sorry**.” They come from the verb أَصَفَّ (*asifa*), “to grieve, to be filled with regret” — so saying *āsif* is describing yourself as *grieved* / *regretful*, the way you’d say “I am tired” or “I am happy.”

That’s the key: آسف **is an adjective**, and Arabic adjectives **agree with the gender of the person they describe**. A man says آسف; a woman says آسفة — the extra *ṣ* (*tā² marbūṭa*) is the everyday feminine ending you’ll meet across Arabic adjectives. English “sorry” never changes no matter who says it; Arabic “sorry” always tells you the speaker’s gender in the same breath.

Why it's said this way

For a quick, **ungendered** “excuse me / pardon” — squeezing past someone, interrupting, a light apology — Arabic reaches for معذرة (*ma^cdhira*), from the root ر-ذ-ع (“to excuse”), the same root as عذر (*‘udhr*, “an excuse”) and the verb يعتذر (*ya^ctadhiru*, “to apologize”). Unlike *āsif/āsifa*, معذرة **doesn’t change with gender** — it’s a noun, not an adjective, so anyone says the same word. Use أسف/آسفة when you mean a real, felt “I’m sorry” (and remember to match your own gender); reach for معذرة for the light, everyday “pardon me.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a man says — “*āsif*”
- a woman says — “*āsifa*”
- the ungendered one — “*ma^cdhira*” = excuse me / pardon

Before you move on

What’s unusual about أسف / آسفة compared to English “sorry”? (**It’s a gendered adjective** — *āsif* for a man, *āsifa* for a woman — where English never changes.) What root gives *āsif*, and what does it mean? (أسف *asafa*, “to grieve, regret.”) What’s the ungendered word for a quick “excuse me,” and what root is it from? (معذرة *ma^cdhira*, from ر-ذ-ع “to excuse.”)

Chapter 8

Days of the Week

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ⇐ eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name any day of the Arabic week and say which two days break the counting pattern.

Name al-jumʿa and as-sabt beside the counted days, and place as-sabt next to Hebrew shabbāt.

8.1 الأحد to الخميس (al-aḥad to al-khamīs) — Sunday to Thursday, by the numbers

Most European and North Indian languages name their weekdays for planet-gods. Arabic does something completely different: it just **counts** them.

Grammar Lens — The pattern: definite article + ordinal number

Five of Arabic’s seven days are simply “**the [number]th**” — the definite article ال (*al-*) plus an ordinal built on the number word:

Arabic	literally	from the number	day
الأحد (<i>al-aḥad</i>)	“the first ”	<i>wāḥid</i> , “one”	Sunday
الاثنين (<i>al-ithnayn</i>)	“the second ” (lit. “the two”)	<i>ithnān</i> , “two”	Monday
الثلاثاء (<i>ath-thulāthāʿ</i>)	“the third ”	<i>thalātha</i> , “three”	Tuesday
الأربعاء (<i>al-arbiʿāʿ</i>)	“the fourth ”	<i>arbaʿa</i> , “four”	Wednesday
الخميس (<i>al-khamīs</i>)	“the fifth ”	<i>khamṣa</i> , “five”	Thursday

No moon, no war-god, no planets at all — just **day one, day two, day three...** This also tells you something about the week itself: counting starts from **Sunday**, so Sunday is “day one” — the Arabic week, like the Jewish and much of the Christian calendar tradition, begins where the European Monday-first convention doesn’t.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “al-aḥad” — the first, Sunday
- count up — “al-ithnayn, ath-thulāthāʿ, al-arbiʿāʿ, al-khamīs” — second through fifth
- contrast — no planet-gods here, just numbers

Before you move on

How does Arabic name Sunday through Thursday? (**As ordinal numbers** — “the first” through “the fifth,” not planet-gods.) Which number is Sunday, and what does that tell you about the week? (“**The first**” — the Arabic week counts starting from **Sunday**.) What Arabic prefix turns a number into “the [x]th day”? (ال *al*-, the definite article.)

8.2 الجمعة and السبت (al-jum^a, as-sabt) — Friday and Saturday

Five days counted off — and then two days important enough to get **real names** instead of numbers.

You'll want to know — The two named days

- الجمعة (*al-jum^a*) = “**the gathering**,” from جمع (*jama^a*), “to gather, collect.” This is the day of the congregational Friday prayer (*ṣalāt al-jum^a*) — the most religiously significant day of the Islamic week, and important enough to earn its own name rather than a number.
- السبت (*as-sabt*) = “**the Sabbath**.”

You'll want to know — Be honest about how السبت differs from Latin's *Sabbatum*

You may remember Latin borrowed the word **Sabbatum** from Hebrew to replace its own pagan *diēs Saturnī* — a loanword crossing from a Semitic language into an Italic one. Arabic's سبت (*sabt*) is a different kind of relationship entirely: Arabic is **itself a Semitic language**, in the same family as Hebrew. So **as-sabt and Hebrew shabbāt aren't borrower-and-lender — they're cousins**, both descending from the same ancient Semitic root س-ب-ت meaning “to rest, to cease.” Where Latin **borrowed** a foreign word, Arabic simply **inherited** a family word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “al-jum^a” — the gathering, Friday
- “as-sabt” — the Sabbath, Saturday
- the contrast — Latin borrowed “Sabbatum”; Arabic's “sabt” is a blood relative of Hebrew “shabbāt”

Before you move on

Why does الجمعة break the counting pattern? (**It's named for the congregational Friday prayer** — “the gathering” — not counted

as a number.) How is Arabic's السبت different from Latin's borrowed **Sabbatum**? (**Arabic and Hebrew are both Semitic languages** — *as-sabt* and *shabbāt* are **cousins** from a shared root, not a loanword crossing between unrelated language families.)

Chapter 9

Four Core Colours

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🙌 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Arabic and give each colour’s feminine form.

Run the four colours in the masculine, then again in the feminine – ḥamrāʾ, zarqāʾ – on the same template.

9.1 أسود / أبيض (aswad / abyad) — black and white, a whole new gender pattern

You’ve already met a gendered adjective — آسفة/أسف (“sorry”), which just added a feminine ending. Color words go further: they reshape the **whole word**, front and back, for gender.

Grammar Lens — The pattern: masculine إ--- / feminine ---اء

- أسود (aswad, masculine) / سوداء (sawdāʾ, feminine) — “**black**”
- أبيض (abyad, masculine) / بيضاء (bayḍāʾ, feminine) — “**white**”

Notice the shape: the masculine form **starts** with إ (a hamza-alif), and the feminine form **drops** that opening letter but **adds** -اء (-āʾ) at the end instead. This isn’t the simple “add one letter” pattern āsif/ āsifa used — it’s a **dedicated template** Arabic reserves specifically for **colors and physical characteristics** (this same shape appears again for red and blue in the next lesson).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- masculine — “aswad, abyad” — black, white
- feminine — “sawdāʾ, baydāʾ” — black, white
- notice the shape — إ--- drops, ---اء appears

Before you move on

What’s the masculine/feminine pair for black? (أسود **aswad** / سوداء **sawdāʾ**.) For white? (أبيض **abyad** / بيضاء **baydāʾ**.) How is this gender-shape different from *āsif/āsifa*? (**It reshapes the whole word** — losing the opening أ and gaining a closing -اء — a template reserved for colors and physical traits, not just adding a simple ending.)

9.2 أزرق / أحمر (ahmar / azraq) — red and blue, the same template again

Two more colors — and the exact same shape you just learned.

Grammar Lens — The pattern holds

- أحمر (*aḥmar*, masculine) / حمراء (*ḥamrāʾ*, feminine) — “**red**”
- أزرق (*azraq*, masculine) / زرقاء (*zarqāʾ*, feminine) — “**blue**”

Same recipe every time: masculine opens with إ, feminine drops that opening and closes with -اء instead. Once you’ve internalized this template from black and white, the whole family of **classic, old** Arabic colors slots into it (yellow أصفر/صفراء, green أخضر/خضراء, too) — one pattern, several colors. (Newer colors like brown, gray, purple, orange, and pink use a **different** pattern entirely, borrowed from nouns — so “every color” would overstate it; this template belongs specifically to Arabic’s oldest, core color set.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- masculine — “aḥmar, azraq” — red, blue
- feminine — “ḥamrāʾ, zarqāʾ” — red, blue
- all four masculine forms in a row — “aswad, abyad, aḥmar, azraq”

Before you move on

What’s the masculine/feminine pair for red? (أحمر **aḥmar** / حمراء **ḥamrāʾ**.) For blue? (أزرق **azraq** / زرقاء **zarqāʾ**.) Does every Arabic color use this same template? (**No** — Arabic’s classic, oldest colors (black, white, red, blue, yellow, green) share **one** template, masc. ا--- / fem. ---اء; newer colors like brown or purple use a different, noun-based pattern instead.)

Chapter 10

Family

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my father, mother, brother and sister in Arabic.

Say akh and ukht, show how ukht is built from the same root plus a feminine -t, and place both beside their Hebrew cousins.

10.1 أب, أم (ab, umm) — father and mother

Two short, ancient words — each just two or three letters — sitting at the root of Semitic family vocabulary across several languages, not just Arabic.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

- أب (*ab*) = “**father**.” A short, ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew אב (*av*) and Aramaic אבא (*abba*) — the very word behind “**Abba, Father**” in the New Testament.
- أم (*umm*) = “**mother**.” Equally ancient, cousin of Hebrew אם (*em*).

These aren’t borrowings between Arabic and Hebrew — both descend from the same ancient Semitic family vocabulary, the way *pater* and English *father* are cousins through PIE rather than one copying the other.

Why it's said this way

أم stays productive in everyday Arabic naming: أم + a child's name forms a **kunya**, an honorific “**mother of** _____” (and أبو, *abū*, does the same for fathers — “**father of** _____”). Someone might be known publicly as *Umm Khālīd*, “mother of Khālīd,” rather than by their own given name — a naming custom still very much alive today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ab” — father — then “umm,” mother
- the Hebrew cousins — “ab/av, umm/em”
- the naming pattern — “Umm + [child's name]” = mother of _____

Before you move on

What are Arabic's words for father and mother? (أب **ab**, أم **umm**.) What are their Hebrew cousins? (**av**, **em** — not borrowings, both from the same ancient Semitic root.) What naming pattern does **umm** still form today? (**Umm** + [child's name], “mother of _____,” a living honorific.)

10.2 أخ, أخت (akh, ukht) — brother and sister

Unlike the color words you just learned (a whole reshaped template for masculine/feminine), siblings here use the **simplest** possible gender marker.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

- أخ (*akh*) = “**brother**” — another short, ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew אָח (*ach*).
- أخت (*ukht*) = “**sister**” — the **same root**, plus a plain feminine -ت (-*t*) ending, cousin of Hebrew אחות (*achot*).

So *ukht* isn't a separate word — it's *akh* wearing the ordinary feminine

ending, the simple pattern you already know from آسف/أسفة (*āsif/āsifa*, “sorry”), not the elaborate colors template.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akh” — brother — then “ukht,” sister
- the shared root plus a simple ending — akh + -t
- the Hebrew cousins — “akh/ach, ukht/achot”

Before you move on

What are Arabic’s words for brother and sister? (أخ **akh**, أخت **ukht**.) How is *ukht* built from *akh*? (**The same root, plus a plain feminine -ت ending** — the simple pattern, not the colors’ elaborate template.) What are their Hebrew cousins? (**ach, achot**.)

Chapter 11

Head and Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Arabic.

Say yad, set it against its near-identical Hebrew twin, and contrast how much further raʾs drifted.

11.1 رأس (raʾs) — the head

One more ancient Semitic root — and a word still hard at work in modern political vocabulary, the same way Latin’s *caput* is in English.

You’ll want to know — The word

رأس (raʾs) = “head” — an ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew ראש (rosh), the very word inside **Rosh Hashanah**, “head of the year.”

Why it’s said this way

Arabic builds رئيس (raʾīs), “**president, chief, head [of an organization]**,” directly on this same root — literally “the one who is the head.” That’s exactly the move English makes with Latin *caput*: **captain** (“head” of a unit), **capital** (“head” city). Different language families, the same very human idea — the person or place “at the head” is the one in charge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “raʿs” — head
- “raʿīs” — president, literally “the head [one]”
- the Hebrew cousin — “raʿs / rosh”

Before you move on

What does رأس mean, and what’s its Hebrew cousin? (“**Head**” — cousin of **rosh**, as in Rosh Hashanah.) What word is built on it for “president,” and what does it literally mean? (رئيس *raʿīs*, “the head [one]” — the same “head = leader” idea as English *captain/capital* from Latin *caput*.)

11.2 يد (yad) — the hand

Some words wear their age lightly — worn down, reshaped, disguised. This one hasn’t changed much at all.

You’ll want to know — The word

يد (*yad*) = “**hand**” — a short, ancient Semitic root. Its Hebrew cousin is spelled and pronounced almost **identically**: יד (*yad*). Where *raʿs/rosh* show a family resemblance, *yad/yad* is closer to twins — one of the more strikingly unchanged shared words across the whole Semitic family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yad” — hand
- the Hebrew twin — “yad” — almost the same word
- contrast — “raʿs/rosh” changed more than “yad/yad” did

Before you move on

What does يد mean? (“**Hand.**”) How does it compare to its Hebrew cousin? (**Nearly identical** — both *yad* — one of the more strikingly unchanged shared words across the Semitic family.)

Chapter 12

Seasons

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Arabic and say why the Islamic months do not stay inside them.

*Say *rabīʿ*, *ṣayf*, *kharīf*, *shitāʾ*, then explain the lunar calendar’s drift against the solar seasons.*

12.1 ربيع, صيف, خريف, شتاء — the four seasons

Four words for the turning year — and a genuine reminder that the tidy four-season picture is a **temperate-climate** habit of mind, not a universal one.

You’ll want to know — The four seasons

Arabic	meaning
ربيع (<i>rabīʿ</i>)	spring
صيف (<i>ṣayf</i>)	summer
خريف (<i>kharīf</i>)	autumn
شتاء (<i>shitāʾ</i>)	winter

Why it’s said this way

ربيع (*rabīʿ*) does double duty: it also names **two months** of the Islamic calendar, **Rabīʿ al-Awwal** and **Rabīʿ al-Thānī** (“first/second Rabīʿ”). That’s worth pausing on, because the **Islamic calendar is lunar** — its months drift across all four solar seasons over

roughly a 33-year cycle, unmoored from any actual spring. So a month named “Rabī^c” won’t reliably fall in spring at all; the name is a fossil from an earlier calendar, kept even as the lunar calendar carried the months loose from the seasons they were once named for.

More broadly: the tidy four-season year assumes a temperate climate with four clearly distinct weather patterns. Much of the Arabic-speaking world spans very different climates — desert, Mediterranean, tropical — where a strict four-way split maps onto lived experience less cleanly than it does further north. The four words above are the standard Modern Standard Arabic vocabulary, useful and real, but not necessarily the only or most natural way every Arabic-speaking region actually experiences the year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rabī^c, ṣayf, kharīf, shitā³” — spring, summer, autumn, winter
- the calendar twist — “rabī^c” also names two Islamic months
- the honest note — lunar months drift free of the solar seasons

Before you move on

What does ربيع do besides name a season? (**Names two Islamic calendar months**, Rabī^c al-Awwal/al-Thānī.) Why don’t those months reliably fall in spring? (**The Islamic calendar is lunar** — its months drift across all four seasons over a ~33-year cycle.) Is the four-season frame equally natural everywhere Arabic is spoken? (**Not necessarily** — it fits temperate climates better than the desert/tropical/Mediterranean climates found across much of the Arabic-speaking world.)

Chapter 13

Water and Bread

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water and bread in Arabic and say which of the two sits on a regular root.

Say māʾ with its irregular plural miyāh, then khubz from the clean root kh-b-z.

13.1 ماء, خبز (māʾ, khubz) — water and bread

Two everyday words — and a study in contrasts: one of them is one of Arabic’s genuinely **oddest** common nouns, and the other is about as **regular** as a word gets.

You’ll want to know — ماء — an old, irregular word

ماء (māʾ) = “**water**.” This word is short but **irregular**: its plural (مياه, *miyāh*) and the forms it takes when attached to another noun don’t follow Arabic’s ordinary noun patterns the way most words do. Words this basic — for water, fire, blood, mouth — are often among the oldest in any language family, and old words wear their irregularities proudly; they were already worn smooth by daily use long before the grammar of the rest of the language settled into its regular patterns.

You’ll want to know — خبز — clean, regular, and freshly made

خبز (*khubz*) = “**bread**” — built cleanly on the root خ-ب-ز (*kh-b-z*), “**to bake**.” Where *māʾ* is a fossil, *khubz* is transparent: the noun for the baked

thing, straight from the verb for baking it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mā” — water — then “miyāh,” its irregular plural
- “khubz” — bread — from kh-b-z, “to bake”
- the contrast — one word is a worn-smooth fossil, the other freshly transparent

Before you move on

What’s unusual about ماء? (It’s **genuinely irregular** — its plural *miyāh* and attached forms don’t follow the ordinary pattern, typical of very old, basic words.) What root is خبز built on, and what does that root mean? (ز-ب-خ, “to bake.”)

Chapter 14

Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the months in Arabic and tell the borrowed civil calendar apart from the Islamic one.*

Say the Latin-sounding civil months, then the first Hijri months, and state what each calendar is used for.

14.1 ديسمبر to يناير — Latin names, borrowed whole, running beside a second calendar

Here’s a genuinely different kind of honesty this lesson needs: Arabic doesn’t have **one** answer to “what are the months called” — it has **two full calendars**, used for different purposes, side by side.

You’ll want to know — Gregorian months

For the everyday, civil, solar calendar, Modern Standard Arabic simply **borrow**s the familiar Latin-derived month names you already know from Spanish/French/English:

Arabic	≈
يناير (<i>yanāyir</i>)	January
فبراير (<i>fabrāyir</i>)	February
مارس (<i>māris</i>)	March
أبريل (<i>abrīl</i>)	April
مايو (<i>māyū</i>)	May
يونيو (<i>yūniyū</i>)	June
يوليو (<i>yūliyū</i>)	July
أغسطس (<i>aghustus</i>)	August
سبتمبر (<i>sibtambir</i>)	September
أكتوبر (<i>uktubar</i>)	October
نوفمبر (<i>nūfambir</i>)	November
ديسمبر (<i>dīsambir</i>)	December

You can hear the Latin (and French) originals right through the Arabic sounds — this is a straightforward, recent borrowing for civil/business use, not an ancient Arabic-invented system.

One more honest wrinkle: these Latin-derived names are the everyday convention in Egypt, the Gulf, and much pan-Arab media — but the Levant and Iraq (Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, Palestine, Iraq) traditionally use a **third**, completely different set for these same twelve solar months, of **Syriac** origin: الثاني كانون (*Kānūn al-Thānī*, January), شباط (*Shubāt*, February), آذار (*Ādhār*, March), and so on. So depending on the country, an Arabic speaker’s civil-calendar month name might come from Latin *or* from Syriac — a third naming system, not just two.

Why it’s said this way

For **religious life** — Ramadan, Hajj, and the Islamic calendar generally — Arabic uses an entirely **separate** set of month names, from the **lunar Hijri calendar**: محرم (*Muḥarram*), صفر (*Ṣafar*), ربيع (*Rabīʿ*), الثاني/الأول (*Rabīʿ al-Awwal/al-Thānī* — the very “Rabīʿ” from the seasons lesson), and eight more, none of which correspond to a fixed solar month. Because the Hijri calendar has **no leap-month correction**, these twelve lunar months drift steadily across all four solar seasons over a roughly 33-year cycle — so Ramadan, for instance, doesn’t fall in the same season every year.

Two calendars, two jobs: the borrowed Latin names for the ordinary business week, the older lunar names for religious observance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yanāyir, fabrāyir, mārīs” — January, February, March — hear the Latin
- the second calendar — “Muḥarram, Şafar, Rabī^c al-Awwal” — entirely different names
- the honest point — two calendars, two purposes, both in everyday use

Before you move on

Where do Arabic’s civil month names (*yanāyir, mārīs...*) come from? (**Borrowed Latin/European names**, recent civil-calendar loans.) What runs alongside them for religious life? (**The Hijri lunar calendar**, with its own entirely different 12 month names — *Muḥarram, Şafar, Rabī^c al-Awwal...*) Why do Hijri months drift across the seasons? (**No leap-month correction** — the lunar year is shorter than the solar year, so the calendar drifts over a ~33-year cycle.)

Chapter 15

Noon and Midnight

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Arabic and recognise *az-ẓuhr* as the name of the midday prayer.

*Say *az-ẓuhr* and *muntaṣaf al-layl*, and name the religious sense Arabic's noon carries.*

15.1 الظهر, منتصف الليل — noon and midnight

Noon in Arabic isn't just a clock-time word — it's tied directly into the rhythm of daily prayer.

You'll want to know — الظهر — noon, and a prayer

الظهر (*az-ẓuhr* or *adh-dhuhr*) = “**noon**” — from the root ز-ه-ظ (*z-h-r*), “**to appear, become visible**” (the sun standing at its highest, most visible point). Be honest about what makes this word different from Spanish's *mediodía*: الظهر **is also the name of the midday Islamic prayer**, *ṣalāt al-ẓuhr*. For a Muslim, “noon” and “time for the noon prayer” are the same word — this isn't a neutral clock-time term the way “noon” or *mediodía* are in cultures where the day isn't organized around five fixed prayer times.

You'll want to know — الليل منتصف — a transparent “half of the night”

الليل منتصف (*muntaṣaf al-layl*) = “**midnight**,” literally “**the half of the night**.” منتصف (*muntaṣaf*) comes from the root ف-ص-ن (*n-ṣ-f*), “**half**” (the

same root as نصف, *niṣf*, “a half”), and الليل (*al-layl*) is simply “**the night**.” This one is fully transparent — no erosion, no double meaning, just “the middle of the night,” structurally exactly like Latin’s *media nox*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aḏ-ḏuhr” — noon, also the midday prayer
- “muntaṣaf al-layl” — literally “the half of the night”
- the honest point — Arabic noon carries a religious meaning that mediodía doesn’t

Before you move on

What does الظهر name besides the time of day? (**The midday Islamic prayer**, *ṣalāt al-ḏuhr*.) What does الليل منتصف literally mean, and what root gives it “half”? (“**The half of the night**” — *muntaṣaf*, from ف-ص-ن *n-ṣ-f*, “half.”) Is Arabic’s word for noon a neutral clock-time word the way Spanish’s *mediodía* is? (**No** — it’s bound up with the daily prayer schedule.)

Chapter 16

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask what time it is in Arabic and answer with the hour.

Ask kam as-sāʿa? and answer with the ordinal hour, including the one-o'clock exception.

16.1 الساعة — one word for “hour,” “clock,” and “a moment”

Arabic’s word for “hour” isn’t native Arabic at all — it’s a very old borrowing, and it still carries three meanings at once.

Why it’s said this way

ساعة (*sāʿa*) = “**hour**” — but also “**clock/watch**” (as an object) and “**a while, a moment**” (as in “wait a *sāʿa*”). According to the historical linguist Theodor Nöldeke, Arabic *ساعة* was borrowed from **Aramaic** ܫܥܬܐ (*šāʿatā*) — the same Semitic root that gives Hebrew its word for hour, שעה (*šāʿā*). This borrowing happened long before Islam, deep in Arabic’s pre-Islamic contact with Aramaic-speaking communities — so unlike some of the religiously-tied vocabulary you’ve seen (like *aḏ-ḏuhr*), *sāʿa* is simply an old, everyday loanword, carrying no special religious weight.

Grammar Lens: كم الساعة؟ — “how much is the hour?”

Arabic asks the time with كم الساعة؟ (*kam as-sāʿa?*), literally “**how much/ how many is the hour**” — and answers with الساعة + an ordinal number (“the second,” “the third”...):

الثانية الساعة. — “It is two o’clock.” (literally “the hour [is] the second”) الثالثة الساعة. — “It is three o’clock.” (literally “the hour [is] the third”)

Be honest about the one exception: **one o’clock breaks this pattern**. You’d expect the ordinal *al-ūlā* (“the first”), but Arabic actually says الساعة الواحدة (*as-sāʿa al-wāḥida*) — using **al-wāḥida**, the plain **cardinal** “one,” not the ordinal. So the rule is “ordinal numbers from two o’clock onward, except one o’clock, which uses the cardinal instead” — a genuine irregularity, not a typo. This is still a different grammatical shape than Spanish’s *la una/las dos* or French’s *une heure/deux heures*, both of which use plain cardinal numbers throughout, with no ordinal/cardinal split at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāʿa” — hour, clock, or a while, depending on context
- “kam as-sāʿa?” — what time is it?
- “as-sāʿa al-thāniya” — it is two o’clock, an ordinal number
- “as-sāʿa al-wāḥida” — it is one o’clock, the one exception, using the cardinal “one” instead

Before you move on

What language did Arabic borrow ساعة from, and what Hebrew word is its cousin? (**Aramaic** *šāʿatā*; cousin of Hebrew *šāʿā*.) What three things can ساعة mean? (**Hour, clock/watch, and a while/moment**.) Does Arabic use cardinal or ordinal numbers to tell the time — and is there an exception? (**Ordinal** from two o’clock onward — “the hour is the *second*” — but **one o’clock is the exception**, using the cardinal *al-wāḥida*, “one,” instead of the

ordinal.)

Chapter 17

Asking Someone's Age

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how old someone is in Arabic and give my own age without using a verb.

Ask kam ʿumruka? and answer ʿumrī ʿishrūna sanaʾ – age as a noun you possess, no verb anywhere.

17.1 عمرک؟ کم — asking age with a noun, not a verb

You’ve seen Romance languages **have** their years, Germanic languages **be** their years, and Classical Latin itself use a third construction (“born” + accusative of duration). Arabic does something structurally different again: it doesn’t use a verb for this at all.

You’ll want to know — عمر — life, lifetime, age

عمر (*ʿumr*) = “age, lifetime, life span” — from the root ع-م-ر (*ʿ-m-r*), broadly tied to the idea of **living, dwelling, flourishing** (the same root behind the personal name ʿUmar, and words for “building, habitation”). Age in Arabic isn’t something you *have* or *are* — it’s expressed as a possessed noun: “your ʿumr,” “my ʿumr.”

Grammar Lens: **عمرک؟ کم** — no verb needed

عمرک؟ کم — “How old are you?” (to a man) — literally “**how much [is] your** *‘umr*.” (*kam ‘umruka?*) **عشرون عمري سنة.** — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**my** *‘umr* [is] twenty years.” (*‘umrī ‘ishrūna sana.*)

Notice there’s **no verb “to be” at all** in the present tense here — Arabic simply juxtaposes two nouns (“my age” / “twenty years”), exactly the way it forms ordinary present-tense sentences without *is/are*. So this is a genuinely **fourth shape** for the concept: not Romance’s “I **have** twenty years,” not Germanic’s “I **am** twenty years [old],” not Latin’s “**born** twenty years [so far],” but “**my age** [is] twenty years” — age as a possessed noun-quantity, stated without any verb at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*‘umr*” — age, lifetime, life span
- “*kam ‘umruka?*” — how old are you? (to a man)
- “*‘umrī ‘ishrūna sana*” — my age is twenty years, no verb at all

Before you move on

What does **عمر** literally mean, and what root is it from? (“**Age, lifetime**” — root **ع-م-ر**, tied to living/flourishing.) Does Arabic use a verb to state age, the way Romance (“have”), Germanic (“be”), or Latin (“born” + duration) do? (**No** — it juxtaposes “my age” and the number, with no verb needed at all.) What does **عمرک؟ کم** literally ask? (“**How much [is] your** *‘umr*?”)

Chapter 18

Weather

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what the weather is doing in Arabic – hot, cold, or raining.

Say *aṭ-ṭaqs*, then the verbless *al-jaw ḥārr* / *al-jaw bārid*, then *innahā tumṭir*, which does take a verb.

18.1 الطقس — weather and ritual, one root

Here’s an unexpected pairing: Arabic’s word for “weather” shares its root with the word for religious “rites.”

You’ll want to know — طقس — weather, and its plural means “rites”

الطقس (*aṭ-ṭaqs*) = “**the weather**” — from root س-ق-ط (*ṣ-q-s*). Its plural, طقوس (*ṭuqūs*), means “**rites, religious ceremonies, liturgy**” — the same root covering both “atmospheric conditions” and “prescribed ritual observances.” (Casual speech often prefers الجو (*al-jaw*, “the atmosphere”) instead, keeping *aṭ-ṭaqs* for more formal or written use.)

You’ll want to know — حار الجو / بارد — hot and cold, still verbless

حار الجو. — “It’s hot.” — literally “**the atmosphere [is] hot.**” (*al-jaw ḥārr*.) بارد الجو. — “It’s cold.” — literally “**the atmosphere [is] cold.**” (*al-jaw bārid*.)

Same pattern as *عمرك؟ كم* from the AGE lesson: **no verb “to be”** at all — just two nouns/adjectives sitting side by side.

You’ll want to know — *تمطر إنها* — but rain gets its OWN personal verb

تمطر إنها. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**she is raining.**” (*innahā tumṭir* — from *مطر*, *maṭar*, “rain,” the same root gives *تمطر*, *tumṭir*, “is raining.”)

Unlike *hot* and *cold*, rain isn’t a verbless adjective sentence — Arabic uses an actual **personal verb**, *tumṭir* (“is raining”), with a **feminine dummy pronoun**, *إنها* (*innahā*, “she/it”), standing in as the subject. So within Arabic’s own weather vocabulary, hot/cold stay verbless while rain gets a real, conjugated verb — echoing the same “rain behaves differently from other weather” pattern Latin shows in its dedicated *pluit*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aṭ-ṭaqṣ” — weather, same root as “ṭuqūs,” rites
- “al-jaw ḥarr. al-jaw bārid.” — it’s hot/cold, no verb
- “innahā tumṭir” — it’s raining, with an actual verb

Before you move on

What does the plural of *طقس* mean, and what’s the connection to “weather”? (*طقوس*, “**rites, religious ceremonies**” — sharing the same root.) Do *حار الجو* and *بارد الجو* use a verb? (**No** — verbless, like *kam ʿumruka?*.) Does *تمطر إنها* use a verb? (**Yes** — *tumṭir*, “is raining,” with a feminine dummy pronoun.)

Chapter 19

Numbers One to Five

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Arabic.

Count wāḥid to khamṣa, then separate the Arabic number WORDS from the Indian-origin digit shapes.

19.1 خمسة أربعة, ثلاثة, اثنان, واحد — one through five

Before the numbers themselves — an honest correction to a very common mix-up: “Arabic numerals” (the digit shapes **0**, **1**, **2**, **3**...) are **not** these words, and don’t come from Arabic at all.

You’ll want to know — خمسة, أربعة, ثلاثة, اثنان, واحد — the words

Arabic	Transliteration	Meaning
واحد	<i>wāḥid</i>	one
اثنان	<i>ithnān</i>	two
ثلاثة	<i>thalātha</i>	three
أربعة	<i>arbaʿa</i>	four
خمسة	<i>khamṣa</i>	five

These are ordinary Semitic-root Arabic words, built the same way Arabic builds any noun — nothing to do with the shapes of the digits you write.

Why it's said this way

Here's the correction: the **digit shapes 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9** that English calls “Arabic numerals” didn't originate in Arabic at all — they were invented in **India**, appearing in Indian mathematical texts and inscriptions centuries before reaching the Arab world. The 9th-century Persian mathematician **al-Khwārizmī** (whose name gives English **algorithm**) wrote an influential treatise on calculating with these **Hindu numerals**, which carried the system into the Islamic world and then, via Latin translations, into Europe. So “Arabic numerals” is really a transmission credit, not an origin credit — the shapes are Indian; only their route to Europe ran through Arabic mathematics. The **words** you're learning here (*wāḥid*, *ithnān*, *thalātha*...) are a completely separate thing: genuine, native Arabic vocabulary, unrelated to that digit-shape history.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wāḥid, ithnān, thalātha, arbaʿa, khamṣa” — one through five
- the honest correction — “Arabic numerals” (the digit SHAPES) are actually Indian in origin, not these Arabic WORDS

Before you move on

What are the Arabic words for one through five? (**wāḥid, ithnān, thalātha, arbaʿa, khamṣa.**) Where did the digit shapes 0-9 actually originate, and who's credited with carrying them to Europe? (**India** — carried into the Islamic world and then Europe largely through **al-Khwārizmī**'s writings.) Are “Arabic numerals” the same thing as these Arabic number words? (**No** — completely separate: one is a set of written digit shapes with Indian origins, the other is native Arabic vocabulary.)

Chapter 20

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Arabic and build the teens as 'X and ten'.

Build the teens as additive X-^cashar compounds, then say ^cishrūn, which is not built that way at all.

20.1 عشر أحَد، عشرون — plain compounds, then a genuinely different twenty

Eleven through fifteen build the same simple way every time. Then twenty breaks the pattern completely — it isn't built the way you'd expect at all.

You'll want to know — عشر خمسة – عشر أحَد — “X and ten”

Arabic	literally
عشر أحَد	<i>aḥada ^cashar</i> — “one-ten” (11)
عشر اثنا	<i>ithnā ^cashar</i> — “two-ten” (12)
عشر ثلاثة	<i>thalāthata ^cashar</i> — “three-ten” (13)
عشر أربعة	<i>arba^cata ^cashar</i> — “four-ten” (14)
عشر خمسة	<i>khamṣata ^cashar</i> — “five-ten” (15)

Every one of these is the counting-word (from the AGE and NUM-1-5 lessons) plus **عشر** (*‘ashar*, “**ten**”) — a straightforward additive compound, the same shape Spanish builds in *once-quince* and Latin in *ūndecim-quīndecim*.

You’ll want to know — **عشرون** — NOT “two-ten,” a genuinely different word

Here’s the honest surprise: **twenty** is **not** built from “two” + “ten” the way 11-15 were built. **عشرون** (*‘ishrūn*, “twenty”) is its **own**, distinct word — a special **plural-like form** built directly on the same “ten” root, **ع-ش-ر** (*‘sh-r*), rather than a compound of *ithnān* (“two”) and *‘ashar* (“ten”). That root, *‘ashar/‘ishrūn*, is the same Semitic “ten” root behind Hebrew’s **עֶשֶׂר** (*eser*, “ten”) — and, coincidentally, resembles the Indo-European “ten” root that gives English its own **-teen** suffix, though the two roots are **not** related: Arabic and English inherited “ten” from two entirely separate language families, so this is a parallel, not a shared borrowing or common ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aḥada *‘ashar*, *ithnā ‘ashar*, *thalāthata ‘ashar*” — 11, 12, 13, “X and ten”
- “*‘ishrūn*” — twenty, its OWN word, not “two-ten”

Before you move on

How are 11-15 built in Arabic? (**X** + **‘ashar** — “one-ten,” “two-ten,” and so on, a plain additive compound.) Is **عشرون** (twenty) built the same way, as “two-ten”? (**No** — it’s a distinct, standalone plural-like form built on the same “ten” root, not a compound of “two” and “ten.”) What root does **‘ashar/‘ishrūn** share with Hebrew? (**ע-ש-ר**/ר-ש-ע, the Semitic root for “ten,” giving Hebrew’s *eser*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Arabic.

Say kalb beside Hebrew kelev, then qitt beside Latin cattus, flagging that the cat link is still debated.

21.1 كلب, قط — a solid root, and the word that closes the loop

Spanish has a genuine dog-word mystery, and German another by way of English. Arabic’s dog-word has no such mystery — and its cat-word turns out to be a long-lost cousin of nearly every European cat-word there is.

Why it’s said this way

كلب (*kalb*, “dog”) traces to **Proto-Semitic *kalb-** — the exact same root behind **Hebrew**’s own word for dog, כָּלֵב (*kelev*) (the name **Caleb** is traditionally connected to this same root, though some scholars instead derive it from *kol-lev*, “whole-hearted”). Unlike Spanish’s *perro* or the English word that replaced “hound,” *kalb* is a solid, well-attested, unmysterious Semitic root, shared across the whole Semitic family (Aramaic, Akkadian, and more).

Why it's said this way

Here's how this whole arc most likely ties together: **قَطّ** (*qitt*, “**cat, tomcat**”) is not just a coincidence-sounding lookalike — it's widely **compared** to the exact same ancient **Afro-Asiatic** root behind Latin's **cattus** (alongside Nubian *kadis*, mentioned back in the Spanish and Latin lessons). Be honest about the uncertainty here, though: linguists don't fully agree on the relationship. Some argue *qitt* and *cattus* both descend from a **shared** ancestor; others have proposed that *kadis* (and even *qitt* itself) could be a **later** borrowing **from** Arabic rather than an independent cousin, reversing the direction. What's not in serious dispute is that Arabic's word for “cat” sits in the same tangled word-family as Spanish's *gato*, French's *chat*, Italian's *gatto*, and German's *Katze* — one root (or a tight cluster of related roots), spreading out in every direction from wherever cats were first domesticated, even if the exact family tree is still being worked out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kalb” — dog, a solid Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew's *kelev*
- “qitt” — cat, most likely a distant cousin of Latin's *cattus* and every European cat-word there is

Before you move on

What root does **كَلْب** trace to, and what's its Hebrew cousin? (**Proto-Semitic *kalb-**; cousin of Hebrew **כֶּלֶב**, *kelev*.) Is **قَطّ**'s relationship to Latin's *cattus* fully settled? (**No** — widely compared, most likely from a shared Afro-Asiatic root, but linguists still debate the exact relationship and direction.) What does this most likely mean for Arabic's word for “cat” compared to Spanish's *gato*, French's *chat*, and German's *Katze*? (**They most likely belong to the same tangled ancient word family** — spreading in every direction from the region where cats were first domesticated.)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Arabic and trace *aṣfar* to the same root as *ṣifr*, 'zero'.

Say akḥḍar beside khuḍār, 'vegetables', then aṣfar beside ṣifr, and follow ṣifr into English zero and cipher.

22.1 أخضر، أصفر — “greens” you’d recognize, and a hidden zero

Arabic’s green word hides an English-style pun. Its yellow word hides something even better — the exact root behind the word “zero” itself.

Why it’s said this way

أخضر (*akḥḍar*, “**green**”) comes from the root ر-ض-خ (*kh-d-r*, “**to be green**”). That same root gives خضار (*khuḍār*, “**vegetables**”) — echoing the exact same move English makes when it calls vegetables “**greens**.” The same root also names the mysterious Quranic figure الخضر (*al-Khiḍr*), “**the Green One**” — traditionally said to be called this because the ground turned green wherever he sat or prayed.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the real surprise: أصفر (*aṣfar*, “**yellow**”) shares its root, ر-ف-ص (*ṣ-f-r*), with صفر (*ṣifr*, “**zero, empty, void**”) — the **exact** Arabic

word that gave English both **zero** (via Italian *zefiro/zero*) and **cipher** (via Medieval Latin *cifra*). So the same three-letter Arabic root sits behind “yellow” and behind the number **zero** itself. The sources don’t fully explain *why* “emptiness” and “yellow” share a root — but the shared root itself, connecting Arabic’s yellow-word straight back to the origin of “zero,” is genuine and well documented.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akhḍar” — green, same root as “khudār,” vegetables
- “aṣfar” — yellow, same root as “ṣifr,” zero
- the connection — “aṣfar, ṣifr, zero, cipher” — one Arabic root, reaching all the way into English math vocabulary

Before you move on

What root does أخضر share with “vegetables,” and what English phrase does this echo? (ر-ض-خ, *kh-ḍ-r* — echoes English calling vegetables “**greens**.”) What Quranic figure shares this root, and what does his name mean? (الخضر, *al-Khidr* — “**the Green One**.”) What word does أصفر share its root with, and what two English words trace back to it? (صفر, *ṣifr*, “zero, empty” — the source of English **zero** and **cipher**.)

Chapter 23

You're Welcome

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can reply to shukran with ʿafwan, and use the same word to say excuse me.

Say ʿafwan as the reply to thanks, unpack the root 'to erase' behind it, and hear the same -an ending it shares with shukran.

23.1 عفو (ʿafwan) — “you’re welcome,” from a root meaning “to erase”

Your very first Arabic lesson already used this word once, in passing, as the reply to *shukran*. Here it gets its own full treatment — starting with a root that literally means “to erase.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

عفو (ʿafwan), root ʿ-f-w (ع-ف-و): the root’s core sense is “**to erase, obliterate, remove**” — and “to pardon, forgive” grows directly out of that, since forgiving something is, metaphorically, **erasing** it. The same root gives العفو (al-ʿAfwu, “**the Supreme Pardoner**”), one of the **99 names of Allah** in Islamic tradition.

You’ll want to know — Be honest: ʿafwan does more than one job

ʿAfwan answers *shukran* as “**you’re welcome**” — but depending on tone and context, the exact same word also does duty as “**excuse me**,” “**par-**

don,” or “sorry.” One root, one word, several closely related jobs — all growing from that same “erase/pardon” sense.

Grammar Lens: the same ending as shukran itself

Look closely at the spelling: عفوؑا ends in the same **tanwīn fatḥ** (“-an”) you already met in شكرؑا (*shukran*) — the indefinite accusative ending. Neither word is a full sentence with its own verb; both are fixed, idiomatic accusative forms functioning as a complete conversational turn on their own. The grammar you learned once, for *shukran*, already explains *ʿafwan* too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “عفوؑا” — *ʿafwan*, “you’re welcome”
- the root ʿ-f-w — “to erase” → “to pardon”
- the shared ending — *shukran* and *ʿafwan* both end in the same **tanwīn fatḥ**, “-an”

Before you move on

What does the root ʿ-f-w literally mean, before it comes to mean “pardon”? (“**To erase, obliterate.**”) Besides “you’re welcome,” what other jobs can *ʿafwan* do? (“**Excuse me,**” “**pardon,**” “**sorry**” — context-dependent.) What grammatical ending does *ʿafwan* share with *shukran*? (The **tanwīn fatḥ**, “-an” — both are fixed indefinite- accusative forms, not full sentences.)

Chapter 24

See You Tomorrow

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can part from someone in Arabic with *ilā l-ghad*, ‘until tomorrow’.

Say ilā l-ghad, point to the ilā already known from ilā l-liqāʾ, and follow gh-d-w from ‘dawn’ to ‘tomorrow’.

24.1 الغد إلى (*ilā l-ghad*) — “see you tomorrow,” the same *ilā* again

You already have the pattern: **ilā** + a future point = “see you [then].” Here it is again, with “tomorrow” filling the slot.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces, one already familiar

الغد إلى (*ilā l-ghad*) = “until tomorrow”:

- إلى (*ilā*) — “until,” the exact same word from *ilā l-liqāʾ* (“see you [later]”).
- الغد (*al-ghad*) — “tomorrow,” root **gh-d-w** (غ-د-و).
- Note ل is a sun letter, so *al-ghad* would assimilate — but غ (*ghayn*) is a **moon letter**, so here the *l* stays put: *al-ghad*, not doubled the way *al-liqāʾ* and *as-salāma* were.

Why it's said this way

Gh-d-w's core sense is “**to go out at dawn, early morning**” — and “**tomorrow**” grows directly out of that “early morning” sense. This is **not** a one-off coincidence: this **exact** shift also happened in Latin, where *māne* (“morning”) became French's *demain* and Spanish's *mañana* (“tomorrow”). Two completely unrelated language families — Semitic and Indo-European — independently building “tomorrow” out of “morning.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ilā l-ghad” — “until tomorrow”
- the reused piece — ilā, already known from ilā l-liqāʾ
- the root echo — gh-d-w, “dawn/morning” → “tomorrow,” the same shift as Latin *māne* → *mañana*/*demain*

Before you move on

What word does **ilā l-ghad** share with **ilā l-liqāʾ**? (**Ilā**, “until.”)
 What does the root **gh-d-w** literally mean, before it comes to mean “tomorrow”? (“**To go out at dawn, early morning.**”) Is this morning-to-tomorrow shift unique to Arabic? (**No** — Latin's *māne* (“morning”) independently became French's *demain* and Spanish's *mañana*, “tomorrow,” the same way.)

Chapter 25

Day

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say 'day' in Arabic and recognise its cognate in Hebrew's Yom Kippur.

Say yawm, run it across the Semitic family, and mark the Egyptian sun-word origin as unsettled.

25.1 يوم (yawm) — “day,” a word shared across the whole Semitic family

This word is bigger than Arabic — it's one of the oldest, most widely shared words across the entire Semitic language family.

You'll want to know — يوم — “day”

يوم (yawm) — “day” — root **y-w-m**. Arabic's day-names can compound with *yawm* — الجمعة يوم (*yawm al-jum^a*, “day of the gathering”) is the full, formal way to say “Friday,” the exact same “day-of-X” construct-state pattern as Latin's *diēs Lūnae* — but colloquially, the bare day-name alone (*al-jum^a*, *as-sabt*, already taught earlier) is just as common. *Yawm* itself is also the ordinary, standalone word for “a day.”

Why it's said this way

Yawm traces to **Proto-Semitic *yawm-** — and this isn't just an Arabic word with foreign relatives, it's a genuinely **Common Semitic** word, found with the same shape and meaning across the whole family:

Hebrew **יוֹם** (*yōm* — yes, the *yom* in **Yom Kippur**, “Day of Atonement”), Akkadian **ūmum**, and Aramaic **yawmā**. Four different Semitic languages, one shared ancient word for “day.”

Why it’s said this way

Some scholars push the trail back even further, to a proposed **Proto-Afroasiatic** root, **yam-* (“day”) — and speculatively connect it to Egyptian **imy**, meaning “sun” (literally “the eye”). Be honest: this deeper connection is a genuinely **proposed**, citable scholarly idea within comparative Afroasiatic linguistics — but a minority one, not accepted by most Egyptologists (standard Egyptian dictionaries gloss *imy* as a common grammatical form, “who/which is in,” not “sun,” and ordinary Egyptian for “day” is an unrelated word, *ḥrw*). Not settled fact the way the Semitic-family cognates are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yawm” — “day”
- the Semitic family — yawm, yōm (Yom Kippur), ūmum, yawmā
- the honest deeper speculation — possibly Egyptian “sun,” not settled

Before you move on

What Hebrew word, familiar from a well-known holiday name, is **yawm**’s direct cognate? (**Yōm**, as in **Yom Kippur**.) Name two other Semitic languages that share this exact word for “day.” (**Akkadian** *ūmum*, **Aramaic** *yawmā*.) Is the proposed Egyptian “sun” connection settled fact? (**No** — a genuinely proposed but speculative deeper link.)

Chapter 26

Night

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say ‘night’ in Arabic and point to layl inside the midnight phrase I already know.

Say layl, find it inside muntaṣaf al-layl, and pair it with yawm as the other pan-Semitic half of the day.

26.1 ليل (layl) — “night,” yawm’s partner across the whole Semitic family

You’ve already met *layl* once, tucked inside *muntaṣaf al-layl* (“midnight”). Now it gets the same standalone treatment *yawm* just did — and the same pan-Semitic family story.

You’ll want to know — ليل — “night”

ليل (layl) — “night” — is the word already hiding inside **muntaṣaf al-layl** (“midnight,” Chapter 15, literally “the half of the night”). Root **l-y-l**.

Why it’s said this way

Just like *yawm*, **layl** is a genuine **Common Semitic** word, not an Arabic-only term with distant relatives. It traces to **Proto-Semitic** **layl-*, cognate with Hebrew לילה (*layla/laylah* — the same word in the famous Passover question, “*mah nishtana ha-layla ha-zeh*,” “why is **this night** different”), Aramaic/Syriac **lēlyā**, and Akkadian **līliātum**. Day and night, *yawm* and *layl*, are **both** words the whole Semitic

family has shared for millennia.

Why it's said this way

Be honest about one genuine scholarly debate: linguists don't fully agree on whether Proto-Semitic had this simple **triradical** **layl-* form, or a **reduplicated** **laylay-* form instead (the doubled shape possibly surviving in some daughter languages' declension patterns). This is a real, open question in comparative Semitics — not settled the way the basic Hebrew/Aramaic/Akkadian cognate set is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “layl” — “night,” already met inside *muntaṣaf al-layl*
- the Semitic family — *layl*, *layla* (Hebrew), *lēlyā*, *līlīātum*
- *yawm* and *layl* — day and night, both pan-Semitic words

Before you move on

Where have you already met **layl** before this lesson? (**Muntaṣaf al-layl**, “midnight.”) What Hebrew word, from a famous Passover question, is *layl*'s direct cognate? (**Layla/laylah**.) Is the exact Proto-Semitic shape of this word — triradical or reduplicated — fully settled? (**No** — a genuine, open scholarly debate.)

Chapter 27

Good Night

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Arabic and explain why the phrase actually talks about the morning.

Say tuṣbiḥ ‘alā khayr, translate it as ‘may you wake into goodness’, and trace tuṣbiḥ back to ṣabāḥ al-khayr’s own root.

27.1 خیر علی تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ‘alā khayr) — wishing the morning, not the night

Every “good night” you’ve learned in other languages wishes a peaceful **night**. Arabic’s everyday version does something completely different — it skips the night and wishes the **morning** instead.

You’ll want to know — خیر علی تصبح — “may you wake into goodness”

خیر علی تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ‘alā khayr) is the most common everyday Arabic “good night” — but it literally means “**may you wake up into goodness.**” Break it down:

- تصبح (tuṣbiḥ) — the ordinary imperfect (“you become”) of أصبح (aṣbaḥa, “**to become morning, to wake up**”) — the **exact same root**, ح-ب-ص (ṣ-b-ḥ), as ṣabāḥ in ṣabāḥ al-khayr (“good morning,” Chapter 1). No special subjunctive or jussive form is

involved — a plain statement doing the work of a blessing, the same way English “you’ll sleep well” can function as a wish without any special grammar.

- على (*‘alā*) — “upon.”
- خير (*khayr*) — “goodness” — the same word already met in **masā’ al-khayr** (“good evening”).

Put together: not “sleep well,” but “**may your waking be good.**” (This particular form, *tuṣbiḥ*, addresses one **man**; a woman is *tuṣbiḥi* [تصبحي], a group is *tuṣbiḥū* [تصبحوا].)

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the genuinely different part: the everyday “good night” of English, French, German, and Spanish wishes something about the **night itself**. Arabic’s everyday version does the opposite: it’s grammatically about the **morning that follows**, built from the same “waking” root already hiding in *ṣabāḥ*. Notice what’s genuinely absent: ليل (*layl*, “night,” last lesson) doesn’t appear anywhere in this phrase at all. It reuses pieces you already have (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, *khayr*) but points them at a **different moment in time** than every other language’s farewell.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tuṣbiḥ ‘alā khayr*” — literally “may you wake into goodness”
- the shared root — *tuṣbiḥ* and *ṣabāḥ*, both from *ṣ-b-ḥ*
- the honest twist — this “good night” is really about the morning, not the night

Before you move on

What does خير على تصبح literally mean? (“**May you wake up into goodness.**”) What root does *tuṣbiḥ* share with *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*? (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, “morning/to become morning.”) Unlike English, French, and German’s “good night,” what moment in time does Arabic’s everyday version actually point to? (**The morning that follows,**

not the night itself.)

Chapter 28

Going and Coming

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for 'he went' and 'he came', read the three-consonant root under each, and explain why Arabic dictionaries list a verb as 'he did' rather than 'to do'.

Say the going/coming pair, name the weak letter that vanishes from $jāʾa$ and point to where it comes back, and restate the root-and-pattern engine dhahaba opened.

28.1 ذَهَبَ (dhahaba) — “he went,” and the engine under every Arabic word

Every word so far has been a thing, a quality, or a fixed courtesy. Now a **verb** — and the machine that builds nearly every word in the language.

You'll want to know — The letters in this word

Three letters, one of them new.

- د ($dāl$) — a small hook resting on the line, sounding like English *d*. It is a **non-joiner**: like *alif*, it will not connect to whatever follows it.
- ذ ($dhāl$) — that same hook with **one dot above**. The dot is the entire difference. Its sound is the *th* of English **this** — voiced — never the *th* of *thin*.
- ه ($hāʾ$) and ب ($bāʾ$) are already yours.

Right to left: ذ stands alone, then هب joins into one piece. *Dha-ha-ba*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ذَهَبَ (*dhahaba*) = “**he went**.” Its root is the bare consonant skeleton ذ-ه-ب. Keep those three consonants, pour a different set of vowels between them, and out comes a different word carved from the same idea:

- ذَهَبَ (*dhahaba*) — “he went.”
- ذَهَب (*dhahab*) — “gold.”
- مَذْهَب (*madhhab*) — “a **way one goes**,” and so the word for a **school of Islamic law**.

That last one is not luck. Putting *ma-* in front of a root gives the **place or the way** of its action, and English already owns two words from that same place-noun family: مَسْجِد (*masjid*), “place of prostration,” worn down through Spanish into **mosque**; and مَغْرِب (*maghrib*), “place of sunset,” kept whole as the **Maghreb**. The pattern is already in your vocabulary. Only the root is new.

Grammar Lens — Arabic has no “to go”

English dictionaries list a verb as “**to go**.” Arabic dictionaries cannot — the language has no infinitive. The form they list is ذَهَبَ, “**he went**”: third person, masculine, singular, finished. Grammarians name each vowel pattern with a dummy root, ل-ع-ف (*f^c-l*, “to do”), so this shape is called فَعَلَ (*fa^cala*). Every verb in these three chapters wears it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- right to left — ذ, then هب — “dhahaba,” he went
- the root — dh-h-b — then dhahab, “gold,” and madhhab, “a school of law”
- the citation form — Arabic lists “he went,” never “to go”

Before you move on

What single mark separates ج from ذ, and what does it do to the sound? (**One dot above** — it turns *d* into the *th* of “this.”) Name two other words built on ذ-ه-ز. (***Dhahab***, “gold,” and ***madhhab***, “a school of law.”) In what form does an Arabic dictionary list a verb? (“**He went**” — *dhahaba* — because Arabic has no infinitive.)

28.2 جاء (jāʾa) — “he came,” and a root that hides one of its own letters

Dhahaba was the tidy case: three consonants, three vowels, nothing hidden. Its opposite number is where the engine gets interesting.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

No new letters here — this word is built entirely from shapes you already have.

- ج (*jīm*) — the hook-and-tail body with **one dot below**, sounding like the *j* of English *jam*.
- ا (*alif*) — the clean downstroke, here carrying a long *ā*.
- ء (*hamza*) — the glottal stop, the catch in “uh-oh,” sitting on the line by itself at the end.

Right to left: ج joined, then ء standing apart. *Jāʾa* — two beats, with a hard little stop at the end.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

جاء (*jāʾa*) = “**he came**.” Its root is ج-ي-أ — and one of those three consonants is missing from the word you just read. That is the point. Arabic calls و and ي **weak** letters. Poured into the *faʿala* shape, the root would give *jayaʾa*, which no Arab mouth wants to say; the ي dissolves and its vowel stretches into the long *ā* you hear. The skeleton is still there, though, and it walks straight back out in مَجِيء (*majīʾ*), “**an arrival**” — the same *ma-* place-and-way prefix met in *madhhab*, with the ي restored in plain sight.

So the irregularity is not chaos. It is a second rule, applied everywhere a weak letter lands in the middle. Being honest about one thing: جاء is the written, formal verb. To tell someone “come here” in ordinary speech you say تَعَالِ (*ta^cāla*), which comes from a completely **different root** meaning “to be high” — originally “come up here.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “dhahaba, jā^ʔa” — he went, he came
- the vanished letter — root j-y-^ʔ, and the ي back in place in “majī^ʔ”
- the everyday imperative — “ta^cāla,” from another root entirely

Before you move on

Which letter of جاء’s root never appears in the word itself, and where does it come back? (ي — restored in مَجِيء, *majī^ʔ*, “an arrival.”) What are Arabic’s two **weak** letters? (و and ي.) What word does an Arabic speaker actually use for “come here,” and is it from this root? (***Ta^cāla*** — **no**, a different root meaning “to be high.”)

Chapter 29

Saying and Seeing

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for 'he said' and 'he saw', read the letters qāf and alif maqṣūra, and name the doer, done-to, place and instrument words each root builds.

Say raʿā, read its dotless alif maqṣūra, follow the root out into raʿy 'opinion' and mirʿāh 'mirror', and restate the pattern family qāla laid out.

29.1 قال (qāla) — “he said,” and a letter you have been reading unnamed

One letter has turned up in Arabic words since the farewell *ilā l-liqāʿ* without ever being introduced. Its own verb is the right place to name it.

You'll want to know — The letters in this word

One new letter, and it is a sound English does not have.

- ق (qāf) — **two dots above** a bowl-shaped body. Joined mid-word it looks much like *bāʿ*'s bowl; alone or final it drops a deep round tail below the line. Its sound is a *k* made far back at the **uvula**, at the top of the throat — heavier and darker than English *k*.
- ا (alif) and ل (lām) are yours already.

Read قال right to left: *qāf*, long *ā*, *lām*. Be honest about the sound: in most everyday spoken Arabic ق is not said that way at all — in Cairo and Damascus it becomes a glottal stop, and across much of the Gulf a hard *g*. The uvular version is the formal one.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

قَالَ (*qāla*) = “**he said**.” Root ق-و-ل — and the same disappearing act as *jāʿa*, with the other weak letter. The plain shape would give *qawala*; the و dissolves and the vowel stretches to *ā*. It reappears the moment the pattern changes: قَوْل (*qawl*), “**an utterance, a saying**.” Now watch one skeleton fill four different pattern-slots:

- قَائِل (*qāʾil*) — “a **speaker**,” the **doer** shape.
- مَقُول (*maqūl*) — “**spoken**,” the **done-to** shape.
- مَقَالَة (*maqāla*) — “an **article**, an essay,” the same *ma*-place-and-way prefix that gave *madhhab*.

Those first two are the very patterns met back in *shukran*, which paired *shākīr* (“thankful”) with *mashkūr* (“thanked”). Learn a pattern once and it works on every root — which is why Arabic vocabulary grows in families rather than one word at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “qāla” — he said — with the deep uvular q
- the weak letter returning — qāla, then qawl, “a saying”
- the family — qāʾil, a speaker; maqūl, spoken; maqāla, an article

Before you move on

How many dots does ق carry, and where is its sound made? (**Two, above** — at the **uvula**, far back in the throat.) Which letter of the root ق-و-ل vanishes in *qāla*, and which word brings it back? (و — restored in قَوْل, *qawl*, “a saying.”) What does مَقَالَة mean, and which earlier word shares its pattern? (“**An article**” — the same *ma*-

shape as *madhhab*.)

29.2 رَأَى (raʾā) — “he saw,” and how seeing becomes having an opinion

A weak letter has hidden in the middle of the last two verbs.
This time it hides at the **end** — and it wears a shape of its own.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

One new shape, and it is a shape you can almost already read.

- ر (rāʾ) — the little downward curve, a tapped *r*, and a non-joiner.
- ا — *alif* carrying **hamza**, the glottal catch, riding on top.
- ي (alif maqṣūra, “the shortened alif”) — this is the new one, and it is simply ي (yāʾ) **stripped of its two dots**. Same body, no dots.
Despite the *yāʾ* body it sounds like a long *ā*, and it only ever turns up at the **end** of a word. The farewell *ilā l-ghad* already carried it, unnamed.

Right to left: *rāʾ*, then *alif-with-hamza*, then the dotless tail. *Ra-ʾā*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

رَأَى (raʾā) = “**he saw**.” Root ر-أ-ي. The weak ي is the **last** consonant this time, and instead of vanishing outright it surfaces as that dotless ي. Three verbs, three placements of weakness: middle in *jāʾa* and *qāla*, final here. Each has its own regular rules.

The family this root grows is the good part:

- رَأْي (raʾy) — “an **opinion**.” Literally a *seeing*. English does the very same thing with “**in my view**” and “the way **I see it**” — two unrelated languages reaching for one metaphor.
- مِرْآة (mirʾāh) — “a **mirror**.” This is the **instrument** shape, *mi-* plus the root: “the thing you see with.” It is a sibling of the *ma-* place shape behind *madhhab* and *maqāla*.
- رُؤْيَا (ruʾyā) — “a **vision**, a dream.”

Seeing, opinion, mirror, vision: four words, one skeleton, no memorising four unrelated forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “raʾā” — he saw — ending on a long ā spelled with a dotless yāʾ
- the metaphor — “raʾy,” an opinion, literally a seeing
- the instrument — “mirʾāh,” a mirror, the thing you see with

Before you move on

What is ى made of, and what does it sound like? (ى *yāʾ* **without its dots** — sounding like a long ā, only ever at the end of a word.) What does رَأْي mean, and what English turn of phrase makes the same move? (“**An opinion**” — literally a seeing, like “**in my view**.”) What is مِرْآة, and what pattern builds it? (**A mirror** — the *mi-* **instrument** shape, “the thing you see with.”)

Chapter 30

Knowing and Eating

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for ‘he knew’ and ‘he ate’, tell ʿarafa apart from ʿalima, and say plainly which of these verbs has an English cousin and which has none.

Say akala with no new letters left to learn, run its doer and done-to forms, place it beside Hebrew akhal, and restate the ʿarafa root family and its Spanish loan.

30.1 عرف (ʿarafa) — “he knew,” and a root that crossed into Spain

Back to a plain, regular root after three weak ones — and to a word that split into two where English has only one.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

One new letter, and it belongs to a family already half-known.

- ع (ʿayn) — the throat-tightening sound with no English equal, met in ʿalaykum and ʿafwan.
- ر (rāʾ) — the tapped *r*, a non-joiner.
- ف (fāʾ) — the new one: a small loop with a tail, carrying **one dot above**, sounding like English *f*. Its partner is ق (qāf) from the *qāla* lesson: mid-word the two bodies are the same shape, and only the dots separate them — **one** dot for *f*, **two** for *q*. A fourth dots-family.

Right to left: ^ʿayn, rāʾ, fāʾ — ^ʿa-ra-fa.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

عَرَفَ (^ʿarafa) = “**he knew, he recognised**” — the plain fa^ʿala shape, no weak letters, root ف-ر-ع. Its family:

- مَعْرِفَة (*ma^ʿrifa*) — “**knowledge**,” the *ma*- shape.
- عُرْف (*ʿurf*) — “**custom**,” what is commonly known.
- الْعَرِيف (*al-^ʿarīf*) — “**the one who knows**,” the expert or overseer. Spanish took the word in during the centuries of Arab rule and keeps it as **alarife**, “master builder.” The palace gardens above Granada, the **Generalife**, are usually read as جَنَّة الْعَرِيف (*jannat al-^ʿarīf*), “the garden of the ^ʿarīf” — though scholars disagree about that second element, so treat it as the leading reading, not a settled one.

Arabic splits “know” in two. عَرَفَ is knowing a *person* or a *place* — recognising. Knowing a *fact* is a different verb, عَلِمَ (*ʿalima*). Spanish cuts the same way with *conocer* and *saber*, French with *connaître* and *savoir*; English collapses both into one word. That second root gives عَالِم (*ʿālim*), “a scholar,” whose plural عُلَمَاء (*ʿulamāʾ*) English borrowed as **ulema**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the dots — ف one dot, ق two dots, one body between them
- “^ʿarafa” — he recognised — beside “^ʿalima,” he knew a fact
- the loan — al-^ʿarīf, Spanish *alarife*, the Generalife in Granada

Before you move on

What tells ف and ق apart? (**The dots** — one above for *f*, two for *q*.) Which of Arabic’s two “know” verbs is ^ʿarafa, and what languages make the same split? (**Recognising a person or place**, against ^ʿalima for a fact — as **Spanish** *conocer/saber* and **French** *connaître/savoir* do.) What Spanish word and what Granada palace

carry al-^ʿarīf? (**Alarife**, “master builder,” and the **Generalife**.)

30.2 أَكَلَ (akala) — “he ate,” and an honest word about cousins

The sixth and last verb of the set — and the one that needs no new letters at all, which is what a course built on words rather than alphabets eventually earns you.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

Nothing new. Every shape here has been taught already.

- ا — *alif* with **hamza** riding on top, the glottal catch, opening the word with a clean *a*.
- ك (kāf) — the angular *k*.
- ل (lām) — the tall hook.

Right to left: *a-ka-la*. Six chapters ago this word would have needed a lesson of its own just to be sounded out; now it reads itself.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَكَلَ (akala) = “**he ate**.” Root ا-ك-ل, and the plain *fa^ʿala* shape once more. Its family runs through the patterns already collected:

- أَكَلَ (akl) — “**eating**,” and so “**food**.”
- مَأْكُولَات (ma^ʾkūlāt) — “**foodstuffs**,” the **done-to** shape from *maqūl*, made plural: the things that get eaten.
- آكِل (ākīl) — “an **eater**,” the **doer** shape, where the root’s own *alif* and the pattern’s *alif* fuse into the long ī.

Now the honest part, because a false cousin is worse than none: **there is no English relative of this word**. Arabic and English are not related languages, and almost none of these six verbs has an English descendant — what English took from Arabic were nouns for goods and sciences, not everyday verbs. What *akala* does have is a **Semitic**

twin: Hebrew אָכַל (*akhal*), “he ate,” the same three consonants in the same order, with the Hebrew noun *okhel*, “food,” standing beside Arabic *akl* — the same family resemblance heard in *salām* and *shalom*, and in *yad* and *yad*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akala” — he ate — then “akl,” food
- the two patterns — “ākil,” an eater; “maʿkūlāt,” foodstuffs
- the honest cousin — no English relative, but Hebrew “akhal”
- all six — dhahaba, jāʾa, qāla, raʾā, ʿarafa, akala

Before you move on

What two pattern-shapes give آكِل and مَأْكُولَات, and what do they mean? (**Doer** and **done-to** — “an eater” and “foodstuffs.”) Does *akala* have an English cousin? (**No** — Arabic and English are unrelated; claiming one would be inventing it.) What is its Semitic twin? (**Hebrew** אָכַל, *akhal*, “he ate.”)

Chapter 31

Understanding, Reading, Writing

Modes:  eyes (4)  Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for 'he understood', 'he read', 'he asked' and 'he wrote', and build a whole family of nouns off each root using the doer, done-to and ma- place shapes I already know.

Run ب-ت-ك through every pattern the track has taught — kitāb, kātib, maktūb, maktab, maktaba — naming the earlier word that wears each shape (qā'il and qāri' for the doer, maqūl and mafhūm and maqrū' for the done-to, madhhab and mas'ala for the ma- place), then place the root beside Hebrew katav and English ketubah.

31.1 فهم (fahima) — “he understood,” and the vowel that makes a state

Six verbs so far, every one of them a deed. This one is not: it happens inside a person — and Arabic marks that in the vowels.

The letters in this word

Nothing new in فهم itself: ف (*fā'*, one dot), ه (*hā'*) and م (*mīm*), with *fā'*'s two-dotted partner ق the pair sorted out in *ʿarafa*. That is twice running — أكل needed no new letters either.

One letter does need naming, because every word-family ahead reaches for it: و (*wāw*). You have read it unnamed inside قَوْل (*qawl*), “a saying.” It is a **non-joiner**, a small loop with a tail under the line, and it holds two jobs — the consonant *w*, and the long vowel *ū*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

فَهِمَ (*fahima*) = “**he understood.**” Root ف-ه-م.

Listen to the middle vowel. *Dhahaba*, *qāla*, *‘arafa* and *akala* all ran *a-a-a*, the فَعَلَ (*fa‘ala*) shape. *Fahima* runs *a-i-a*: فَعِلَ (*fa‘ila*), which Arabic keeps for **states** rather than deeds. Understanding is not performed; it arrives.

- فَهْمَ (*fahm*) — “**understanding**,” the bare thing.
- مَفْهُومَ (*mafhum*) — “**understood**,” the **done-to** shape of *mashkūr* and *maqūl*, its long *ū* riding that و. As a noun it is “**a concept**”: a thing that has been understood.

And the flat statement *akala* insisted on holds here too: ف-ه-م **has no English relative**. *Fathom* is Germanic; the resemblance is noise. No Hebrew twin worth the claim, either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- two words needing no new letters — *akala*, then *fahima*
- the two shapes — *akala*, *a-a-a*; *fahima*, *a-i-a*
- “*fahima*,” he understood — then *fahm*, understanding; *mafhum*, a concept
- the dots once more — ف one, ق two, one body between them
- three roots, three ideas — *ma‘rifa*, knowledge; *fahm*, understanding; *akl*, food
- the honest line — no English cousin here, as with *akala*

Before you move on

Which vowel of *fahima* differs from *akala*, and what does it mark? (The middle *i* — فَعِلَ, a state rather than a deed.) What is مَفْهُومَ? (“**Understood**,” and so “**a concept**” — the done-to shape of *maqūl* and *mashkūr*.) Does *fahima* have an English cousin? (No — *fathom* is Germanic.) Which letter was named here, and where had

you read it? (ق, *wāw* — inside *qawl*.)

31.2 قرأ (*qaraʿa*) — “he recited,” and the word English spells Quran

One root in this chapter did give English a word — exactly one, and it is not the word for reading.

The letters in this word

ق (*qāf*, two dots) and ر (*rāʾ*) are yours. The third is ا, *hamza* on an *alif* seat, closing the word.

Hamza is the homeless consonant. It has a sound of its own — the catch in “uh-oh” — but usually no letter, so it borrows a **seat**, and which seat depends on the vowels around it:

- ا — hamza on l, as in قَرَأَ and in أَنْتَ.
- ؤ — hamza on و, the letter named last lesson.
- ئ — hamza on ي, which gives up its dots to carry it.
- ء — and where no seat suits, hamza alone on the line, closing جاءَ.

Four spellings, one consonant. The seat is bookkeeping; the hamza is the sound.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

قَرَأَ (*qaraʿa*) = “**he read**” — nearer the root’s heart, “**he recited aloud**.” Reading here is done with the voice. Root ق-ر-أ, plain *faʿala* shape.

- قَارِئ (*qārīʾ*) — “a **reader**,” the **doer** shape of *qāʾil*, hamza on its dotless *yāʾ* seat.
- مَقْرُوء (*maqrūʾ*) — “**read**,” the **done-to** shape of *mafḥūm*, long *ū* on the و, hamza left seatless at the end.
- قُرْآن (*qurʾān*) — “**the recitation**,” the thing recited. English writes it **Quran**, or **Koran**. Its long *ī* is the alif-and-hamza

fusion already met in أَكِل (ākil), “an eater.”

That single loan is the shape of the whole story. Arabic gave English *algebra*, *alcohol*, *coffee*, *sugar* and *admiral* — goods and sciences, nouns nearly every one. Out of أ-ر-ق travelled not “to read” but the name of a book. The nearer relative is Hebrew קָרָא (*qara*), “he read.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- hamza’s seats — ا on alif, و on wāw, ئ on dotless yāʾ, ء on nothing
- “qaraʾa,” he recited — then qārīʾ, a reader
- the done-to pair — mafhūm, a concept; maqrūʾ, read — both on wāw
- the borrowed word — qurʾān, “the recitation,” English Quran
- the fused alif — ākil, an eater; qurʾān

Before you move on

Which three seats can hamza take, and what happens to the yāʾ when it serves? (ا, و and ي — the yāʾ drops its dots: ئ.) Which English word descends from أ-ر-ق, and what does it mean in Arabic? (**Quran** — “**the recitation**.”) Which letter carries the long ū of مَقْرُوء (و.) Which earlier word shares the fused ā? (أَكِل, ākil, “an eater.”)

31.3 سأل (saʾala) — “he asked,” and the Arabic word for answerable

Hamza sat at the end of the last word. Here it sits in the middle — and as the vowels shift around it, it changes seats without changing sound at all.

The letters in this word

Nothing new: س (*sīn*), ا (hamza on its *alif* seat) and ل (*lām*). Right to left, *sa-ʿa-la*.

What is worth doing is watching that seat move while the root holds still:

- سَأَلَ (*saʿala*) — the *a* keeps hamza on ا.
- سُؤَالَ (*suʿāl*) — the *u* pulls it onto و.
- سَائِلَ (*sāʿil*) — the *i* pulls it onto dotless ي.

One consonant, one root, three spellings — exactly the rule laid out with *qaraʿa*, now doing its work inside a single family.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سَأَلَ (*saʿala*) = “**he asked**.” Root س-أ-ل, the plain *faʿala* shape.

- سُؤَالَ (*suʿāl*) — “**a question**.”
- سَائِلَ (*sāʿil*) — “an **asker**,” the doer shape that also gave *qārīʿ*, “a reader.”
- مَسْأَلَة (*masʿala*) — the *ma-* shape: “a **matter**, a **problem**” — a thing asked about.
- مَسْؤُولَ (*masʿūl*) — the **done-to** shape, literally “**asked-of**,” and so “**responsible**”; as a noun, “an **official**.” Arabic builds accountability out of being the one who gets questioned, which is a fair account of what accountability is.

The Hebrew twin is exact: שָׁאַל (*shaʿal*), “he asked” — Arabic *s* against Hebrew *sh*, the same swap heard between *salām* and *shalom*. Its passive participle is the name שָׂאֻל (*Shaʿul*), English **Saul**: “asked for.” From the Arabic root, English took nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seat moving — *saʿala* on alif, *suʿāl* on wāw, *sāʿil* on dotless yāʿ

- “saʿala” — he asked — then suʿāl, a question
- the two doers — qāriʿ, a reader; sāʿil, an asker
- masʿala, a matter — masʿūl, asked-of, and so responsible
- the twins — Arabic saʿala, Hebrew shaʿal, and the name Saul

Before you move on

Which three seats does hamza take across *saʿala*, *suʿāl* and *sāʿil*? (**Alif, wāw, dotless yāʿ** — one consonant, three spellings.) What does مَسْئُول mean literally, and what does it mean in use? (“**Asked-of**” — and so **responsible**, or an official.) Which two words here wear the doer shape? (*Sāʿil*, an asker, and *qāriʿ*, a reader.) What does the name **Saul** mean? (“**Asked for**” — from Hebrew *shaʿal*, twin of سَأَلَ.)

31.4 كَتَبَ (kataba) — “he wrote,” and the root that furnishes a library

The chapter closes on the root every Arabic grammar reaches for first. Three letters — and you already own every pattern they need.

The letters in this word

ك (kāf), ت (tāʿ, two dots) and ب (bāʿ, one dot below) were taught long ago. New is how they sit together: **all three join**, so كَتَبَ is one unbroken run of pen — unlike ذَهَبَ, where *dhāl* refuses to connect, or أَكَلَ, where the *alif* stands off alone.

One old mark earns its keep too: put ّة (*tāʿ marbūṭa*) on مَكْتَبَ (*maktab*) and you get مَكْتَبَةٌ (*maktaba*). One letter, and an office becomes a library.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كَتَبَ (*kataba*) = “**he wrote**.” Root ك-ت-ب, plain *faʿala* shape. Now pour it through the patterns this track has handed you:

- كِتَابَ (*kitāb*) — “a **book**.” A written thing.
- كَاتِبَ (*kātib*) — “a **writer**,” the **doer** shape of *qāʿil* and *qāriʿ*.

- مَكْتُوب (*maktūb*) — “**written**,” the **done-to** shape of *maqūl* and *mafḥūm* — and in speech, what has been written for you: **fate**.
- مَكْتَب (*maktab*) — the **ma- place** shape of *madhḥab* and *masjid*: the place of writing, a **desk**, an **office**.
- مَكْتَبَة (*maktaba*) — that place plus ة: a **library**.

Five words off one root, not one of them learned separately. That is the whole return on the root system, collected in one lesson.

No English word descends from ب-ت-ك. English does hold one from the same **Semitic** root, by way of Hebrew: a **ketubah**, the written Jewish marriage contract — כְּתוּבָה (*ketubbah*), “a written thing,” from כָּתַב (*katav*), “he wrote.” That is *maktūb*’s own pattern in the other language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three joined letters — kāf, tāʾ, bāʾ — “kataba,” he wrote
- the doers — qāʾil, qāriʾ, kātib
- the done-to run — maqūl, mafḥūm, maqrūʾ, maktūb
- the ma- place shape — madhḥab, masʾala, maktab
- the letter that moves — maktab, an office; maktaba, a library
- the Semitic twin — Hebrew *katav*, English *ketubah*

Before you move on

Name five words built here from ب-ت-ك. (*Kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktūb*, *maktab*, *maktaba*.) Which pattern gives “office,” and which two earlier words wear it? (The **ma- place shape** — *madhḥab* and *masʾala*.) Which two earlier words share *kātib*’s doer shape? (*Qāʾil* and *qāriʾ*.) What single letter turns an office into a library? (ة.) Which English word comes from this root? (**None** — but **ketubah** comes from its Hebrew twin *katav*.)

Chapter 32

Taking, Thinking, Helping, Loving

Modes:  eyes (4)  Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for 'he took', 'he thought', 'he helped' and 'he loved', and tell a plain verb from a rebuilt one — doubled, stretched or prefixed — by what the shape does to the root's meaning.

*Say the chapter's four verbs against the four shapes they wear —
ʾakhadha plain, fakkara doubled, sāʿada stretched, ʾaḥabba prefixed —
then run the done-to shape across maktūb, maʾkhūdh and maḥbūb and
restate the ma- engine dhahaba opened.*

32.1 أخذ (ʾakhadha) — “he took,” and the last of the plain verbs

The last chapter changed the **vowels** inside a root. This one changes the **shape** of the verb itself — a doubled letter, a stretched vowel, a prefix. The verb here is the plain one, kept to measure the other three against.

The letters in this word

No new letters, and three worth re-reading:

-  — hamza on its *alif* seat, opening the word as it opens .
-  (*khāʾ*) — the hook family's **one dot above**, the *ch* of Scottish “loch.”

- ذ (dhāl) — dāl with **one dot above**, the *th* of “this,” the letter that opened ذهب.

Right to left: *ʿa-kha-dha*. Note what the page does with it. كتب ran as one unbroken piece; أخذ cannot, because *alif* is a non-joiner. It breaks into أ and خذ — the two-piece shape of ذهب.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَخَذَ (*ʿakhadha*) = “**he took**.” Root أ-خ-ذ, the plain فَعَلَ shape — the last verb in this book to wear it unaltered.

- أَخَذَ (*akhadh*) — “**taking**.”
- آخَذَ (*ākhidh*) — “one **taking**,” the **doer** shape of *kātib*, where the root’s own *alif* and the pattern’s fuse into long Ā — the fusion seen in أَكَلَ (*ākil*), “an eater.”
- مَأْخُذٌ (*maʿkhūdh*) — “**taken**,” the **done-to** shape of *maktūb*.

Its Hebrew twin is אָחַז (*ʿahaz*), “he seized.” Two regular swaps carry you across: Arabic خ answers Hebrew א, and Arabic ذ answers Hebrew ז. Those are standing correspondences between the languages, not guesses about this pair. English took nothing from either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the letters — hamza on alif, khāʿ, dhāl — “ʿakhadha,” he took
- the same opening — أَكَلَ, then أَخَذَ, hamza on its alif seat
- which words break — kataba into one piece, ʿakhadha and dhahaba into two
- the dot that makes dhāl — dāl, then dhāl, the *th* of “this”
- the fused alif — ākil, an eater; ākhidh, one taking
- the done-to pair — maktūb, written; maʿkhūdh, taken

Before you move on

Which letter keeps أخذ from running as one piece, and which Chapter 31 verb did run as one? (**The alif**, a non-joiner — against كتب.) What turns د into ذ? (**One dot above** — *d* becomes the *th* of “this.”) Which two words fuse their alifs into ĩ? (**Ākil** and **ākhidh.**) Which Hebrew consonants answer Arabic خ and ذ? (ן and ז — in תִּחַז, ^ʔ*ahaz.*)

32.2 فَكَّرَ (fakkara) — “he thought,” and a root rebuilt by doubling

Every verb so far has been a bare root with vowels poured between its letters. Arabic can also **rebuild** a root, and the first way it does so is by doubling one letter.

The letters in this word

ف, ك and ر are all yours, and all three join, so فَكَّرَ runs as one piece.

The new thing is not a letter but a mark: َ (*shadda*), the little *w* riding the ك of فَكَّرَ. It says “**sound this consonant twice**” — *fak-ka-ra*, not *fa-ka-ra*. You met it among the ḥarakāt and on the tail of *shukran*; here it is load-bearing, because that doubling is the whole difference between one verb and another.

Everyday Arabic prints no *shadda*, as it prints no short vowels; the reader supplies it.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

فَكَرَ (*fakkara*) = “**he thought**, he pondered.” Root ف-ك-ر.

Doubling a root’s middle consonant is no irregularity. It is a pattern with a name and a job: فَعَّلَ (*fa^cala*), which grammarians number **Form II**, and it generally means doing the root **hard, repeatedly**, or **to something else**. *Fakkara* is thinking worked at, while the bare root holds the raw material:

- فَكَّرَ (*fikr*) — “**thought**,” thinking as such.
- فِكْرَة (*fikra*) — “**an idea**,” one thought, closed by the same ّة that made a library out of an office.

- تَفَكَّرَ (*tafkār*) — “**thinking**,” the activity, on Form II’s own noun shape.
- مُفَكِّرٌ (*mufakkir*) — “**a thinker**.” Form II builds its doer with a مُ (*mu-*) prefix, not the long *ā* of *kātib*. A rebuilt verb gets a rebuilt doer.

No English cousin here, and no Hebrew twin worth the claim.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the doubling — fa-ka-ra, then fak-ka-ra, shadda on the kāf
- “fakkara,” he thought — then fkr, thought; fikra, an idea
- plain beside rebuilt — ʾakhadha, then fakkara
- the two doers — kātib, a writer; mufakkir, a thinker
- the done-to shape holding steady — maktūb, maʾkhūdh

Before you move on

What does the **shadda** instruct, and which letter carries it in فَكَّرَ? (**Double the consonant** — it rides the ك.) What is Form II, and what does it do to a root? (فَعَّلَ, middle letter **doubled** — the root done hard, repeatedly, or to something else.) How does Form II build its doer, against *kataba* and ʾakhadha? (مُفَكِّرٌ with **mu-**, against كَاتِب and أَخَذَ with a long *ā*.)

32.3 سَاعَدَ (*sāʿada*) — “he helped,” from a root meaning good fortune

The second way Arabic rebuilds a root is gentler than doubling: it stretches a vowel. What comes out is a verb pointed at somebody else.

The letters in this word

Nothing new: س (*sīn*), ا (*alif*, here carrying long *ā*), ع (*ʿayn*) and د (*dāl*).

Two things are worth noticing. ساعد breaks in two — سا, then عد — because *alif* will not join forwards, the split that broke أخذ and ذهب while كتب ran whole. And ع sits **inside** a word here, joined on both sides, where in عرف it opened one: the *ʿayn* changes shape by position more than almost any letter, while its throat-tightening sound never changes.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سَاعَدَ (*sāʿada*) = “**he helped**.” Root س-ع-د — which on its own does not mean helping at all. It means **good fortune**:

- سَعِيد (*saʿīd*) — “**happy**, fortunate,” also the name **Saeed**.
- سَعَادَة (*saʿāda*) — “**happiness**.”

Stretch the vowel after the first root letter — فَاعَلَ (*fāʿala*), **Form III** — and the verb turns outward: doing the root **with** or **toward** another person. *Sāʿada* is bringing your good fortune to bear on somebody. That is Arabic’s account of helping.

- مُسَاعَدَة (*musāʿada*) — “**help**, assistance.”
- مُسَاعِد (*musāʿid*) — “**an assistant**,” on the same مُ doer prefix that gave *mufakkir*.

English carries one name from this root: the ruling family آل سُعود (*Āl Saʿūd*) is what is said in **Saudi** Arabia — a family name, not a borrowed verb. Hebrew’s טַוֵּן (*saʿad*), “to sustain,” is the twin; a מִסְעָדָה (*misʿada*) is a restaurant.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pieces — سا, then عد — “sāʿada,” he helped
- which break — ʾakhadha and sāʿada in two, kataba in one
- the ʿayn opening ʿarafa, then joined inside sāʿada
- the root before the help — saʿīd, happy; saʿāda, happiness

- doubled against stretched — fakkara’s shadda, sā^cada’s long ā
- the two mu- doers — mufakkir, a thinker; musā^cid, an assistant

Before you move on

What does Form III do to a root, and to its meaning? (**Stretches the vowel after the first letter** — فاعَلَ — and aims the action **at somebody else**.) What does د-ع-س mean before it means helping? (**Good fortune** — sa^cid, “happy.”) Which mark makes fakkara Form II, and does sā^cada carry one? (**The shadda** on the ك — and **no**.) Which English place-name carries this root? (**Saudi** Arabia, from آل سُعود.)

32.4 أَحَبَّ (ʾaḥabba) — “he loved,” and the four shapes together

The last verb of the chapter, and the last of its four shapes: plain, doubled, stretched — and now prefixed.

The letters in this word

Three letter-shapes for four consonants. ا (hamza on its *alif* seat), ح (ḥā^ʔ, the hook family’s undotted member, a hard breath from deep in the throat) and ب (bā^ʔ) — with the **shadda** on that final ب doubling it: أَحَبَّ is ʾa-ḥab-ba.

The mark is the one that rode the ك of فَكَّرَ, doing a different job: there it built a new verb, here it only spells a root whose last two letters are the same.

On the page the word breaks after the *alif* — أ, then حَبَّ — the two-piece split of ساعد and أخذ once again.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَحَبَّ (ʾaḥabba) = “**he loved**,” and more mildly “he liked.” Root ح-ب-ح. The ا on the front is **Form IV**, أَفْعَلَ (ʾafʿala): the prefix that makes a root **bring about** its own idea. Love, on this account, is something a person causes.

- حُبَّ (ḥubb) — “love.”

- حَبِيب (ḥabīb) — “**beloved**,” feminine حَبِيبَة (ḥabība); add the “my” ending of اسمي (ismī) and it is حَبِيبِي (ḥabībī), “my beloved.”
- مَحْبُوب (maḥbūb) — “**beloved, well-liked**,” the **done-to** shape of maktūb and maʾkhūdh.

Hebrew’s ordinary verb for loving, אָהַב (ahav), is **not** a relative. The real twin is רַחֵם (ḥaviv), “dear,” which is ḥabīb exactly. No English word descends from ח-ב-ב: ḥabībī travels through music, not dictionaries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the chapter’s four — ʾakhadha, fakkara, sāʿada, ʾaḥabba
- the four shapes — plain, doubled, stretched, ʾa- prefix
- “ʾaḥabba,” he loved — then ḥubb, love; ḥabīb, beloved
- the pieces — أ alone, then حَبَّ, as ساعد split into سا and عد
- the done-to run — maktūb, maʾkhūdh, maḥbūb
- the ma- place shape from the first verb lesson — madhhab, maktab
- the rebuilt doers — mufakkir; musāʿid

Before you move on

Name this chapter’s four verbs and the shape each wears.
 (ʾAkhadha plain, **fakkara** doubled, **sāʿada** stretched, ʾaḥabba prefixed — Forms I to IV.) What does Form IV’s أ do? (**Makes the root bring about its own idea.**) Why does حَبَّ carry a shadda, and is it fakkara’s reason? (**Because the root’s last two letters are both ب — not a Form II doubling.**) Which Hebrew word is ḥabīb, and which root first showed you the *ma-* shapes? (רַחֵם — while ahav is no relation — and ב-ה-ז, in madhhab.)

Chapter 33

Asking for a Drink

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) 🖱 Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name tea, milk, sugar and coffee in Arabic and ask for any of them politely, and I can tell at sight whether an Arabic noun is feminine.

Say the chapter's drinks and name which of them Arabic built and which it borrowed — ḥalīb from ḥalaba, 'he milked', against shāy and sukkar, which arrived with no root at all — then read the ʾ off qahwa as a gender marker, place it beside maktaba and as-salāma, and order each drink with min fadlik, answering ʿafwan.

33.1 شاي (shāy) — “tea,” and a word with no root

Every Arabic word you have taken apart so far had a root under it. This one does not — and that absence is the lesson.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ش (shīn) has been on the page since شكرًا (shukran): the sīn skeleton with three dots above it. Then ا (alif), the non-joiner, and ي (yāʾ).

So شاي breaks where alif forces it to break: شا, then ي. That is the same two-piece split you met in أحبّ — ا standing alone, then حبّ.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

شاي (shāy) = “tea.”

Now the honest part. Take كتب (kataba): its root pours into كتاب

(*kitāb*, a book), كَاتِب (*kātib*, a writer), مَكْتَب (*maktab*, an office) and مَكْتَبَة (*maktaba*, a library). Try that with *shāy* and nothing comes out. There is no shape it fills, no doer, no place, no done-to. That is because **shāy is borrowed**, and a borrowed word arrives without a root. Arabic took it through Persian چای (*chāy*), which took it from the **northern Chinese chá**. Your own language took the same Chinese word by the other road. Traders on the southern coast of China said it *tê*, Dutch ships carried that form to Europe, and it became English **tea**, French **thé**, German **Tee**. Overland through Persia it stayed *chá*: Russian **chay**, Turkish **çay**, Arabic **shāy**. So *shāy* and *tea* are not merely similar. They are the two ends of one word, separated by which way it left China.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- shīn, alif, yāʾ — “shāy,” tea
- where it breaks — shā, then yāʾ, as أَحَبَّ broke after the alif
- what a root gives — kitāb, kātib, maktab, maktaba
- what shāy gives — nothing, because it was borrowed
- the overland road — Chinese chá, Persian chāy, Arabic shāy
- the sea road — Hokkien tê, Dutch, English tea

Before you move on

Why can you not build a word family from شاي? (**It has no Arabic root** — it was borrowed, and borrowed words arrive without one.) Name what ب-ت-ك builds, for contrast. (***Kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*, *maktaba***.) Which language handed *shāy* to Arabic, and which language did that one take it from? (**Persian**, from **Chinese**.) Is English *tea* a relative? (**Yes** — the same Chinese word, carried by sea rather than overland.)

33.2 حليب (ḥalīb) — “milk,” and the verb underneath it

Yesterday’s word had no root to stand on. This one has a root so plain you can hear the verb inside the noun.

The letters in this word

Nothing new again. ح (ḥāʾ) is the undotted member of the hook-and-tail family — the body it shares with خ (khāʾ, one dot above) and ج (jīm, one dot below). It is the hard breath from deep in the throat that opens أَحَبَّ (ʾaḥabba).

Then ل (lām), ي (yāʾ) carrying the long ī, and ب (bāʾ).

All four join, so حليب runs as one unbroken stroke — the opposite of شاي, which had to stop at its *alif*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

حليب (ḥalīb) = “milk.” Root ح-ل-ب, and its verb is حَلَبَ (ḥalaba), “he milked.” So the noun is simply the milked thing.

You have met this exact transparency before. خبز (khubz, bread) sits on ز-ب-خ, “to bake”: the baked thing. Arabic does this constantly — name the action, and the everyday noun falls out of it.

The pattern ḥalīb wears, فَعِيل (faʿīl), is one to keep. It takes a root and hands back a quality or a result you can hold.

Hebrew has the word unchanged: חָלַב (ḥalav), “milk,” the same root doing the same job — the family resemblance already heard in *salām* and *shalom*.

One caution, because a good story is not the same as a true one. The Syrian city حَلَب (Ḥalab, English **Aleppo**) is often explained as a milk name. It is not: Ḥalab appears in Bronze Age records centuries before Arabic was written, so the milk account is a later invention hung on a name that already existed. No English word descends from ح-ل-ب at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the hook family — ḥāʾ no dot, khāʾ one above, jīm one below

- ḥāʾ, lām, yāʾ, bāʾ — “ḥalīb,” milk
- the verb under it — “ḥalaba,” he milked
- the same move in bread — khubz, from kh-b-z, to bake
- the pattern — faʿīl, as in ḥalīb
- the borrowed one against the built one — shāy, then ḥalīb
- the Hebrew twin — ḥalav

Before you move on

What does the root ح-ل-ب mean as a verb? (**To milk** — so *ḥalīb* is the milked thing.) Which earlier word works the same way? (**Khubz** — bread, from *kh-b-z*, to bake.) Which of the chapter’s words so far has no root at all? (**Shāy** — it was borrowed.) Is Aleppo named for milk? (**No** — the name is far older than Arabic; that story is folk etymology.)

33.3 سكر (sukkar) — “sugar,” and an Arabic article stuck to a Spanish word

Another traveller — and this one left a piece of Arabic grammar behind in Spain.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. س (*sīn*), the low comb; ك (*kāf*), the angular *k*; and ر (*rā*), the little downward curve that **breaks** — a non-joiner, like *alif*. So سكر joins from *sīn* to *kāf*, and *rā* hangs off the end.

Written fully it is سُكَّر, and the mark over the ك is the **shadda**. You have seen it do two jobs. On فَكَّر (*fakkara*) it built a new verb out of an old root. Here it does the quieter job it did on أَحَبَّ: it spells a letter the word already owns twice over — *suk-kar*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سُكَّر (*sukkar*) = “**sugar**.” Like *shāy*, and unlike *ḥalīb*, it is **borrowed**: no Arabic root, no family of shapes. Its road west starts in **Sanskrit**, where **śarkarā** meant “grit, gravel”

— sugar named for its coarse grains. **Persian** took it as *shakar*, Arabic as *sukkar*, and Arabic carried it into medieval **Latin** as *succarum*. From there: Italian **zucchero**, French **sucre**, German **Zucker**, English **sugar**.

Then **Spanish**, which shows what the others hide. Spanish for sugar is **azúcar** — and that opening *a-z-* is Arabic’s own ﺍﻝ (*al-*), the article, welded onto the front of the noun. Spanish borrowed **al-sukkar** whole and never took it apart.

You know why the *l* vanished: ﺱ is a **sun letter**, so *al-* + *sukkar* is said **as-sukkar**, as *al-* + *salām* is said **as-salām**. Spanish kept the sound, not the spelling. English holds *algebra* and *alcohol*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- sīn, kāf, rā — and rā breaks, so nothing joins after it
- “sukkar,” sugar — the shadda doubling the kāf, suk-kar
- the shadda’s two jobs — fakkara built a verb, ʾaḥabba spelled one
- the road — Sanskrit śarkarā, Persian shakar, Arabic sukkar
- the article that stayed — as-sukkar, Spanish azúcar
- the sun letter — al- plus salām said as-salām
- borrowed, borrowed, built — shāy, sukkar, ḥalīb
- the letters before it — shīm, alif, yāʾ; then ḥāʾ, lām, yāʾ, bāʾ

Before you move on

Which letter in سكر refuses to join what follows? (**Rā**.) What is the shadda doing here, and which earlier verb used it the same way? (**Only spelling a doubled letter** — as in ʾaḥabba, not as in fakkara.) What language did *sukkar* come from before Persian? (**Sanskrit** — śarkarā, “grit.”) What is hiding at the front of Spanish **azúcar**? (**Arabic al-**, said *as-* before a sun letter.)

33.4 قهوة (qahwa) — “coffee,” the tied tāʾ, and asking for all of it

The chapter closes on a word your own language already borrowed — and on the small letter at its end that tells you the word is feminine.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ق (*qāf*, two dots above), the *k* made far back in the throat; ه (*hāʾ*), the loop that changes shape wherever it stands; و (*wāw*), a non-joiner like *rā*; and then ۀ.

ۀ is the tāʾ **marbūṭa**, the “tied tāʾ” — an ه with tāʾ’s two dots on it. It appears only at the end of a word.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

قهوة (*qahwa*) = “coffee.”

Here is what the ۀ buys you. Arabic nouns carry **gender**, and Arabic usually **shows** you which is which: a noun ending in ۀ is almost always **feminine**. That is a rule you apply on sight, not a list to memorise. You have watched it work already:

- مَكْتَب (maktab), an office, becomes مَكْتَبَة (maktaba), a library.
- سَلَام (salām), peace, becomes السَّلَامَة (as-salāma), the safety — the root م-ل-س wearing an ending and a pattern.

So *qahwa* is feminine, while *shāy*, *ḥalīb* and *sukkar* are masculine — and the ending alone told you.

The road out of Arabic is short and well lit. Ottoman **Turkish** took *qahwa* as **kahve**; Venetian traders took *kahve* as Italian **caffè**; from Italian came French **café**, German **Kaffee** and English **coffee**. The English word in your mouth is this Arabic one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- qāf, hāʾ, wāw, tāʾ marbūṭa — “qahwa,” coffee
- the tied tāʾ — an hāʾ wearing tāʾ’s two dots, only at a word’s end

- what it marks — feminine; maktab becomes maktaba, salām becomes as-salāma
- gendered — qahwa feminine; shāy, ḥalīb, sukkar masculine
- order each — “shāy, min faḍlik”; “qahwa, min faḍlik”; “ḥalīb, min faḍlik”; “sukkar, min faḍlik”
- the answer to thanks — “ʿafwan,” think nothing of it
- ḥalīb joined throughout, sukkar’s rā broke, and the wāw breaks here
- built against borrowed — ḥalaba gave ḥalīb; shāy and sukkar gave nothing

Before you move on

Which of this chapter’s words is feminine, and how can you tell? (*Qahwa* — it ends in ʾ.) Name two earlier words with that ending. (*Maktaba* and *as-salāma*.) Ask for each drink politely. (*Shāy, qahwa, ḥalīb, sukkar* — each with *min faḍlik*, “from your grace.”) What do you answer when someone thanks you? (*ʿAfwan*.) Which word here was built from a verb? (*Ḥalīb*, from *ḥalaba* — the others travelled in.)

Chapter 34

Asking for Food

Modes:  eyes (4)  Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for salt, meat, cheese and food in Arabic, and I can build the word for a restaurant myself out of a root and the ma- place shape.

Name ط as the emphatic partner of ت beside ص under س and ض under د, then pour ط-ع-م through the ma- place shape that already gave maktab and madhhab to generate maṭʿam, ‘a restaurant’, and ask for the chapter’s foods with min faḍlik.

34.1 ملح (milḥ) — “salt,” and the sailor hiding in it

A word for something you can hold in one hand — whose root stretches from a mineral to the open sea to a compliment.

The letters in this word

Nothing new, but one shape is worth a second look. م (*mām*), ل (*lām*), ح (*ḥāʾ*) — all three join, so ملح is one run of pen.

The ح is the hook-and-tail letter that opened حليب (*ḥalīb*), but at the **end** of a word it grows its full tail and swings below the line: open at the start of *ḥalīb*, closed and tailed at the end of *milḥ*.

قهوة made the same point at the other end of a word: ّ exists only in final position.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مِلْح (*milḥ*) = “salt.” Root م-ل-ح, and this is a root that has gone travelling inside its own language:

- مَلَّاح (*mallāḥ*) — “a sailor.” The man of the salt water. It wears the doubled *lām* shape Arabic keeps for trades and habits.
- مَلِيح (*malīḥ*) — “handsome, pleasant.” Salty, said of a person. Arabic reached for the same idea English reaches for when it calls a person *the salt of the earth*.

Note *malīḥ*’s shape: فَعِيل (*faʿīl*), the same pattern that gave you حَلِيب (*ḥalīb*). A root plus that pattern hands back a quality. Hebrew has מֶלַח (*melaḥ*), “salt,” unchanged — one more Semitic twin. English is **not** in this family: *salt* comes down from Latin *sāl* and its Germanic cousins. And unlike *sukkar*, nothing here was borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- mīm, lām, ḥāʾ — “milḥ,” salt
- ḥāʾ in two places — opening ḥalīb, closing milḥ with its tail
- the root’s reach — mallāḥ, a sailor; malīḥ, handsome
- the faʿīl pattern twice — ḥalīb, malīḥ
- the Hebrew twin — melaḥ; and no English relative, only Latin *sāl*
- the borrowed one for contrast — *sukkar*, from Sanskrit by way of Persian
- the letters just behind — sīn, kāf, rā; qāf, hāʾ, wāw, tāʾ marbūʿa

Before you move on

What else does م-ل-ح give besides salt? (***Mallāḥ***, a sailor, and ***malīḥ***, handsome.) Which pattern do *malīḥ* and *ḥalīb* share? (***Faʿīl***.) Why does the ح of *milḥ* not look like the ح of *ḥalīb*? (**It is at the end of the word**, so it takes its full tailed shape.) Does

English *salt* belong to this family? (**No** — it descends from Latin *sāl*.)

34.2 لحم (laḥm) — “meat,” and the town on the seam

This word and its Hebrew twin are the same root — and they mean different foods. There is a town whose name proves it.

The letters in this word

Nothing new, and something pleasing: لحم is ملح read the other way about. The same shapes — ل (*lām*), ح (*ḥāʾ*), م (*mām*) — in a different order, and so a different root and a different word.

That is the root system stated as plainly as it can be. The letters are not the word. The **order** is the word.

Here ḥāʾ sits in the **middle**, so it wears its joined-both-sides shape: neither ḥalīb’s open opening nor milḥ’s tailed ending.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

لَحْم (laḥm) = “**meat**.” Root ل-ح-م.

Now the twin, and it is the best one in this book. Hebrew’s לֶחֶם (*leḥem*) is the same root — and it means **bread**.

Neither language changed the meaning. The old Semitic root named **the staple food**, and each people filled it with whatever theirs was: meat where herds mattered, bread where grain did.

English already owns the proof. The town is لحم بيت (Bayt Laḥm) in Arabic and לֶחֶם בֵּית (Bēt Leḥem) in Hebrew — one name, in which *bayt* and *bēt* both mean “a house of.” English calls it **Bethlehem**: house of bread on one side of the seam, house of meat on the other.

And notice what Arabic did **not** do. It had this root available for bread and did not use it. Arabic’s bread is خُبْز (*khubz*), built on ز-ب-خ, “to bake” — the baked thing, as ḥalīb is the milked thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- lām, ḥāʾ, mīm — “laḥm,” meat
- the same shapes reordered — mīm, lām, ḥāʾ is “milḥ,” salt
- ḥāʾ in the middle, joined on both sides
- the twin that shifted — laḥm is meat, Hebrew leḥem is bread
- the town on the seam — Bayt Laḥm, Bēt Leḥem, Bethlehem
- Arabic’s own bread — khubz, from kh-b-z, to bake
- the salt root’s reach — mallāḥ, malīḥ
- qahwa’s letters and its feminine ending — qāf, hāʾ, wāw, tāʾ marbūṭa

Before you move on

What separates لحم from ملح? (**Only the order of the letters** — the whole root system.) What does Hebrew *leḥem* mean, and why is that no contradiction? (**Bread** — the root named the **staple food**.) Which English place name carries both? (**Bethlehem**.) What is Arabic’s own word for bread, and where from? (**Khubz**, from ز-ب-خ, “to bake.”)

34.3 جبن (jubn) — “cheese,” and where the root system stops

The root system has been paying you back for chapters. This word is where it politely declines to.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ج (*jīm*) is the third of the hook-and-tail family: the body of ح (*ḥāʾ*) and خ (*khāʾ*), marked by one dot **below**. Then ب (*bāʾ*), one dot below, and ن (*nūn*), one dot above.

Dots are the whole difference here, as they were between the ḥāʾ of لحم and the khāʾ of خبز.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

جُبْن (*jubn*) = “**cheese**.” In everyday speech you will more often hear جُبْنَة (*jibna*) — and that ending is the ة you now recognise on sight, doing its usual work.

Now the honest part, because you have been taught to trust roots and this is where that trust needs a limit.

جُبْن also means “**cowardice**,” and جَبَان (*jabān*) is “**a coward**.” Same letters, same order. So is a cheese a coward?

No. Arabic’s dictionaries list these as **separate entries** — words spelled alike, not one idea branching. Compare a real root: ح-ل-م carries salt into *mallāḥ*, the sailor of salt water, and into *malīḥ*, a salty compliment. You can feel the thread. Between cheese and cowardice there is none, and inventing one would be the mistake the milk story made of Aleppo.

Two words can share three letters by accident. Arabic has many roots and few letters.

English took none of this: **cheese** comes from Latin **cāseus**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- jīm, bāʾ, nūn — “jubn,” cheese
- the hook family by dots — ḥāʾ none, khāʾ one above, jīm one below
- the everyday form — jibna, with the tied tāʾ
- the accident — jubn is also cowardice, jabān a coward
- the verdict — separate words, not one root branching
- a real branching — milḥ, mallāḥ, malīḥ
- meat and salt — laḥm, milḥ, the same shapes reordered

Before you move on

What separates ج from ح and خ? (**One dot below**.) What else do the letters of *jubn* spell? (**Cowardice** — *jabān* is a coward.) Are cheese and cowardice one root? (**No** — separate words that look

alike.) Name a root that really does branch. (م-ل-ح — *milh*, *mallāh*, *malīh*.) What does the ending on *jibna* tell you? (**Feminine**, as *qahwa* is.)

34.4 طَعَام (ṭaʿām) — “food,” and a restaurant you can build yourself

A new root, a new letter — and a word you will not have to be taught, because you already own the shape it comes in.

The letters in this word

One letter to name at last. ط is ṭāʾ, the **emphatic** partner of ت (tāʾ): the same *t*, said with the tongue flat, so the syllable goes dark around it.

Arabic keeps a small set of emphatic pairs, and you have met the others without being told they were a set:

- ص (ṣād) is the emphatic س (sīn) — the ص of صباح (*ṣabāḥ*).
- ض (ḍād) is the emphatic د (dāl) — the ض of من فضلك (*min faḍlik*).
- ط (ṭāʾ) is the emphatic ت (tāʾ) — this one.

Then ع (*ʿayn*), the throat sound already named, ا (*alif*) and م (*mīm*). Ṭāʾ joins; *alif* does not, so طَعَام runs طعا, then م.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

طَعَام (ṭaʿām) = “**food**.” Root ط-ع-م, whose verb طَعِمَ (ṭaʿima) means “**he tasted**,” and whose bare noun طَعْم (ṭaʿm) is “**taste, flavour**.”

So Arabic has two ways to speak of eating. أَكَلَ (*akala*) is the plain act — he ate. ط-ع-م goes through the tongue: tasting, and so the food that gets tasted.

Now take the م **place shape** you own. It made مَكْتَب (maktab), the place of writing, from ب-ت-ك, and مَذْهَب (madhhab) from ب-ه-ذ. Put ط-ع-م through it:

مَطْعَم (maṭʿam) — the place of eating. **A restaurant.**

Nobody taught you that word. The pattern did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ṭāʾ, ʿayn, alif, mīm — “ṭaʿām,” food
- the emphatic set — ṣād under sīn, ḍād under dāl, ṭāʾ under tāʾ
- where you had them — ṣabāḥ, min faḍlik, now ṭaʿām
- the verb and the bare noun — ṭaʿima, he tasted; ṭaʿm, taste
- two ways to eat — akala the act, ṭaʿima the tasting
- the ma- place shape — madhhab, maktab, so maṭʿam, a restaurant
- the chapter’s foods — milḥ, laḥm reversing its letters, jubn, ṭaʿām
- order them — “laḥm, min faḍlik”; “jubn, min faḍlik”
- and the odd old one — māʾ, water, whose plural miyāh keeps no pattern

Before you move on

Which plain letter is ط the emphatic partner of, and name the other pairs. (ت — with ص under س and ض under د.) What does ط-ع-م mean as a verb? (**To taste.**) Build “restaurant” from it, and name the earlier words in that shape. (**Maṭʿam** — like **maktab** and **madhhab**.) Ask for the chapter’s foods politely. (**Milḥ, laḥm, jubn, ṭaʿām** — each with **min faḍlik**, “from your grace.”) Which everyday word keeps no pattern at all? (**Māʾ** — its plural **miyāh** is irregular.)

Chapter 35

The People You Introduce

Modes: 👁 eyes (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name and introduce a neighbour, a son, a daughter and a friend in Arabic, and say what single letter genders a pair of them.

Take *ṣadīq* back to ص-د-ص, ‘to be truthful’, and run the family *ṣidq*, *ṣādīq*, *ṣadaqa* and *aṣḍiqāʾ*, naming the faʿīl pattern it shares with *ḥalīb* and *malīḥ* and the doer shape it shares with *qāʾil* and *kātib*, then line up the people already owned — *ab*, *umm*, *akh*, *ukht* — against *jārī*, *ibn*, *bint* and *ṣadīqī*.

35.1 جار (jār) — “neighbour,” and a root with a letter in hiding

After a chapter of things you order, a chapter of people you introduce — starting with the one who lives next door.

The letters in this word

Nothing new, and it is short: ج (*jīm*, the hook-and-tail body with one dot below), ا (*alif*) and ر (*rā*). Both ا and ر are non-joiners, so جار barely joins at all — compare طعام, which broke once before its *mīm*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

جار (*jār*) = “a neighbour.” Add the “my” ending of اسمي (*ismī*) and you have جاري (*jārī*), “my neighbour” — which is how the word

usually arrives in a conversation.

Now listen to the root. You can hear only *j* and *r*. But an Arabic root wants three consonants, and the missing one is in hiding: the root is ج-و-ر, and its و has collapsed into that long *l*.

You have watched this before. قال (*qāla*), “he said,” is ل-و-ق with the same disappearing و. Arabic calls these **hollow** roots, and the hidden letter comes back when the word changes shape:

- جَاوَرَ (*jāwara*) — “he lived alongside.” There is the و, in the open.
- جِيرَان (*jīrān*) — “**neighbours**,” where it returns as a long *ī*.

Hebrew’s גֵּר (*ger*), a resident outsider living among a people, comes from the same Semitic root for dwelling alongside.

English **neighbour** is no relative — it is Germanic, the *nigh-dweller*. Two unrelated languages built one word out of one idea, worth noticing **because** it is not descent.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- jīm, alif, rā — “jār,” a neighbour
- with the my ending — “jārī,” my neighbour, as ismī is my name
- the hidden letter — the root is j-w-r, and the wāw is inside the alif
- the same hiding place — qāla, he said, from q-w-l
- where it comes back — jāwara; jīrān, neighbours
- the hook family by dots — ḥāʾ, khāʾ, jīm
- the restaurant you built — maṭʿam, the place of eating
- the honest non-cousin — English neighbour, the nigh-dweller

Before you move on

What is جار’s third root letter, and where has it gone? (و — collapsed into the long *alif*, as in *qāla* from ل-و-ق.) Where does it resurface? (In *jāwara* and *jīrān*.) How do you say “my

neighbour”? (*Jārī* — the ending of *ismī*.) Is English *neighbour* related? (**No** — Germanic, the *nigh-dweller*.)

35.2 ابن, بنت (ibn, bint) — son and daughter, one letter apart

A pair you can learn in one move, because Arabic has already shown you the move it uses.

The letters in this word

Nothing new in either. ابن is ا (alif), ب (*bā*², one dot below) and ن (*nūn*, one dot above) — two letters that share a bowl and differ only by where the dot sits.

بنت is the same ب and ن, then ت (*tā*², two dots above) on the end. Both words join throughout, unlike جار, which stopped twice.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ابن (*ibn*) = “a son.” بنت (*bint*) = “a daughter.”

What separates them is one ت, and nothing else.

You have met that letter doing that job. أخ (*akh*) is a brother; أخت (*ukht*) is a sister. Same word, one ت added for the feminine. Arabic does not build a separate word for the woman; it marks the word it has. (This is the bare cousin of the ة that marks *qahwa* feminine — same letter, tied instead of open.)

On the root, tradition and comparison disagree. Arab grammarians file ابن under ب-ي-ن-ب, “to build” — a son as what a house is built of, which is a lovely idea. Comparative scholars are less sure: Hebrew בן (*ben*) and בַּת (*bat*) show the same bare shape, more like a very old primitive word than something derived from a verb. Hold it loosely. Hebrew *bat* is *bint* with the **n** swallowed into the **t**. And *ibn* stands in plain sight inside names English carries: **Ibn Sīnā**, the physician the Latin west called Avicenna. No English **word** descends from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- alif, bā^ʔ, nūn — “ibn,” a son
- bā^ʔ, nūn, tā^ʔ — “bint,” a daughter
- the dots that separate bā^ʔ and nūn — one below, one above
- the move you already knew — akh, then ukht
- and the parents beside them — ab, a father; umm, a mother
- the loosely held root — b-n-y, to build, as the grammarians have it
- the Hebrew pair — ben, bat
- the neighbour, and the emphatic ṭā^ʔ of ṭa^cām — jāri; ṭa^cām, maṭ^cam

Before you move on

What is the only difference between ابن and بنت? (**An added ت** — as with **akh** and **ukht**.) And the parents? (**Ab** and **umm**.) What root do grammarians give *ibn*, and why hold it loosely? (ي-ن-ب, “**to build**” — but Hebrew *ben* and *bat* suggest an older bare word.) Where does *ibn* appear in a name English knows? (*Ibn Sīnā*, Avicenna.)

35.3 صديق (ṣadīq) — “friend,” the one who is true to you

The chapter closes on a word whose root is not about company at all. It is about telling the truth.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ص (*ṣād*) is the emphatic س, first met in صباح (*ṣabāḥ*) — heavy and dark where *sīn* is light. Then د (*dāl*), ي (*yā^ʔ*) carrying the long ī, and ق (*qāf*). د is a non-joiner, so صديق breaks after it: صد, then يق.

The feminine is صديقة (*ṣadīqa*) — the ّة, tied on the end, doing what it did to *qahwa*: the open ت of بنت and أخت in its tied form.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

صَدِيق (*ṣadīq*) = “a friend.” Root ص-د-ق, and the root means “to be truthful, to be sincere.”

A friend, in Arabic, is defined by honesty rather than proximity. The family agrees:

- صِدْق (*ṣidq*) — “truth, sincerity.”
- صَادِق (*ṣādiq*) — “truthful,” the **doer** shape worn by قَائِل (*qāʾil*, a sayer) and كَاتِب (*kātib*, a writer).
- صَدَقَة (*ṣadaqa*) — “voluntary alms.” A gift given for its own sake: a **true** gift, as against one owed.
- أَصْدِقَاء (*aṣḍiqāʾ*) — “friends.”

And now the pattern. صَدِيق is فَعِيل (*faʿīl*) — the shape of حَلِيب (*ḥalīb*), the milked thing, and مَلِيح (*malīḥ*), the salty one. Root plus *faʿīl* hands back a quality made into a person or a thing.

This is the machinery that turned سَلَام (*salām*) into السَّلَامَة (*as-salāma*): one root, several patterns, several words.

English took nothing from ص-د-ق. *Friend* is Germanic, from an old word for loving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ṣād, dāl, yāʾ, qāf — “ṣadīq,” a friend
- the emphatic pair — sīn light, ṣād heavy, as in ṣabāḥ
- what the root means — to be truthful; a friend is one who is true
- the family — ṣidq, ṣādiq, ṣadaqa, aṣḍiqāʾ
- the doer shape — qāʾil, kātib, ṣādiq
- the faʿīl shape — ḥalīb, malīḥ, ṣadīq
- the feminine — ṣadīqa, tied tāʾ, as as-salāma has it
- this chapter’s people — jāri with its two non-joiners, ibn, bint, ṣadīqī

- and the family you had — *ab*, *umm*, *akh*, *ukht*

Before you move on

What does ص-د-ق mean, and what does that make a friend? (**To be truthful** — the one who is true to you.) Name the family. (***Ṣidq***, ***ṣādiq***, ***ṣadaqa***, ***aṣḍiqāʿ***.) Which earlier words wear *ṣadīq*'s *faʿīl* pattern, and which wear *ṣādiq*'s doer shape? (***Ḥalīb*** and ***malīḥ***; ***qāʿīl*** and ***kātīb***.) Introduce the people you can now name. (***Jārī***, ***ibn***, ***bint***, ***ṣadīqī*** — beside ***ab***, ***umm***, ***akh***, ***ukht***.) What does the ʾ of *ṣadīqa* do? (**Marks it feminine** — as on *qahwa* and *as-salāma*.)

Chapter 36

Cups, Plates, and More Than One

Modes:  eyes (4)  Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for oil, a cup, a plate and a spoon in Arabic, and I can tell a broken plural from a sound one and say which kind of noun usually takes which.

Set the mi- tool shape of mil^caga and mir^oāh against the ma- place shape of maṭ^cam and maktab, then sort the plurals: akwāb, aṭbāq and malā^ciq re-poured into a new shape against qahawāt and ṣadīqāt, which only add an ending — and ask for each thing with min fadlik.

36.1 زيت (zayt) — “oil,” and a letter you already knew

One new letter to name — and you will find you already own it, because it is an old letter wearing a dot.

The letters in this word

ز is zāy, the z. And here is all there is to it: ز is ر (rā) with **one dot above**.

That is the abjad’s favourite trick. ب, ن and ت share one bowl and differ by dots. ح, خ and ج share one hook. Now ر and ز share one curve.

Everything rā does, zāy does: it hangs below the line and **refuses to join** what follows — the non-joiner that ended سكر.

Then ي (yā^o) and ت (tā^o). So زيت is ز alone, then يت joined.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

زَيْت (*zayt*) = “oil” — in the first place olive oil, and by extension oil of any kind. Root ت-ي-ز, which also gives:

- زَيْتُون (*zaytūn*) — “olives.”
- زَيْتُونَة (*zaytūna*) — “an olive,” one of them, with the tied ة making the single thing out of the collective.

And now Spain. You met **azúcar** and found Arabic’s **al-** welded onto its front. The same thing happened here, twice over:

- الزَّيْت (*az-zayt*) became Spanish **aceite**, “oil.”
- الزَّيْتُونَة (*az-zaytūna*) became Spanish **aceituna**, “an olive.”

ز is a **sun letter**, which is why *al-* is said *az-* — the assimilation that makes *al-* + *sukkar* into *as-sukkar*. Spanish took the sound it heard, article and all. Portuguese did the same with **azeite**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- zāy is rā plus one dot above, and it breaks as rā breaks
- the dot families — bāʾ, nūn, tāʾ; ḥāʾ, khāʾ, jīm; rā and zāy
- zāy, yāʾ, tāʾ — “zayt,” oil
- the olives — zaytūn; one olive, zaytūna
- the welded article — az-zayt gave aceite, as-sukkar gave azúcar
- the friend and his root — ṣadīq, from ṣ-d-q, to be true
- the pair one letter apart — ibn, bint

Before you move on

What is ز, described from a letter you had? (**Rā with one dot above** — and it breaks the same way.) What does ت-ي-ز give besides oil? (**Zaytūn** and **zaytūna**.) Which Spanish words carry

this root with Arabic's article stuck on, and which one did *sukkar* give? (*Aceite* and *aceituna*; *azúcar*.) Why *az-* rather than *al-*? (ج is a sun letter.)

36.2 كُوب (kūb) — “a cup,” and more than one of them

A short, useful word — and the door into the thing about Arabic nouns that surprises every learner.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ك (kāf), the angular *k*; و (wāw), here carrying the long *ū*; and ب (bāʾ).

و is a non-joiner, so كُوب goes كو, break, ب. Another non-joiner: ر ended *sukkar*, ر opened *zayt*, and و splits this.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كُوب (kūb) = “a cup.” Root ب-و-ك.

Now say “cups.” In English you add an *s*. In Arabic you do something else entirely:

أَكْوَاب (akwāb).

Nothing was added to the end. The root ب-و-ك was taken out of one shape and **poured into another**, أَفْعَال (afʿāl). Arabic calls this a **broken plural**, and it is not an exception — it is how most ordinary Arabic nouns make their plurals.

You have seen a root move between shapes many times: ب-ت-ك became *kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*, *maktaba*. A broken plural is that same machinery pointed at number instead of meaning. So this is not a new rule to learn. It is a rule you already have, doing a job you did not expect it to do.

On where *kūb* came from, honesty first. It sits close to a cup-word that travelled all round the Mediterranean — Latin **cuppa**, behind English **cup** and French **coupe**. Whether Arabic took it from that family, or the resemblance is coincidence, is **not settled**: a resemblance worth knowing, not a descent worth claiming.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- kāf, wāw, bāʾ — “kūb,” a cup
- more than one — “akwāb,” and nothing was added to the end
- what happened instead — the root was poured into the shape afʿāl
- the same machinery you had — kitāb, kātib, maktab, maktaba
- ask for one — “kūb māʾ, min faḍlik” — a cup of water, from your grace
- and answer the thanks — “ʿafwan”
- the odd old word for water — māʾ, whose plural miyāh follows no pattern
- the non-joiners — zāy in zayt, dāl in ṣadīq, wāw here

Before you move on

How does Arabic make “cups” out of كُوب? (*Akwāb* — the root is **re-poured into a new shape**, not given an ending. That is a **broken plural**.) Which earlier root shows the same shape-changing machinery? (ب-ت-ك — *kitāb, kātib, maktab, maktaba*.) Ask for a cup of water politely. (*Kūb māʾ, min faḍlik*.) And reply to thanks? (ʿ*Afwan*.) Did Arabic get *kūb* from Latin *cuppa*? (**Unsettled** — a resemblance, not a claim.)

36.3 طبق (ṭabaq) — “a plate,” and a broken plural that repeats

One broken plural is a surprise. Two in the same shape is a pattern — and a pattern you can use.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ط (*ṭāʾ*) is the emphatic ت, named when you built طعام (*ṭaʿām*) — the dark, flat-tongued *t*, standing beside ص under س and ض under د.

Then ب (*bāʾ*) and ق (*qāf*). All three join, so طبق runs unbroken — unlike كوب, which had to stop at its *wāw*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

طَبَق (*ṭabaq*) = “**a plate, a dish.**” Root ط-ب-ق.

Its plural is أَطْبَاق (*aṭbāq*).

Say that beside أَكْوَاب (*akwāb*) and listen. Same opening أَ, same long *ā* before the last letter, same nothing-added-at-the-end. Both are the shape أَفْعَال (*afʿāl*). So the broken plural is not chaos: it is a small set of shapes, and you have now met the commonest one twice.

The root itself means **to cover, to lie in layers** — a plate being the flat thing that covers. Which is why the same root gives:

- طَابِق (*ṭābiq*) — “**a storey**” of a building. A layer of house. And notice its shape: that is the **doer** form of *ṣādiq* and *kātib*.
- طَبَقَة (*ṭabaqa*) — “**a layer**,” and so “**a social class**,” with the tied *ḍ* on the end.

A plate, a floor and a social class, off one idea about layers. And the plates themselves belong somewhere you already built: مَطْعَم (*maṭʿam*), the place of eating.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ṭāʾ, bāʾ, qāf — “ṭabaq,” a plate
- the emphatic set once more — ṣād, ḍād, ṭāʾ
- the two broken plurals — akwāb, aṭbāq, both in the shape afʿāl
- what the root means — to cover, to lie in layers
- its other children — ṭābiq, a storey; ṭabaqa, a layer or a class
- where the plates live — maṭʿam, the place of eating

- the oil, whose *zāy* is *rā* plus a dot — *zayt*, *zaytūn*

Before you move on

What shape do أَكْوَاب and أَطْبَاق share? (*Af^cāl* — the broken plural you have now met twice.) What does ق-ب-ط mean? (**To cover, to lie in layers.**) Name two more words it builds. (*Tābiq*, a storey, and *ṭabaqa*, a layer or a class.) Which plain letter is ط the emphatic partner of? (*Tā^ʔ*.) Where would you find a stack of *aṭbāq*? (**In a maṭ^cam** — the place of eating.)

36.4 مِلْعَاقَة (mil^caqā) — “a spoon,” the tool shape, and two ways to say more than one

The last word, and it pays two debts at once: the shape that makes tools, and the question of how Arabic counts past one.

The letters in this word

Nothing new: م (*mīm*), ل (*lām*), ع (*ʿayn*, the throat sound), ق (*qāf*) — and then *ḍ*, the tied *tā^ʔ*.

That *ḍ* tells you, before anything else, that مِلْعَاقَة is **feminine** — the signal you read off قَهْوَة (*qahwa*), صَدِيقَة (*ṣadiqa*) and طَبَقَة (*ṭabaqa*).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مِلْعَاقَة (mil^caqā) = “a spoon.” Root ل-ع-ق, whose verb لَعَقَ (*la^ciqā*) means “he licked, he lapped.” A spoon is the thing you lap with. Two shapes now stand side by side, differing by one vowel:

- م, the **place** shape: مَكْتَب (maktab), the place of writing; مَطْعَم (maṭ^cam), the place of eating.
- م, the **tool** shape: مِرْآة (mir^ʔāh), the thing you see with; مِلْعَاقَة (mil^caqā), the thing you lap with.

Ma- builds a room. *Mi-* puts something in your hand.
Now the plurals this chapter has been circling.

Broken — the root re-poured, nothing added: أَكْوَاب (akwāb), أَطْبَاق (aṭbāq), مَلَاعِق (malā^ciq), spoons.

Sound — an ending added, the word left intact. Arabic uses it for the *ṣ* words: قَهْوَة gives قَهَوَات (*qahawāt*), and صَدِيقَة gives صَدِيقَات (*ṣadīqāt*). The rule of thumb: a noun in *ṣ* usually takes the added ending, and most other everyday nouns break. *Mil^caqā* is the honest reminder that “usually” is doing work — it ends in *ṣ* and breaks anyway.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- mīm, lām, ʿayn, qāf, tāʾ marbūṭa — “mil^caqā,” a spoon
- the verb under it — “la^ciqā,” he lapped
- the place shape — maktab, maṭʿam
- the tool shape — mirʾāḥ, mil^caqā
- the broken plurals — kūb with its breaking wāw gives akwāb; aṭbāq; malā^ciq
- the sound plurals — qahwa gives qahawāt, ṣadīqa gives ṣadīqāt
- the tied tāʾ marking feminine — qahwa, ṣadīqa, ṭabaqa, mil^caqā
- ask for each — “kūb, min faḍlik”; “ṭabaq, min faḍlik”; “mil^caqā, min faḍlik”
- and the oil — zayt, whose Spanish child is aceite

Before you move on

What separates م from مـ? (**Ma-** makes a place, **mi-** a tool — *maktab* and *maṭʿam* against *mirʾāḥ* and *mil^caqā*.) What does ل-ع-ق mean? (**To lap**.) Name this chapter’s broken plurals, and a sound one. (**Akwāb, aṭbāq, malā^ciq; qahawāt or ṣadīqāt.**) What does the *ṣ* on *mil^caqā* tell you? (**Feminine** — and unusually for a *ṣ* word, it still breaks.) Ask for a spoon politely. (**Mil^caqā, min faḍlik.**)

Chapter 37

The Tense That Was Missing

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can put a verb in the present tense for myself with the أَ- prefix, and I can say لا أفهم – ‘I do not understand’ – which is the sentence a beginner needs most and which this book was one form away from for six chapters.

Eleven verbs taught as third-person past forms become first-person present forms, and each of them is then denied – so a reading list turns into a speaking stock on one prefix.

37.1 أَكْتُبُ (aktub) — the tense that was missing

Eleven verbs in this book and every one of them is a **past** tense, third person, masculine: *kataba*, “he wrote.” Nothing here has ever happened now, and nothing has ever happened to **you**.

You’ll want to know: the أَ- in front

كُتِبَ — *kataba* — **he wrote** · أَكْتُبُ — *aktub* — **I write**

سَأَلَ — *saʿala* — **he asked** · أَسْأَلُ — *asʿal* — **I ask**

The past tense marks who is speaking at the **end** of the word. The present marks it at the **front**, with a prefix, and أَ is the prefix for *I*. Nothing is added at the back at all.

Grammar Lens: the front of the word, not the back

root	past, he	present, I
ب-ت-ك	كتب	أكتب
ل-أ-س	سأل	أسأل
ب-ب-ح	أحب	أحب

The third row is a warning as much as an example: أَحَبَّ is *he loved* and *I love* on the page, and only the vowels tell them apart — *aḥabba* against *uḥibb*. Arabic does not usually write those vowels. Context does the work, and this is where a reader starts needing it.

That *أ* is old. Hebrew and Aramaic mark their first person the same way, at the front, with the same letter. It is older than either language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — *kataba ... aktub*
- the second pair — *saʿala ... asʿal*
- *uḥibb* — I love
- the one this book most needs, in romanization — *afham*, I understand

Before you move on

Where does the past tense mark the person, and where does the present? (**Past at the end; present at the front.**) Which letter is the prefix for *I*? (أ.) And why can أَحَبَّ be read two ways? (**The vowels that separate them are not written.**)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

37.2 لا أفهم (lā afham) — I do not understand

لا has been in this book since chapter five, named there as the word that negates a present-tense verb. The book had no present-tense verb until the lesson before this one.

- *Recall*: the item before this — the prefix that means *I*, on *aktub*

You'll want to know: أفهم لا

أفهم لا — *lā afham* — **I do not understand.**

Two words, and both halves were already in the book: لا from chapter five, and فهم — *fahima*, “he understood” — from chapter thirty-one. All that was missing was the prefix the last lesson taught.

لا goes in **front** of the verb, which is where the chapter-five lesson said it goes, and the verb keeps its own shape.

Grammar Lens: the same operation on every verb you own

said	means
أكتب	I write
أكتب لا	I do not write
أسأل لا	I do not ask

Nothing moves and nothing is added at the end. This is the operation a beginner uses more than any other, and this book could not perform it on any verb until this chapter.

One note on the page rather than the language: فاء, the letter in the middle of أفهم, has no lesson in this track's script ladder yet, so the sentence is printed whole here, in the lesson that owns it, and named in romanization wherever else it appears.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lā afham*
- the affirmative it denies — *afham*
- *lā aktub ... lā asʿal*

Before you move on

Where does لا stand in relation to the verb? (**In front of it.**) Which two chapters supplied the halves of this sentence? (**Five**, for لا, and

thirty-one, for فهم.) And what did the sentence need that neither of them had? (**The present tense**, from the lesson before this one.)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

37.3 Now, and not

Two items landed in this chapter and one of them was a whole tense. Name the prefix, and name the sentence it unlocked.

Your turn

- *Say it*: three verbs in the past, as the book taught them — *kataba*, *saʿala*, *fahima*
- *Say it*: the same three in the present, for yourself — *aktub*, *asʿal*, *afham*
- *Say it*: each of them denied — *lā aktub*, *lā asʿal*, *lā afham*
- *Recall*: the very first verb this book taught, nine chapters back — *dhahaba*

Before you move on

Which end of the verb carries the person in the present tense? (**The front.**) Where does ٴ go? (**In front of the whole verb.**) And how many new words did *lā afham* need? (**None** — both halves were already taught, and only the tense was missing.)

Chapter 38

Two at Once

Modes: ⇐ voice (3) 👁 eyes (2) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can join two nouns with و, offer a choice with أو, turn a clause against the one before it with لكن, and accept what somebody said with حسناً.

The pantry and family of chapters 33-36 – tea, coffee, milk, sugar, salt, meat, cheese, food, a cup, a spoon, a son, a daughter, a neighbour, a friend – becomes combinable for the first time, joined, offered and turned.

38.1 و (wa-) — and

Chapter one taught the reply to the greeting and said of it: *hear the little wa- at the front; it means and*. That sentence taught nothing. This book has thirty-six chapters of vocabulary and has never joined two words.

You'll want to know: و

والحليب الشاي — *ash-shāy wa-l-ḥalīb* — **the tea and the milk**.

واللحم الملح — *al-milḥ wa-l-laḥm* — **the salt and the meat**.

One letter, and it is **written joined to the word that follows it**, never with a space after it. That is why it looks like part of the next word and why it has been on the page in front of you since chapter one without ever being a word you owned.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

و is the same conjunction Hebrew and Aramaic write with a single letter, in the same job, and it has held that job for three thousand years. It is by a wide margin the commonest word in written Arabic: Arabic prose strings clauses with و where English would use a full stop, so a page of Arabic has far more *ands* in it than a page of English ever does.

Note that و is also the letter *wāw*, the long *ū* inside كُوب and يَوْم. One shape, two jobs, told apart by whether it stands alone at the head of a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ash-shāy wa-l-ḥalīb*
- *al-milḥ wa-l-laḥm*
- three at once — *ash-shāy wa-l-ḥalīb wa-s-sukkar*
- the greeting reply that carried it all along — *wa-^calaykum as-salām*

Before you move on

Is و written with a space after it? (**No** — it is joined to the word it introduces.) Which two languages write the same conjunction with the same single letter? (**Hebrew and Aramaic.**) And where has it been sitting since chapter one? (**At the front of the greeting reply.**)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

38.2 و (aw) — or

و gives somebody both things. Nothing in this book has ever made anybody choose.

- *Recall:* the joiner from the lesson before, and where it is written — *wa-*, joined on

You'll want to know: أو

الحليب أو الشاي — *ash-shāy aw al-ḥalīb* — **the tea or the milk.**

Unlike و, this one stands as its own word with a space on each side. It sits where و sits, between the two things, and nothing else in the sentence changes.

Look at the shape: أ — the hamza-carrying alif you know from أكل — followed by و, the letter that on its own means *and*. Arabic's two coordinators are one letter apart and mean opposite things.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أو is Semitic ^ʿ*aw*, the same word Hebrew keeps. It is the whole apparatus a host needs: two nouns, أو between them, and the question particle a later lesson in this book will add. Until this lesson the corpus could name coffee, tea, milk and sugar and could not offer any one of them against another.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ash-shāy aw al-qahwa*
- the same pair joined instead of split — *ash-shāy wa-l-qahwa*
- and hear the difference — one hands you both, one makes you pick
- *bi-sukkar aw bi-dūn* — with sugar or without

Before you move on

Which joiner is written joined to the next word, and which stands apart? (و joins on; أو stands apart.) Which letter do they share? (و.) And which of them makes somebody choose? (أو.)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

38.3 لكن (lākin) — but

Two joiners so far. One adds, one chooses, and neither of them can disagree with anything.

- *Recall:* the two items before this one — *wa-*, *aw*

You'll want to know: لكن

أسمع لكن لا أكتب — *asma^c lākin lā aktub* — **I hear, but I do not write.**

And with the sentence chapter thirty-seven built, whose verb carries a letter the script ladder has not reached: *asma^c lākin lā afham*, **I hear, but I do not understand.**

لا الحليب لكن حلو الشاي — *ash-shāy ḥulw lākin al-ḥalīb lā* — **the tea is sweet but the milk is not.**

و puts two clauses on the same side. لكن turns the second one against the first, and it stands at the head of the clause it turns.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Look at the first two letters: لا, the negator this book taught in chapter five, with an old particle behind it. Arabic's *but* has a *not* inside it. English did the same thing by a different road. **But** is Old English *be-ūtan*, “be **out**, except” — and *out* is still visible in it if you look. Two unrelated languages built their adversative out of a word for leaving something aside.

In writing you will also meet لكنّ with a shadda, which takes a following noun in the accusative. The plain لكن in this lesson joins clauses and asks nothing of what follows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *asma^c lākin lā afham*
- the same two clauses with the other joiner — *asma^c wa-afham*
- and hear what changed — the second clause no longer argues
- *ash-shāy wa-l-ḥalīb ... ash-shāy lākin lā al-ḥalīb*

Before you move on

Which word is hiding at the front of لكن? (لا, the negator from chapter five.) Which English word was built the same way? (**But**, from *be-ūtan*, “be out.”) And what does لكن do that و cannot? (**Turn the second clause against the first.**)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

38.4 حسناً (ḥasanan) — all right

نعم and لا answer a question. Neither of them says *I am following you*, and a conversation needs that more often than it needs an answer.

- *Recall*: the joiner from the lesson before, and the negator inside it — *lākin*

You'll want to know: حسناً

حسناً — *ḥasanan* — all right; fine; very well.

... لكن حسناً, — *ḥasanan, lākin ...* — all right, but ...

The ending is one you have written twice already. شكرًا and عافان wear the same ة, the two-stroke *tanwīn* over an alif that turns an Arabic adjective into an adverb. The root here is حَسَن, *ḥasan*, “good, beautiful.” So *ḥasanan* is literally *goodly*.

Grammar Lens: agreeing, and half-agreeing

said	does
نعم	answers a question
حسناً	accepts what was said
... لكن حسناً,	accepts, and then turns

The third row is the shape almost every real disagreement takes. A learner who can only say نعم or لا has to accept or refuse whole; this is the first thing in the book that lets them do neither.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ḥasanan*
- the three words with the same ending — *shukran*, *ʿafwan*, *ḥasanan*
- the half-agreement — *ḥasanan*, *lākin* ...

Before you move on

What does the *ʿ* ending do to an Arabic adjective? (**Turns it into an adverb.**) Which two words in this book already wear it? (شكراً and *ʿafwan*.) And what does حسناً do that نعم does not? (**Accepts what was said**, without answering a question.)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

38.5 Two at once

Three joiners landed in this chapter. Name them, and say for each one whether it adds, chooses, or turns — and which of the three is written joined to the word after it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *ash-shāy wa-l-qahwa*, then *ash-shāy aw al-qahwa*
- *Say it:* the half-agreement — *ḥasanan*, *lākin* ...
- *Recall:* five lessons back, the prefix that means *I* — on *aktub*

Your turn: the distant band — every noun in the pantry, two at a time

This is what the chapter actually bought. Chapters thirty-three to thirty-six taught a pantry and a family that could only ever be named one item at a time — and every one of them is now combinable. Take them two at a time, cold, from memory.

Say these aloud:

- the four drinks and their sweetener — *ash-shāy wa-l-qahwa wa-l-ḥalāb wa-s-sukkar*

- the same four as a choice, two at a time — *shāy aw qahwa, ḥalīb aw sukkar*
- what is on the table — *al-milḥ wa-l-laḥm wa-l-jubn*, and over it all *aṭ-ṭaʿām*
- what you eat it with — *kūb wa-milʿaqa*
- the people — *ibn wa-bint, jār wa-ṣadīq*
- one of each, turned — *ash-shāy lākin lā al-qahwa*

Before you move on

Which of this chapter's joiners has a negator inside it? (لكن.) Which one is a single letter with no space after it? (و.) And which word accepts what somebody said without answering a question? (حسنًا.)

Chapter 39

Denying, and Asking

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can deny a nominal sentence with ليس, a past-tense verb with ما and a present-tense verb with لا, refuse two things at once with لا ... ولا, and turn any of them into a yes-or-no question with هل.

Three negators sorted by the kind of sentence each one owns, then every one of them asked back with هل – so نعم and لا, taught in chapter 5 as answers, finally have a question to answer.

39.1 ليس (laysa) — is not

حسن اسمي — *my name is Hasan* — is a complete Arabic sentence with no verb in it, and it is the sentence shape this book teaches best. Try to deny it with لا and there is no verb for لا to stand in front of.

- *Recall:* the joiner two lessons back that has لا hiding inside it — *lākin*

You'll want to know: ليس

حسن ليس اسمي — *ismī laysa Ḥasan* — **my name is not Hasan.**

ماء ليس الحليب — *al-ḥalīb laysa māʾan* — **milk is not water.**

Arabic leaves the present-tense *is* out. To deny a sentence that never had one, the language supplies a word that exists only for that job — and ليس is it.

Notice the َ on ماءً: ليس puts what follows it in the accusative, which is the one grammatical demand it makes and the reason its predicate wears a tanwīn where the affirmative would not.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Arab grammarians read ليس as لا — the negator of chapter five — welded to أيس, an old word meaning *there is*. So the word began as *there-is-not*, and it still behaves like a verb: it takes person endings, even though nothing it denies is a verb. It is a fossil doing a job nothing else in the language does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the affirmative, then the denial — *ismī Ḥasan ... ismī laysa Ḥasan*
- *al-ḥalīb laysa māʿan*
- *ash-shāy laysa ḥalīban*

Before you move on

Why can a nominal sentence not be denied with لا? (**There is no verb for لا to stand in front of** — Arabic leaves *is* out.) What are the two pieces grammarians find inside ليس? (لا and أيس, *there is*.) And what does ليس do to the word after it? (**Puts it in the accusative.**)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

39.2 ما (mā) — did not

لا denies a present-tense verb and ليس denies a sentence with no verb at all. Eleven verbs in this book are in the **past**, and neither of those two touches them.

- *Recall*: the item before this one, and what it demands of the word after it — *laysa*

You'll want to know: ما

ما كتب — *mā kataba* — **he did not write.**

ما أكل — *mā akala* — **he did not eat.**

Arabic uses a **different word** to negate the past from the one it uses for the present. لا in front of a past-tense verb is not a weaker sentence; it is the wrong word.

Grammar Lens: three negators, three kinds of sentence

negator	denies	example
لا	a present-tense verb	<i>lā aktub</i>
ما	a past-tense verb	<i>mā kataba</i>
ليس	a sentence with no verb	<i>ismī laysa Ḥasan</i>

That is the whole of A1 Arabic negation in three rows, and this chapter is where the second and third of them arrive.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

You have written these two letters before. اسمك ما — *what is your name?* — opens chapter two, and that ما means *what*. It is the same word. Semitic languages carry one very general particle that Arabic puts to work as *what*, as *not*, and as *as long as*, and only its position in the sentence tells you which one you are reading.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kataba ... mā kataba*
- the present beside the past — *lā aktub ... mā kataba*
- the two jobs of the same two letters — *mā ismuka? ... mā akala*

Before you move on

Which negator goes with a past-tense verb, which with a present, and which with no verb? (ليس, لا, ما) Which question word is

spelled the same as this one? (ما, *what*.) And what tells the two apart? (**Where they stand in the sentence.**)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

39.3 لا ... ولا ... — neither, nor

The last chapter taught the joiner that adds. This lesson uses it to refuse — which is the one place a coordinator and a negator arrive as a single written word.

- *Recall*: the negator of the past, from the lesson before — *mā*

You'll want to know: لا ... ولا ...

حليب ولا شاي لا — *lā shāy wa-lā ḥalīb* — **neither tea nor milk.**

One لا in front of the first thing, and ولا — the joiner و written onto a second لا — in front of the next. English needs two different words, *neither* and *nor*; Arabic uses the same word twice and glues the *and* onto the second.

Grammar Lens: the mirror of the joiner

said	means
والحليب الشاي	the tea and the milk
حليب ولا شاي لا	neither tea nor milk

The second line is the first with a لا put in front of each thing. Nothing else changes — and the definite article drops, because you are refusing tea in general rather than a particular cup of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lā shāy wa-lā ḥalīb*
- the affirmative it mirrors — *ash-shāy wa-l-ḥalīb*
- *lā qahwa wa-lā sukkar*

Before you move on

How many negators does *neither ... nor* need in Arabic? (**Two, and they are the same word.**) What is welded onto the second one? (و, the joiner.) And what happens to the definite article? (**It drops** — the refusal is general.)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

39.4 هل (hal) — a question is coming

نعم and لا were taught in chapter five as answers. Thirty-four chapters later this book still cannot ask the question they answer.

- *Recall:* the double refusal from the lesson before — *lā shāy wa-lā ḥalīb*

You'll want to know: هل

هل أنت بخير — *hal anta bi-khayr?* — **are you well?**

هل كتب — *hal kataba?* — **did he write?**

Put هل at the front of any statement and it becomes a yes-or-no question. Nothing else in the sentence moves — no word order changes, no ending changes.

Arabic **needs** the word. English asks by moving the verb in front of the subject; Bengali and Urdu ask by letting the voice rise. Written Arabic does neither: the particle carries the whole question, which is why a page of Arabic tells you a question is coming before you have read any of it.

Grammar Lens: what the particle replaces

language	how a yes-or-no question is marked
English	the verb moves in front of the subject
Arabic	هل at the front, and nothing moves

A negative asks the same way, and that is the ordinary way to check something you suspect: *hal laysa hunāka shāy?* Answer either with نعم

or with لا.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hal anta bi-khayr?* — and answer it *naʿam* or *lā*
- *hal kataba?*
- the statement, then the question — *anta bi-khayr ... hal anta bi-khayr?*

Before you move on

What moves when an Arabic statement becomes a yes-or-no question? (**Nothing** — هل goes at the front.) Why can it not be done with the voice alone, as in Bengali or Urdu? (**Written Arabic marks it with a particle.**) And which two words answer it? (نعم and لا, from chapter five.)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

39.5 Denying, and asking

Arabic has three negators and each one owns a different kind of sentence. Name all three, and say what each one denies.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the verbless sentence denied — *ismī laysa Ḥasan*
- *Say it:* the past denied — *mā kataba*
- *Say it:* the present denied — *lā aktub*, and *lā afham*
- *Say it:* both refused at once — *lā shāy wa-lā ḥalīb*
- *Say it:* each of those asked back — put *hal* in front and change nothing else
- *Recall:* six lessons back, the word that accepts what was said — *ḥasanan*

Before you move on

Which negator would you use for *حسن اسمي*, which for *كتب*, and which for *أكتب*? (*ليس*, then *ما*, then *لا*.) What does *هل* ask of the sentence it fronts? (**Nothing at all** — it only marks it.)

Chapter 40

Why, That, and When

Modes: ⇨ voice (4) 👁 eyes (1) ⇨ Hands-free start: first 1 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask why with لماذا, answer it with لأن, report what I write or think with أُن, and put one event beside another in time with حينما.

The first three-clause Arabic sentence in this track: an acceptance, an objection and a reason, built from حسناً, لكن and لأن over the present tense of chapter 37.

40.1 لماذا (limādhā) — why

This book can ask *what, how, how much* and — since the last chapter — *yes or no*. It has never been able to ask for a reason.

- *Recall:* the particle from the lesson before, and what it moves — *hal*, and nothing

You'll want to know: لماذا

لماذا؟ — *limādhā?* — **why?**

It is a compound and every piece is recoverable: ل, the preposition *for*, plus ما, *what* — which is itself ما plus ذا, *this*. Arabic's *why* is transparently **for-what-this**.

And the ما inside it is the same particle the last chapter taught as the negator of the past tense, and the same one chapter two taught as *what* in اسمك ما. Three jobs, one word, told apart by where it stands.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

لماذا and هل are the two ends of Arabic questioning. هل asks for a yes or a no and adds no information; لماذا asks for a whole clause back, and the next lesson supplies the word that clause begins with.

The letter ل in the middle of this word has no lesson in this track's script ladder yet, so the word is printed whole here, in the lesson that owns it, and named in romanization wherever else it appears.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *limādhā?* — on its own
- the question words this book now owns — *mā, kayfa, kam, hal, limādhā*
- the pieces it is built from — *li- ... mā ... dhā*

Before you move on

What are the three pieces of لماذا? (ل for, ما what, ذا this.) Which of them has the book already taught twice, in two different jobs? (ما — what in chapter two, did not in chapter thirty-nine.) And what does لماذا ask for that هل does not? (**A whole clause.**)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

40.2 لأن (li-anna) — because

The lesson before this taught the question. A question nobody can answer is worse than no question at all.

- *Recall:* the item before this, and the three pieces inside it — *limādhā*

You'll want to know: لأن

لا أكتب لأنني أسمع لا — *lā aktub li-annanī lā asma^c* — **I am not writing because I do not hear.**

Look at the first letter. *limādhā* opens with ل, *for*, and so does this word — with اُنْ, *that*, behind it instead of a question word. Arabic's *why* and *because* are one particle apart, and both are visibly built out of pieces rather than borrowed whole.

لْ needs a subject after it, so for *I* it becomes لِأَنْنِي, *li-annanī*. That is one ending on one word, and it is the only thing the construction asks of you.

Grammar Lens: the claim, then the reason

head word	what follows it
لكن	an objection
لأن	a reason

Both stand at the head of the clause they govern, and both come **after** the claim they attach to. Put them in one sentence and you have the shape of an argument.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the question, then the answer word — *limādhā?* ... *li-anna*
- *lā aktub li-annanī lā asma^c*
- an objection and a reason in one breath — *ḥasanan, lākin* ... *li-anna*
- ...

Before you move on

Which letter do *limādhā* and اُنْ share, and what does it mean? (ل, *for*.) What follows it in each? (**A question word** in one, **a complementiser** in the other.) And which comes first, the claim or the reason? (**The claim**.)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

40.3 اُنْ (anna) — that

fakkara — *he thought* — has been in this book since chapter thirty-two, and nobody has ever been able to say **what** they think.

- *Recall*: the reason word from the lesson before, and the piece behind its ل — *li-anna*

You'll want to know: أَنْ

أَنْ أَكْتُبْ — أَكْتُبُ أَنَّنِي سَامِي جَارِي — *aktub anna Sāmī jāri* — **I write that Sami is my neighbour.**

أَنْ takes a whole sentence and makes it the object of a verb of writing, saying, knowing or thinking. Everything before it is the frame; everything after it is the reported thing.

You met it one lesson ago without being told: لَأَنْ is ل plus this word. The shadda over the ن is the doubling mark, and it belongs to the word — this is **anna**, with the *n* doubled, not **ana**.

Grammar Lens: what follows it

The clause after أَنْ is a **nominal** sentence — two nouns side by side, the shape chapter two taught — and أَنْ puts the first of them in the accusative, in the same way لَيْسَ does to what follows it. Two particles, one grammatical habit, and it is worth seeing them together. English lets *that* be dropped: *I think it is good*. Arabic does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aktub anna Sāmī jāri*
- the word it hides in — *li-anna ... anna*
- with the verb from chapter thirty-two, in romanization — *fakkara anna ...*

Before you move on

Where have you already read أَنْ? (**Inside** لَأَنْ, in the lesson before.)
 What kind of clause follows it? (**A nominal sentence**, whose first noun goes into the accusative.) And can it be dropped, the way English drops *that*? (**No**.)
 Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

40.4 حينما (ḥīnamā) — when

أُ hangs a sentence off a **verb**. This lesson's word hangs one off a **moment**.

- *Recall*: the complementiser from the lesson before — *anna*

You'll want to know: حينما

كتب جاء، حينما — ḥīnamā jā^ʔa, kataba — **when he came, he wrote.**

أسمع حينما أكتب — aktub ḥīnamā asma^c — **I write when I hear.**

The clause it opens can come first or second, and Arabic marks the seam with a comma when it comes first — which is the same rule English follows and one of the few places the two languages punctuate alike.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

حين is an ordinary noun meaning **a time, a moment**, and ما is the same general particle you have now met three times: as *what* in chapter two, as the past-tense negator in chapter thirty-nine, and inside *limādhā* in this chapter. Stuck onto حين it makes *at-the-moment-that*. Arabic writes another word here, ^cindamā, built the same way on a preposition meaning *at*. It is the commoner of the two in modern prose and it needs a letter this track's script ladder has not reached, so it is named in romanization and left for a script lesson. حينما costs no new letters at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ḥīnamā jā^ʔa, kataba
- the same joined the other way round — kataba ḥīnamā jā^ʔa
- aktub ḥīnamā asma^c

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of حينما (حين, a moment, and ما.) How many jobs has that ما now done in this book? (**Three** — *what, did not*, and this one.) And when does Arabic put a comma at the seam? (**When the time clause comes first**, as English does.)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

40.5 Why, that, and when

Four items landed in this chapter and three of them share a piece with another. Name all four, and say which piece each one shares.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the question and its answer — *limādhā?* ... *li-anna* ...
- *Say it:* a reported thought — *aktub anna Sāmī jāri*
- *Say it:* a moment — *ḥīnamā jāʿa, kataba*
- *Say it:* the three-clause sentence — *ḥasanan, lākin lā afham li-annanī lā asma^c*
- *Recall:* six lessons back, the particle that makes any statement a question — *hal*
- *Recall:* eleven lessons back, the joiner written with no space after it — *wa-*

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter's words begin with the same ʾ? (*limādhā* and لَأَن.) Which particle sits inside لَأَن? (أَنَّ.) And which of the four hangs a clause off a moment rather than off a verb? (حينما.)

Chapter 41

Calling Somebody, and Asking Again

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can call somebody by name with يا, ask them to say it again with فضلك من كرّر, and run the whole first meeting of chapters one to four with the repair kit inside it.

The greeting, name and wellbeing exchanges of chapters 1-4 – untouched for more than a hundred lessons – are run cold and then broken on purpose, so the learner uses أفهم لا, عفوًا and فضلك من كرّر to get the conversation back.

41.1 يا (yā) — calling somebody

Chapter two taught you to give your name and to ask for somebody else's. Forty chapters later you still cannot **call** them by it.

- *Recall:* the time joiner from the lesson before — ḥīnamā

You'll want to know: يا

يا حسن — yā Ḥasan — **Hasan!** (calling him)

يا جار — yā jār — **neighbour!**

Arabic does not address a person with a bare name. *حسن* on its own is a statement *about* Hasan; *يا حسن* is speaking *to* him. The particle is not optional politeness — it is how the language marks the difference between naming somebody and calling them.

Two letters, both long since yours, and no ending changes on the name.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

يا is pan-Semitic and English has no particle of its own to match it. The one place English reaches for something similar is old translation — *O Lord, O Israel* — where the *O* is standing in for exactly this. It sounds archaic in English and is entirely everyday in Arabic. It goes before a title or a kin term as readily as before a name: *يا ابن يا*, بنت, *yā ṣaḍīqī*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *yā Ḥasan*
- *yā jār ... yā ṣaḍīqī*
- the name alone, then called — *Ḥasan ... yā Ḥasan*

Before you move on

What is the difference between *حسن* and *يا حسن*? (**One names him; the other calls him.**) Does the name change shape after it? (**No.**) And what does English use where Arabic uses *يا*? (**Nothing, ordinarily** — only *O* in old translation.)
Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

41.2 فضلك من كرّر — say it again, please

Chapter thirty-seven gave you the first thing a lost learner says. Saying it only helps if you can also ask for the sentence back.

- *Recall*: the particle from the lesson before, and what it turns a name into — *yā*

You'll want to know: كَرِّر

كَرِّر — *karrir* — **repeat**.

كَرِّر من فضلك — *karrir min faḍlik* — **say it again, please**.

The *please* is not new: chapter six taught it. What is new is the verb, and the shape it comes in — this is the first **command** in the book, and Arabic builds one by stripping the present tense back to its bare stem.

Look at the shadda. كَرِّر doubles its middle letter, which is the same Form II shape as *fakkara* in chapter thirty-two — a pattern that means *do it thoroughly, do it repeatedly*. On the root ر-ج-ك, “to return”, that gives exactly *do it again*.

Grammar Lens: the repair kit, whole

when

you did not follow

you want it again

you are grateful for it

say

lā afham

karrir min faḍlik

shukran

The inventory that measured this track said the repair kit was strong with one hole in it: sorry, excuse me, pardon, please and thank you were all taught, and *I do not understand* and *say it again* were not. Those two are what chapters thirty-seven and forty-one add, and between them they needed one new verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *karrir*
- *karrir min faḍlik*
- the whole kit in order — *lā afham ... karrir min faḍlik ... shukran*
- and get their attention first — *yā Ḥasan, karrir min faḍlik*

Before you move on

Which chapter taught the *please* in this sentence? (**Six.**) Which earlier verb wears the same doubled shape? (**fakkara**, chapter thirty-two.) And what does that shape add to a root? (**Doing it thoroughly, or again.**)

Source: Unicode Arabic chart.

41.3 Calling somebody, and asking again

Two items landed in this chapter: one gets somebody's attention and one asks them for the sentence back. Name both.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *yā Ḥasan, karrir min faḍlik*
- *Say it:* the reason you are asking — *lā afham li-annanī lā asma^c*
- *Recall:* four lessons back, the particle that fronts a question — *hal*
- *Recall:* nine lessons back, the word that accepts what was said — *ḥasanan*
- *Recall:* five lessons back, ask why, then report the answer — *limādhā? ... aktub anna ...*
- *Recall:* ten lessons back, refuse both at once — *lā shāy wa-lā ḥalīb*

Your turn: the distant band — the first meeting, and what to do when it goes wrong

The exchange this book opened with was taught more than a hundred lessons ago and has not been asked for since. It is also the exact place a beginner loses the thread. Run it cold, and put the new chapter inside it.

Say these aloud:

- the greeting and its reply, and hear the 9 at the front of the reply — *as-salāmu ʿalaykum ... wa-ʿalaykum as-salām*
- the name exchange — *mā ismuka? ... ismī ... tasharrafnā*
- the wellbeing exchange — *kayfa ḥāluka? ... bi-khayr, al-ḥamdu li-llāh*

- now lose the thread and rescue it — *‘afwan, lā afham. karrir min faḍlik*
- thank them, and close — *shukran ... ma‘a s-salāma*

Before you move on

Five chapters ago this book could not say a verb in the present, deny a nominal sentence, join two nouns, ask a yes-or-no question, give a reason, or say that it had not understood. Say the sentence that was one tense away for thirty-one chapters. (***lā afham.***) Say what you ask next. (***karrir min faḍlik.***) And say how you get somebody’s attention first. (***yā* plus their name.**)

Pronunciation & Script — a reference

A **reference**, not a chapter — a place to look things up as you go, never a wall to climb first. Chapter 1 (the reading course) teaches you to decode the script from zero, letter by letter, each letter introduced as a word needs it; this page just collects the sound-and-script facts in one spot. Lessons name the sounds they need and link here.

Transliteration note: this curriculum writes Arabic in both the **script** (مرحبا) and a **Latin transliteration** (*marḥaban*), with a dot under a letter marking the “heavy”/emphatic or throaty consonants.

The script, in one breath

- **Right to left.** Eyes and writing both go right → left.
- **Letters connect.** Most letters join to the next, so a letter has up to four shapes (isolated / initial / medial / final). You don’t drill these — you re-meet them inside real words.
- **Short vowels are often unwritten.** *a, i, u* are usually diacritics (harakāt) left off in everyday text; long vowels (ā, ī, ū) are written as letters (ا و ي).

Consonants with no English equivalent

- **ha-heavy** — ح (ḥ): a “heavy” *h*, breathed hard from deep in the throat (vs. the light ه *h*). *marḥaban, ṣabāḥ*.
- **kha** — خ (kh): a guttural scrape at the back of the throat = Scottish *loch*, German *Bach*, **Spanish** *j* (*jueves*). *khayr*.

- **ayn** — ع (ʿ, “ayn”): a tightening deep in the throat, voiced. No English equivalent; approximate it. *ʿalaykum*, *ʿafwan*.
- **hamza** — ء (ʾ): a **glottal stop**, the catch in “uh-oh.” *masāʾ*.
- غ (gh): like a French/guttural *r* (gargled *g*). ق (q): a *k* made far back, at the uvula.

Emphatic (“heavy”) consonants

- **emphatic-sad** — ص (ṣ), ض (ḍ), ط (ṭ), ظ (ẓ): heavier, deeper versions of *s*, *d*, *t*, *dh*, made with the tongue lower and the mouth fuller. They genuinely change the word (ص *ṣ* ≠ س *s*). *ṣabāḥ*.

Light consonants (close to English)

- **shin** — ش (sh) = English *sh* (*shukran*). س (s) = plain *s*. ب (b), ل (l), م (m), ر (r, a tapped/rolled *r* like Spanish), ن (n), ك (k), ت (t) — all near their English values.

The definite article and “sun/moon letters”

- **sun-moon** — ال (al-, “the”) attaches to its noun. Before a **sun letter** (ن ل ظ ط ض ص ش س ز ر ذ د ت) the *l* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al-salām* → **as-salām**, *al-nūr* → **an-nūr**. Before a **moon letter** (the rest, e.g. ب ك ق خ) the *l* stays: **al-khayr**. You can hear the sun-letter rule fossilized in Spanish *azúcar* (← *as-sukkar*).

The root system (structure, not pronunciation)

- Most words are built on a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed vowel **patterns**: k-t-b (writing) → *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office). Learn a root and a few patterns, and you generate a whole family. See the first lesson.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

أَكَلَ *akala*

“he ate” — no new letters, no English cousin, and a Hebrew twin close enough to hear; the sixth verb, closing the set

Introduced in Chapter 30.

الحمد لله *al-ḥamdu lillāh*

praise be to God — the everyday answer to ‘how are you?’

Introduced in Chapter 3.

السلامة *as-salāma*

the safety — Chapter 1’s *salām*, plus a pattern and a feminine ending

Introduced in Chapter 4.

as-salāmu °alaykum

peace be upon you

Introduced in Chapter 1.

أَوْ *aw*

or — two letters, and the word an offer cannot be made without

Introduced in Chapter 38.

بخير *bi-khayr*

well, fine — literally ‘in goodness’

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ذهب *dhahaba*

he went” — the track’s first verb, and the clearest possible view of the root-and-pattern engine, since the same three consonants also give “gold” and “a school of law

Introduced in Chapter 28.

فهم *fahima*

“he understood” — the first verb whose middle vowel is not an *a*, marking it a state rather than a deed, and the done-to shape that turns it into the word for a concept

Introduced in Chapter 31.

فَكَرَ *fakkara*

“he thought” — the first verb that is not a bare root at all, but a root rebuilt by doubling its middle letter, and the mu- doer that comes with the rebuild
Introduced in Chapter 32.

حَالِ *hāl*

state, condition — the thing Arabic actually asks about
Introduced in Chapter 3.

حَلِيبِ *halīb*

“milk” — the opposite case to shāy: a home-grown noun sitting straight on the verb for milking, and a Hebrew twin that is the same word
Introduced in Chapter 33.

حَسَنًا *hasanan*

all right, fine, very well — the backchannel this track had no word for, and the first way a learner can agree with somebody
Introduced in Chapter 38.

حِينَمَا *hīnamā*

when — the clause joiner that puts one event beside another in time, with the same مَا inside it the last chapter taught twice
Introduced in Chapter 40.

بنت ابن *ibn, bint*

son and daughter — one pair gendered by a single added ت, exactly as أَخ and أُخْت were, and the ibn that stands in the middle of names English already knows
Introduced in Chapter 35.

إلى الغد *ilā l-ghad*

see you tomorrow — literally ‘until tomorrow’, reusing the same ilā (‘until’) already met in see you later
Introduced in Chapter 24.

إلى اللقاء *ilā l-liqāʾ*

see you — literally ‘until the meeting’, the structure Spanish borrowed a word for
Introduced in Chapter 4.

جار *jār*

“neighbour” — the person you introduce most often, built on a hollow root whose middle letter hides exactly as qāla’s does
Introduced in Chapter 35.

جاء *jāʾa*

“he came” — the partner of dhahaba, and the first root whose middle letter is weak enough to vanish, showing that even Arabic’s irregularities are patterned
Introduced in Chapter 28.

جين *jubn*

“cheese” — and an honest limit on the root system, because the very same three letters also spell cowardice and the two are not one idea
Introduced in Chapter 34.

كِرَرِ فَضْلِكَ مِنْ *karrir min fadlik*

say it again, please — the second half of a repair kit whose first half arrived four chapters ago, and the first command this book has ever given

Introduced in Chapter 41.

كَتَبَ *kataba*

“he wrote” — the chapter’s payoff, where one root and the patterns you already own hand you a book, a writer, an office and a library with nothing new to memorise

Introduced in Chapter 31.

كَيْفَ *kayfa*

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

كَيْفَ هَالِكٌ؟ *kayfa ḥāluka / kayfa ḥāluki*

how are you? — literally ‘how [is] your state?’, gendered -ka / -ki

Introduced in Chapter 3.

كُوبَ *kūb*

“a cup” — the word that opens Arabic’s broken plural, where more than one is not made by adding anything but by re-pouring the word into a new shape

Introduced in Chapter 36.

لَا أَفْهَمُ *lā afham*

I do not understand — the one hole in an otherwise strong repair kit, one present-tense form away since chapter thirty-one

Introduced in Chapter 37.

لَحْمَ *lahm*

“meat” — one Semitic root that Arabic settled on meat and Hebrew settled on bread, with Bethlehem sitting on the seam between them

Introduced in Chapter 34.

لَكِنْ *lākin*

but — the first word in this book that can set one clause against another, and three letters the reader has owned since chapter two

Introduced in Chapter 38.

لَيْسَ *laysa*

is not — the denial of the nominal sentence, which is the one thing this book teaches productively and could not deny

Introduced in Chapter 39.

لِأَنَّ *li-anna*

because — the answer to the question the lesson before taught, and the same ل with a complementiser behind it

Introduced in Chapter 40.

لِمَاذَا *limādhā?*

why — the question this book has never been able to ask, built out of the preposition ل and the word for “what”

Introduced in Chapter 40.

marḥaban

hello / welcome — there is room for you

Introduced in Chapter 1.

مع *ma^ca*

with

Introduced in Chapter 4.

مع السلامة *ma^ca s-salāma*

goodbye — literally ‘with safety’, closing the greeting arc on the root that opened it

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ملح *milḥ*

“salt” — a plain Semitic word whose root also gives Arabic its sailor and its word for handsome, and which shows ḥā³ in its final shape

Introduced in Chapter 34.

ملعقة *mil^caqa*

“a spoon” — the closing payoff, where the mi- tool shape stands beside the ma- place shape you already own, and where sound and broken plurals finally sort themselves out

Introduced in Chapter 36.

قهوة *qahwa*

“coffee” — the chapter’s payoff, where the tied tā³ finally earns its keep as Arabic’s visible gender marker, and where you can order everything the chapter taught

Introduced in Chapter 33.

قال *qāla*

“he said” — the letter qāf finally named, and one root that yields a saying, an article, a speaker and a spoken thing

Introduced in Chapter 29.

قرأ *qara³a*

“he read, he recited” — hamza’s three seats sorted out at last, and the one root in this chapter that really did give English a word

Introduced in Chapter 31.

رأى *ra³ā*

“he saw” — the dotless alif maqṣūra named at last, and a root whose seeing turns into opinion and into the word for a mirror

Introduced in Chapter 29.

صديق *ṣadīq*

“friend” — the chapter’s payoff, where a root meaning truth explains the word, the fa^cīl pattern turns up for the third time, and every family word you own lines up behind it

Introduced in Chapter 35.

salām

peace / hello

Introduced in Chapter 1.

سأل *saʿala*

“he asked” — one root that builds a question, a problem, an asker and the word for being answerable, plus the Hebrew twin hiding inside the name Saul

Introduced in Chapter 31.

ساعد *sāʿada*

“he helped” — a root that means good fortune, stretched by one long vowel into a verb aimed at somebody else, and the family name behind the word Saudi

Introduced in Chapter 32.

شاي *shāy*

“tea” — the first noun in this book with no Arabic root at all, and a word that reached Arabic and English from the same Chinese original by two different roads

Introduced in Chapter 33.

سكر *sukkar*

“sugar” — a word that crossed Asia and Europe, and the one that shows Arabic’s own al- fused onto the front of a Spanish noun

Introduced in Chapter 33.

طبق *ṭabaq*

“a plate” — a second broken plural in the very same shape as akwāb, which turns a surprise into a pattern, and a root whose other child is a storey of a building

Introduced in Chapter 36.

طعام *ṭaʿām*

“food” — the chapter’s payoff, where a root you have never met hands you the word for restaurant free of charge, because you already own the pattern

Introduced in Chapter 34.

خير على تصيح *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*

“good night” — but honestly, it doesn’t wish you a good NIGHT at all; it wishes you a good morning, reusing both roots from ṣabāḥ al-khayr and masāʾ al-khayr

Introduced in Chapter 27.

و *wa-*

and — the commonest word in written Arabic, glossed once in chapter one inside a fixed reply and taught never

Introduced in Chapter 38.

زيت *zayt*

“oil” — one new letter that is only rā wearing a dot, and a second Spanish word carrying Arabic’s article welded to its front

Introduced in Chapter 36.

أحبّ *ʾaḥabba*

“he loved” — the chapter’s payoff, closing the ladder of four verb shapes, and the root behind the ḥabībī of every second Arabic song

Introduced in Chapter 32.

أخذ ^ʾ*akhadha*

“he took” — the last plain-shaped verb in the book, kept as the control against the three rebuilt verbs that follow, with a Hebrew twin reached by two regular consonant swaps

Introduced in Chapter 32.

عرف ^ʿ*araḥa*

“he knew, he recognised” — one of Arabic’s two words for knowing, whose root reached Spain and named a palace in Granada

Introduced in Chapter 30.

أم أب

father and mother — ancient Semitic roots, cousins of Hebrew’s own family words

Introduced in Chapter 10.

عشرون — عشر أحد

11-15, plain “X-and-ten” compounds — then twenty, NOT “two-ten” but its OWN plural form of “ten”

Introduced in Chapter 20.

أزرق أحمر

red and blue — the same gendered color template as black and white

Introduced in Chapter 9.

أخت أخ

brother and sister — one shared Semitic root, gendered by a single added letter

Introduced in Chapter 10.

أصفر, أخضر

green and yellow — akhdar’s root also gives “vegetables” (echoing English’s own “greens”), and asfar shares its root with sifr, “zero” — the very word behind English “zero” and “cipher”

Introduced in Chapter 22.

آسفة / آسف

sorry (āsif masc. / āsifa fem. — a GENDERED adjective, from asifa “to grieve, regret”)

Introduced in Chapter 7.

اسم

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

... اسمي

my name is... (with no “is”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

أبيض أسود

black and white — color adjectives that change shape with gender, more than “sorry” did

Introduced in Chapter 9.

ال

the (al- — the attached article)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

الخميس الأربعاء الثلاثاء الإثنين الأحد

Sunday–Thursday — Arabic counts its weekdays instead of naming them for planets

Introduced in Chapter 8.

السبت الجمعة

Friday and Saturday — the two days that break the counting pattern

Introduced in Chapter 8.

الساعة

hour / o'clock — and the same word Arabic uses for “clock” and “a while”

Introduced in Chapter 16.

الطقس

weather — the SAME root also gives “rite, religious ceremony”; hot/cold are verbless adjectives, but rain gets its own personal verb

Introduced in Chapter 18.

الليل منتصف الظهر

noon (also the name of the midday Islamic prayer) and midnight (“the half of the night”)

Introduced in Chapter 15.

أنت

you (anta m. / anti f.)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

تشرفنا

pleased to meet you (literally “we have been honoured”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

رأس

the head — a Semitic root cognate with Hebrew rosh, and the source of “president” in Arabic itself

Introduced in Chapter 11.

شتاء خريف صيف ربيع

the four seasons — Modern Standard Arabic’s set, though the classical calendar didn’t always carve up the year this way

Introduced in Chapter 12.

شكرا

thank you (shukran)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

الخير صباح

good morning (ṣabāḥ al-khayr — “morning of goodness”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

عفوًا

“you’re welcome” (also “excuse me/pardon/sorry,” depending on context) — root ʿ-f-w, “to erase, to pardon”; grammatically the same construction as shukran itself
Introduced in Chapter 23.

قط, كلب

dog and cat — kalb is a solid, well-attested Semitic root (cousin of Hebrew’s own dog-word), unlike the tangled dog-words of Spanish, Hindi, and English; qitt most likely closes the loop, widely compared to the SAME ancient root behind Latin’s cattus/gato/chat/Katze, though the exact relationship is still debated
Introduced in Chapter 21.

عمرک؟ کم

how old are you? — literally “how much [is] your lifetime?”; age as a NOUN you possess, not a verb you conjugate
Introduced in Chapter 17.

لا

no (lā)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

لیل

“night” — the word already hiding inside muntaṣaf al-layl (‘midnight’), and yawm’s pan-Semitic partner, cognate with Hebrew layla
Introduced in Chapter 26.

ما

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

اسمک؟ ما

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

خبز ماء

water and bread — one of Arabic’s most irregular common words, and one built on a clean, ordinary Semitic root
Introduced in Chapter 13.

الخير مساء

good evening (masāʾ al-khayr — “evening of goodness”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

فضلك من

please (min faḍlik — literally “from your grace”)

Introduced in Chapter 6.

نعم

yes (naʿam)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

خمسة أربعة ثلاثة اثنان واحد

one through five — the Arabic WORDS for numbers, genuinely different from “Arabic numerals” (the written digit shapes 0-9), which actually trace back to India

Introduced in Chapter 19.

ي

my (possessive suffix -ī)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

يد

the hand — an ancient Semitic root, nearly unchanged since its Hebrew cousin

Introduced in Chapter 11.

ديسمبر نوفمبر أكتوبر سبتمبر أغسطس يوليو يونيو مايو أبريل مارس فبراير يناير

the Gregorian months — Latin names borrowed almost intact, running ALONGSIDE the Islamic calendar’s own, entirely different lunar months

Introduced in Chapter 14.

يوم

day” — a true pan-Semitic word, cognate with Hebrew yom (as in Yom Kippur), and possibly tracing all the way back to an ancient word for “sun

Introduced in Chapter 25.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 3

3.1 ح، خ، ج — *the dots trick, on a brand-new body*

Where is the dot on خ?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 3

3.1 ،ح ،خ ح — *the dots trick, on a brand-new body*

Answer: above

Also accepted: one above; above the body

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

0–9

11-15, plain “X-and-ten” compounds — then twenty, NOT “two-ten” but its OWN plural form of “ten” عشرون — عشر أحد
Chapter 20, p. 103

A

“a cup” — the word that opens Arabic’s broken plural, where more than one is not made by adding anything but by re-pouring the word into a new shape كوب (kūb)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 171

“a plate” — a second broken plural in the very same shape as akwāb, which turns a surprise into a pattern, and a root whose other child is a storey of a building طبق (ṭabaq)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 171

“a spoon” — the closing payoff, where the mi- tool shape stands beside the ma- place shape you already own, and where sound and broken plurals finally sort themselves out ملعقة (mil^caqa)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 171

all right, fine, very well — the backchannel this track had no word for, and the first way a learner can agree with

somebody حسناً (ḥasanan)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 38, p. 183

and — the commonest word in written Arabic, glossed once in chapter one inside a fixed reply and taught never و (wa-)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 183

***as-salāmu ʿalaykum* — hear, write, repair**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

Asking for a Drink

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 149

Asking for Food

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 157

Asking Someone’s Age

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 97

B

because — the answer to the question the lesson before taught,

and the same لَئِنْ (li-anna) with a complementiser behind it

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 40, p. 199

black and white — color adjectives that change shape with

gender, more than “sorry” did أبيض أسود

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 9, p. 71

brother and sister — one shared Semitic root, gendered by a

single added letter أخت أخ

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 10, p. 75

but — the first word in this book that can set one clause against

another, and three letters the reader has owned since chapter

two لكن (lākin)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 183

C

Calling Somebody, and Asking Again

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 205

“cheese” — and an honest limit on the root system, because the

very same three letters also spell cowardice and the two are not

one idea جبن (jubn)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 157

“coffee” — the chapter’s payoff, where the tied tāʾ finally earns

its keep as Arabic’s visible gender marker, and where you can

order everything the chapter taught قهوة (qahwa)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 149

Cups, Plates, and More Than One

chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 171

D

Day

chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 113

day” — a true pan-Semitic word, cognate with Hebrew yom (as in Yom Kippur), and possibly tracing all the way back to an ancient word for ”sun **يوم**

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 25, p. 113

Days of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 67

Denying, and Asking

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 191

Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 105

dog and cat — kalb is a solid, well-attested Semitic root (cousin of Hebrew’s own dog-word), unlike the tangled dog-words of Spanish, Hindi, and English; qitt most likely closes the loop, widely compared to the SAME ancient root behind Latin’s cattus/gato/chat/Katze, though the exact relationship is still debated **قط, كلب**

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 21, p. 105

F

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 75

Farewells

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 45

father and mother — ancient Semitic roots, cousins of Hebrew’s own family words **أُم أَب**

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 75

“food” — the chapter’s payoff, where a root you have never met hands you the word for restaurant free of charge, because you already own the pattern **طعام** (ṭa^cām)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 157

Four Core Colours

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 71

Friday and Saturday — the two days that break the counting

pattern **السبت الجمعة**

Chapter 8, p. 67

“friend” — the chapter’s payoff, where a root meaning truth explains the word, the faʿīl pattern turns up for the third time, and every family word you own lines up behind it صديق (ṣadīq)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 165

G

Going and Coming

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 121

good evening (masāʾ al-khayr — “evening of goodness”) الخير مساء
explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

good morning (ṣabāḥ al-khayr — “morning of goodness”) صباح الخير

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

Good Night

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 117

“good night” — but honestly, it doesn’t wish you a good NIGHT at all; it wishes you a good morning, reusing both roots from ṣabāḥ al-khayr and masāʾ al-khayr خير على تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr)
explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 27, p. 117

goodbye — literally ‘with safety’, closing the greeting arc on the root that opened it السلامة مع (maʿa s-salāma)

Chapter 4, p. 45

Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 107

green and yellow — akhdar’s root also gives “vegetables” (echoing English’s own “greens”), and asfar shares its root with sifr, “zero” — the very word behind English “zero” and “cipher” أخضر, أصفر

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 22, p. 107

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

“he asked” — one root that builds a question, a problem, an asker and the word for being answerable, plus the Hebrew twin hiding inside the name Saul سأل (saʾala)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 31, p. 133

“he ate” — no new letters, no English cousin, and a Hebrew twin close enough to hear; the sixth verb, closing the set أكل (akala)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 30, p. 129

“he came” — the partner of dhahaba, and the first root whose middle letter is weak enough to vanish, showing that even

Arabic’s irregularities are patterned جاء (jāʿa)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 28, p. 121

“he helped” — a root that means good fortune, stretched by one long vowel into a verb aimed at somebody else, and the family name behind the word Saudi ساعد (sāʿada)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 141

“he knew, he recognised” — one of Arabic’s two words for knowing, whose root reached Spain and named a palace in Granada عرف (ʿarafa)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 30, p. 129

“he loved” — the chapter’s payoff, closing the ladder of four verb shapes, and the root behind the ḥabībī of every second Arabic song أحبّ (ʾaḥabba)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 141

“he read, he recited” — hamza’s three seats sorted out at last, and the one root in this chapter that really did give English a word قرأ (qaraʾa)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 31, p. 133

“he said” — the letter qāf finally named, and one root that yields a saying, an article, a speaker and a spoken thing قال (qāla)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 29, p. 125

“he saw” — the dotless alif maqṣūra named at last, and a root whose seeing turns into opinion and into the word for a mirror رأى (raʾā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 29, p. 125

“he thought” — the first verb that is not a bare root at all, but a root rebuilt by doubling its middle letter, and the mu- doer that comes with the rebuild فكر (fakkara)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 141

“he took” — the last plain-shaped verb in the book, kept as the control against the three rebuilt verbs that follow, with a Hebrew twin reached by two regular consonant swaps أخذ (ʾakhadha)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 141

“he understood” — the first verb whose middle vowel is not an a, marking it a state rather than a deed, and the done-to shape that turns it into the word for a concept فهم (fahima)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 31, p. 133

he went — the track’s first verb, and the clearest possible view of the root-and-pattern engine, since the same three consonants also give “gold” and ”a school of law ذهب (dhahaba)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 28, p. 121

“he wrote” — the chapter’s payoff, where one root and the patterns you already own hand you a book, a writer, an office and a library with nothing new to memorise كتب (kataba)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 31, p. 133

Head and Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 79

hello / welcome — there is room for you marḥaban

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

hour / o’clock — and the same word Arabic uses for “clock” and “a while” الساعة

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 16, p. 93

how كيف (kayfa)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 31

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 31

how are you? — literally ‘how [is] your state?’, gendered -ka / -ki حالك؟ كيف (kayfa ḥāluka / kayfa ḥāluki)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 3, p. 31

how old are you? — literally “how much [is] your lifetime?”; age as a NOUN you possess, not a verb you conjugate عمرك؟ كم

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 17, p. 97

I

I do not understand — the one hole in an otherwise strong repair kit, one present-tense form away since chapter

thirty-one أفهم لا (lā afham)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 37, p. 179

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 17

is not — the denial of the nominal sentence, which is the one thing this book teaches productively and could not

deny ليس (laysa)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 191

K

Knowing and Eating

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 129

M

“meat” — one Semitic root that Arabic settled on meat and Hebrew settled on bread, with Bethlehem sitting on the seam between them لحم (laḥm)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 157

“milk” — the opposite case to shāy: a home-grown noun sitting straight on the verb for milking, and a Hebrew twin that is the same word حلب (ḥalīb)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 149

Months

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 87

my name is... (with no “is”) اسمي ...

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 17

my (possessive suffix -ī) ي

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

N

name اسم

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

“neighbour” — the person you introduce most often, built on a hollow root whose middle letter hides exactly as qāla’s

does جار (jār)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 165

Night

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 115

“night” — the word already hiding inside muntaṣaf al-layl (‘midnight’), and yawm’s pan-Semitic partner, cognate with Hebrew layla ليل

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 26, p. 115

no (lā) لا

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 5, p. 59

noon (also the name of the midday Islamic prayer) and midnight (“the half of the night”) الليل منتصف الظهر

Chapter 15, p. 91

Noon and Midnight

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 91

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 103

Numbers One to Five

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 101

O

“oil” — one new letter that is only *rā* wearing a dot, and a second Spanish word carrying Arabic’s article welded to its front زيت (zayt)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 171

one through five — the Arabic WORDS for numbers, genuinely different from “Arabic numerals” (the written digit shapes 0-9), which actually trace back to India خمسة أربعة ثلاثة اثنان واحد

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 19, p. 101

or — two letters, and the word an offer cannot be made without أو (aw)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 183

P

peace be upon you *as-salāmu ʿalaykum*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 1, p. 1

peace / hello *salām*

explicit focus: pronunciation, writing, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Please

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 63

please (min faḍlik — literally “from your grace”) فضلك من

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 6, p. 63

pleased to meet you (literally “we have been honoured”) تشرفنا

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

praise be to God — the everyday answer to ‘how are you?’ الحمد لله (al-ḥamdu lillāh)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 31

R

red and blue — the same gendered color template as black and white أزرق أحمر

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 9, p. 71

S

“salt” — a plain Semitic word whose root also gives Arabic its sailor and its word for handsome, and which shows ḥāʾ in its final shape ملح (milḥ)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 157

say it again, please — the second half of a repair kit whose first half arrived four chapters ago, and the first command this book has ever given كَرَّرَ فَضْلَكَ مِنْ كَرَّرَ (karrir min faḍlik)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 41, p. 205

Saying and Seeing

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 125

Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 83

see you — literally ‘until the meeting’, the structure Spanish borrowed a word for إِلَى الْلِقَاءِ (ilā l-liqāʾ)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 45

See You Tomorrow

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 111

see you tomorrow — literally ‘until tomorrow’, reusing the same ilā (‘until’) already met in see you later إِلَى الْغَدِ (ilā l-ghad)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 24, p. 111

son and daughter — one pair gendered by a single added ت, exactly as أَخ and أُخْت were, and the ibn that stands in the middle of names English already knows بِنْتُ ابْنٍ (ibn, bint)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 165

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 65

sorry (āsif masc. / āsifa fem. — a GENDERED adjective, from asifa “to grieve, regret”) آسَفَ / آسِفَةٌ

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 7, p. 65

state, condition — the thing Arabic actually asks about حَال (ḥāl)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 31

◌ْ◌◌ — **stop, double, or add -an**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 17

“sugar” — a word that crossed Asia and Europe, and the one that shows Arabic’s own al- fused onto the front of a Spanish noun سَكَّرَ (sukkar)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 149

Sunday–Thursday — Arabic counts its weekdays instead of naming them for planets الْخَمِيسَ الْأَرْبَعَاءَ الْثَلَاثَاءَ الْإِثْنَيْنِ الْأَحَدَ

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 8, p. 67

T

Taking, Thinking, Helping, Loving

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 141

“tea” — the first noun in this book with no Arabic root at all, and a word that reached Arabic and English from the same Chinese original by two different roads شاي (shāy)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 149

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 93

thank you (shukran) شكرا

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

the (al- — the attached article) ال

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

the four seasons — Modern Standard Arabic’s set, though the classical calendar didn’t always carve up the year this way ربيع

شتاء خريف صيف

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 12, p. 83

the Gregorian months — Latin names borrowed almost intact, running ALONGSIDE the Islamic calendar’s own, entirely different lunar months أغسطس يوليو يونيو مايو أبريل مارس فبراير يناير

ديسمبر نوفمبر أكتوبر سبتمبر

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 14, p. 87

the hand — an ancient Semitic root, nearly unchanged since its Hebrew cousin يد

Chapter 11, p. 79

the head — a Semitic root cognate with Hebrew rosh, and the source of “president” in Arabic itself رأس

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 79

The People You Introduce

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 165

the safety — Chapter 1’s salām, plus a pattern and a feminine ending السلامة (as-salāma)

Chapter 4, p. 45

َ ُ ِ — the short vowels the abjad usually hides

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 17

The Tense That Was Missing

chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 179

Two at Once

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 183

U

Understanding, Reading, Writing

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 133

W

Water and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 85

water and bread — one of Arabic’s most irregular common words, and one built on a clean, ordinary Semitic root خبز ماء
Chapter 13, p. 85

Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 99

weather — the SAME root also gives “rite, religious ceremony”; hot/cold are verbless adjectives, but rain gets its own personal verb الطقس

Chapter 18, p. 99

well, fine — literally ‘in goodness’ بخير (bi-khayr)

Chapter 3, p. 31

what ما

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

what’s your name? اسمك؟ ما

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 17

when — the clause joiner that puts one event beside another in time, with the same ما inside it the last chapter taught

twice حينما (ḥīnamā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 40, p. 199

Why, That, and When

chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 199

why — the question this book has never been able to ask, built out of the preposition ل and the word for “what” لماذا؟ (limādhā?)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 40, p. 199

with مع (ma‘a)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 45

Y

Yes and No

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 59

yes (na‘am) نعم

Chapter 5, p. 59

you (anta m. / anti f.) أنت

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

You’re Welcome

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 109

“you’re welcome” (also “excuse me/pardon/sorry,” depending on context) — root ʿ-f-w, “to erase, to pardon”; grammatically the same construction as shukran itself عفو
 explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 23, p. 109

Other

ء and أ — the glottal catch

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 17

ا and م — finish سلام without a cliff

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

أكتب (aktub) — the tense that was missing

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 37, p. 179

أَنَّ (anna) — that

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 40, p. 199

ب ت ث — one bowl, three dot choices

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

ج خ ح — the dots trick, on a brand-new body

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 31

بخير and خير — writing “good,” and how you say you’re well

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 31

ر and ح — two shapes inside marḥaban

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 1, p. 1

س and ل — recall one shape, add one

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

ع and ي — open ʿalaykum gently

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 1, p. 1

ع (ʿayn) — the eye that became an O

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 45

ك and ر — an angular k, and an r that won’t hold hands

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 31

ك and و — complete the greeting after the sound

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

لا ... ولا ... — neither, nor

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 39, p. 191

ما (mā) — did not

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 191

مع السلامة — the goodbye, and a word you already know

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 45

ث ت ن — one bowl, four dot-patterns

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 17

ه and ة — the loop, and the ending that means “feminine”

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 45

هل (hal) — **a question is coming**

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 39, p. 191

ي (yāʾ) — **the last dot-letter, and “my name”**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 17

يا (yā) — **calling somebody**

grammar topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 41, p. 205